

Rel 320 Symbolism and Christianity

Numbered Transcript

REL 320 • Jonathan Pageau

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Lecture 1: Symbolic Unities

At a glance — Pageau begins an 'adventure of meaning,' proposing that symbolism is a coherent way of seeing — introducing symbolic unities that structure how we perceive the world.

- 1.1 Hello, everyone. I'm going to take you on, hopefully, on an adventure. Maybe we can call it an adventure of meaning. But I'm going to try to propose to you today that, opposite from the idea that the world is lacking meaning, or that the world is just random, that in fact the world is full of meaning and that the world is actually—meaning is inevitable, that it is impossible to avoid it, and that actually meaning infuses everything that you do, from the smallest action up to the greatest plan.
- 1.2 So it's going to take a while for you to kind of get on this journey because we're so infused with this way of thinking, where we have this idea that meaning is superimposed on things. You know, it's like things are meaningless, but then we kind of force meaning on top of them. I'm hoping I'm going to bring you along a path to help you show that that's not how it works and that is inevitable. And on this path, I hope to give you a few keys at understanding first the way that our lives lay themselves out, the way that we bind to the things that we care about, family, nation, stories, religious affiliations as well.
- 1.3 And the word I'm going to use is symbolism. That's the word that I use to talk about this. And already, you're going to have to do a bit of an effort in your mind because when we think of symbolism, we often think of the little man or the woman in the lavatory, or let's say something which arbitrarily represents something else. But the way that I'm going to talk to you about symbolism, that's not what we're going to look at. The word symbol, it comes from Greek, and it means to throw things together.
- 1.4 And in some of its uses, you find that term used properly the way that I want to bring it to you. So for example, in the Christian tradition, we talk about the symbol of the Apostles. The symbol of the Apostles is basically the Creed. Imagine Christianity is a whole bunch of things. It's a bunch of texts, it's a bunch of traditions, a bunch of way of doing things. And there's all these—and though you're like, "Well, how, what is it? What is this thing?" So what the people did is they picked the most important aspects of the faith, they gathered them together, and then they come up with something like the Creed.
- 1.5 So what I'm going to suggest to you is, that is what symbolism is. It is the manner in which things are gathered together towards a unifying meaning, unifying purpose. And what's interesting is that there's the word symbol, which means to gather together, to throw together things, and then there's the word diabolical, which is the opposite of that. So diabolical means to rip things apart, to break things apart. Already, that's an interesting way of understanding what it is that nihilism tends to do to us. It tends to fragment the meaning in our lives and break them apart.

- 1.6 First way to get to symbolism for secular people and for normal people is to think of just the way that our attention works. And here we're going to dive into something that is called phenomenology, which is, we're used to rationalist thinking, we're used to scientific thinking, where we have a sense in which what is real are these descriptions of material objects. What's real is when I give you the formula for water. What is real is when I describe some giant star so far away, and here is how it works, here are the chemicals. But the thing is, that's not the first point of where our experience lies.
- 1.7 Scientific descriptions are actually abstractions. Nobody here experiences H₂O. You do not experience H₂O. You experience wet, cold, refreshing, right? That's what—drowning, maybe—that's what you experience as water. But H₂O, I'm not saying that H₂O doesn't exist. Of course, H₂O exists. But it is a secondary step. It's not the first step. And that is true of all the phenomena that we encounter. Now, we do these tricky things in our minds, right, and we've been convinced in some ways. You've heard people say that. The sun rising in the morning is an illusion. The sun isn't rising. The Earth is turning. That's the real thing. What you're seeing, what you're experiencing, that's an illusion.
- 1.8 People talk about that all the time. They'll say, "Well, there's the summer solstice, let's say, the shortest day of the year." Well, if you were on Mount Mars, you wouldn't experience it as a summer solstice. You would experience it as just certain cosmic movements of different bodies in the heavens. And so we have to be attentive to the moments where that happens because it happens quite a bit where people will, let's say, alienate us from our experience by pointing to the mechanical causes of the universe.
- 1.9 And so in order to understand symbolism, we have to get back in our body and to realize that, even for the scientist sitting at his desk, looking through a microscope and analyzing the things, the sky is still up and the Earth is still down. And if you don't live that way, you're going to trip and you're going to hurt yourself, right? And so the basic categories of symbolism, the categories that religions use, that stories use, that fairy tales use—these categories are categories of experience. And if people struggle to think that those are more real, what I would ask you to do is at least understand that these are the categories that you exist in.
- 1.10 And if you want to understand stories, if you want to understand religion, if you want to understand why things have these shapes, then you have to dive back into your experience and understand that that's how you go through it. It's like the abstract idea of a mountain on a map that you look at as a geographical point on this map is very different from walking on a path and coming up to a mountain and having to climb that mountain. The climbing of the mountain and the experience of the mountain is your first real—that's your experience of the mountain. That's what gives the mountain identity, OK? So that will be very important to dive into, first of all, for us to be able to understand.

- 1.11** So Martin Heidegger, the German philosopher, was trying to talk about these things. He had this notion of how the world lays itself out for us, how there's an order, there's a manner in which the experience of the world we have has a certain coherence. He had this term called Dasein, which is this unfolding of the world in front of us. He said Dasein is care. And so care is probably the best way to understand the way that meaning unfolds. Let me explain that very simply.
- 1.12** The world in front of you is made out of billions of details. You're aware of that. Anything that I look at, anything that I can identify as having an identity, can be broken down into its parts indefinitely. There's as much detail in the corner of this little table. I could describe this for hours and hours if I wanted to. My big toe has—I could write a 1000-page book on description of all the little details and all the little ridges and all the pores and everything. There's an indefinite amount of detail in the world.
- 1.13** And if we were able to simply be flooded by that detail, in some ways we would be paralyzed. If there was no hierarchy in the way the world laid itself out to us, we would be completely paralyzed. We couldn't be able to tell the difference of what's important and what isn't. You would be stuck. Imagine you're sitting at a table and there's a meal and all you see are just the details of everything. You can't bring it together into one. Why aren't you eating the salt shaker? There's a manner in which the fact that we care about things for our own purposes is the way in which meaning binds together.
- 1.14** So what I'm going to propose to you is that this is inevitable. It is the opposite of arbitrary. Even like I said, the scientist living, sitting at his desk, analyzing things, is still living in that world. It is something like the first world. And so when someone tells you that the sun rising up in the morning is an illusion, well, you still manage your day based on that. Most of us, let's say 90% of us, will still be awake when the sun is out and will still sleep when the sun is gone. That is actually the thing that manages our year.
- 1.15** And it's the same. It's like you could say that winter is arbitrary because it's just the Earth being a little further from the sun, and that's why it's cold, and it's the way it's angled, and it's the way the sun hits the Earth. But it's like, yeah, but still put on a winter coat because you're going to freeze to death. That is the first reality for you, OK? And so this idea of care, what it does is it —foregrounds and backgrounds is a good way to see it. It describes what is relevant.
- 1.16** The cognitive scientist John Vervaeke, who has been very good at giving us technical descriptions, he talks about relevance realization. That is, the way in which you exist, the way in which identity comes together, has to do with relevance. We could go so far as to say that most of the identities that we see only have existence through their relevance. That is, in some ways, consciousness, intelligence, is the place or the manner in which phenomena binds together towards unities. The notion of identity is somehow bound up with what we're doing, which is the capacity for relevance, the capacity to notice what's important and what isn't.

- 1.17 Because without that, what you'll find is you'll find nihilists that will always break things down to their parts. You've probably heard it. It's a trick. It's a good trick. Once you see the trick, you realize that it's pretty simple. Is that if you point to the meaning of something, the more nihilist person will say, "It's just—" and then they'll break it down to its parts. It's like, talk about human civilization. "Oh, we're just a bunch of apes." Talk about human intelligence. "It's just a bunch of chemicals in your brain." "It's just electric currents going through some matter." That's what thoughts are, right?
- 1.18 So this is the problem of breaking things down to their parts. You could keep going. You could just keep breaking things down to their parts because everything's made of parts. You could just keep going down and you could just say, "Everything's a quantum field." You could just say that all the time. You could just say, "Everything's a quantum field. Everything's a quantum field." It's ridiculous. It's ridiculous. We actually see unity in things at all these different levels. This unity of relevance kind of comes together, and this is actually the way the world works.
- 1.19 When we notice meaning, when we notice things coming together and shining in front of us, that's actually how it works. The notion of care, just that might be enough to help you understand something like a church or why religious symbolism works the way it does. Think about when you walk into a bus, imagine this. You walk into a bus, you walk into a subway, and everybody's kind of gray. Because you don't know the people. Everybody's just kind of gray. Then all of a sudden, you see your old buddy from high school. What's going to happen to that person? That person is going to shine. It's going to be brighter, not visually, but in terms of the way in which you perceive them, they're going to pop out, they're going to foreground.
- 1.20 All of a sudden, all these gray people are going to background, and your friend is going to be shining for you. And a materialist might say, "Well, that's just subjective. It's just your subjective experience. It's not real." But everybody recognized that experience, right? So it has a reality. It has a reality which is through our experience, but it's a universal experience. If you open up the cupboard and you see a bunch of cups, and one of the cups is the cup your grandmother gave you before she died, that cup has more relevance.
- 1.21 That relevance is not totally contained in its parts. Your friend from high school is as much an ape or as much a sack of chemicals or as much a whatever you want to describe them as all the others, but for some reason, they pop out and they appear. This is this idea of care. Now, this is an extreme example, but that notion of care as being that which, let's say, drives you to notice unity, it will be as true as when you're walking up to the bus itself. Because as you're walking up to the bus, and the bus stops, and the door opens, there's a million things going on everywhere around you.
- 1.22 There's the wind blowing through the leaves. There's dust on the ground, there's people in the background, there's noise all over the place. But for some reason, you're able to focus. And all of a sudden, the door becomes relevant, the steps become

relevant, and everything is lined up into unity. Those identities pop out. They're brighter in very much the same way that your friend is brighter in the bus. It's a little smaller. It's not as large. You might not notice it as much, but this is what's happening all the time.

1.23 That is how you bind things together. This idea is not just about objects. It's not just—like, the objects are real. This has relevance to me. I don't just see it as a piece of cardboard. This is a clipboard. It's not just a piece of cardboard. The function that it has is binding it towards a higher identity, OK? But that's also true in time. It's not just true about things, it's also true in time. Because as things are happening, like I said, there are billions of things happening simultaneously all the time, everywhere around you. There's an indefinite amount of things happening in this room. But the way we function is that we bind relevant moments or relevant things together, through time, in order to create a cohesive line of functioning, like a cohesive story, we could say.

1.24 And so what stories do is that stories bind events into time into something that we recognize as having identity. That's how you remember something. Because the fact that you remember something is because a sequence of things had relevance to you, and they were able to cohere together, to have one purpose, we could say. And this is really, let's say, this is really something which is, like I said, if you think of the scientist, again, sitting at their desk and identifying their things, that experience is bound into a whole other world, a whole other world where that person gets up in the morning, goes to work, comes back home, and goes to bed. That cycle of experience. Now, that cycle of experience, of just waking up, going on your day, ending the day, and going to bed, that's pretty much the pattern of every single story.

1.25 You've probably heard of the hero's journey. The hero's journey, which is this mythological structure that Joseph Campbell kind of brought out of all these myths—the idea of the hero that is at a certain stasis and then is called to adventure. Something happens, something's pulling him away from his stasis. He goes into this chaotic, kind of messy world where he has to fix things, where he has to kill the monster, where he has to do all this stuff. Then he comes back home and brings the wisdom back to where he was. And it's like he ends the story in a different position, the same position, but transformed.

1.26 You could say, "Wow, yeah, I could recognize that's a story." Like most Disney stories, all these stories have that. But that's how your day is, too. That's how your day functions. You get up in the morning, you're at home, you open the door, you go out into a world that is less stable, that is the world of strangers, the world of surprise and experience. Then you come back home and you bring back the bounty of that. You don't get paid every day, but you do get paid to do that. You do bring back bounty from going out of your house and moving out into the world and bringing back the treasure. That's actually the structure of your day. And it ultimately ends up being the structure of pretty much everything that you will remember in your life. Anything that will have—

- 1.27 So if you—a good example would be, if you go to work and you come back home, and your spouse asked you, "How was your day?", how long are you going to make that story? To talk about turning on the computer, and then "my chair was a little squeaky, and I'm sitting there and it's, like, there's so many pixels in front of me." I could go really into detail if I want to. "I could hear the humming of the hard drive," and like, oh my goodness, your spouse is going to die of boredom if you do that.
- 1.28 This is what I mean about care. When I talk about care, this is what I mean. No, what you're going to, what you're going to do is you're going to synthesize your day and you're going to bring out relevant things that happened during the day, and then you'll compress that into a story. Maybe something in the day represents a little hero's journey for you. You had a problem—oh, surprise problem—something crazy happened, blah, blah, blah. Then we were able to solve it, or maybe we haven't been able to solve it, and I hope we can solve it later. It's like, that's what you're going to tell your spouse. Why? Why is that the story you tell and not reproducing the humming sound of your hard drive? Because care—that's how we remember things, that's how we notice that they even have an identity, OK?
- 1.29 Structure, which is something like the very structure of attention, we could call it. It is not arbitrary. It has a pattern. It has a pattern, and that pattern is true even in the ways that it breaks down. That is, meaninglessness and nihilism is actually part of this bigger pattern, just like the hero's journey, right? The hero has to go out, move into chaos, things kind of break down, things kind of happen to them, things seem like they're falling apart, and then you bring them back together, right? It's every action movie, it's every story that has that flavor to it.
- 1.30 So the world has a pattern. And the pattern is—this pattern is different, but it's not completely different. You'll see why. It's not completely different. It's different from the way that scientists talk about the world. But it is, it precedes it. Science is embedded in this pattern of attention. It has to be. There's no way around it. There are no facts that exist outside of human experience. Now, it doesn't mean that they're arbitrary. It doesn't mean that they're subjective in the weird way we talk about that, where they're idiosyncratic to the person that's finding them. But it does mean that they have to be embedded in human conscious experience.
- 1.31 And so this pattern of human conscious experience is primary. It precedes the technical description of anything. And sadly, in our day, we have in some ways, we've downplayed that. We've mocked things that are based on that structure. But I think that, right now, as we notice the world kind of fraying at the edges and things kind of falling apart, it'll be important for us to recapture that.
- 1.32 And the funny thing about that, it's not that hard to recapture it because it really is your experience. It really is the pattern of your experience. If I say something like, "God is above," and you're like, "Well, that's silly. It's like God's not up there, up on the clouds or somewhere, hanging out with the space station or whatever it is that means."

But it's like, that's actually an abstraction. Like, your experience of above is a real experience. And it can help you understand why even religious stories or whatever have the structure they do.

- 1.33** The idea that hell and death are under the Earth, it's like, if you dig there, you won't find a bit of fire with someone with pitchforks. But if you want to understand those stories, you can understand that, yeah, still, you also can't live underground. Like, really, it's not —if you dig a hole, if I bury you underground, you will die. It's not good. And that's where your body will be eaten, and that's where you will diabolically fall apart, your whole body will disassemble, and you'll be broken down only into the parts that constitute you. It's all very, very coherent.
- 1.34** And that's what we're going to be exploring in this thing. The structures of the stories and the structure of religious practice as is completely coherent, if we're able to dive back into our experience, our just regular, everyday experience. And this is going to be —and I think you're going to get it because I've already mentioned that. So symbolism is not just the way we describe these stories. Symbolism happens. It's not metaphor. It's not allegory. It is the manner in which things come together. And so your life is symbolic. It is necessarily symbolic. There's no way around it. You're stuck with meaning. Because in order to remember something, in order to care for something, in order to do anything that necessitates you to move through all this chaos towards a purpose, will happen through symbolism.
- 1.35** Now, the question will be, why is it that we often don't notice it? Why is it that when I watch a movie, then I can see the symbolism? If I read a religious text or if I go to church, it's like there I can see all the symbolism because it's a hyper experience. And the reason also has to do with attention. It has to do with the idea of binding things together. So think about the way a movie works. Why do we care to watch movies? Why are we interested in watching stories? It's not arbitrary. Let's say, contemporary artists have tried to make movies about anything. Like, they have tried to make movies where they're just, let's say, filming for 3 hours, just like a pond flickering. But very few people are able to muster the care enough to watch a movie like that.
- 1.36** It's actually a deliberate effort to try to break down meaning because it's like, "I'm just going to film the side of a table for an hour, and then I'm going to put that up in a gallery." But yeah, let's just say, people who pretend like they care about that, I'm sorry. Yeah, maybe. But let's say the movies that gather a lot of attention, the movies that really gather people together for them to be excited about the story, those movies need to have a certain type of pattern. And they have to attend to our care. They have to be in line with what it is that humans care about. And if you're able to contract it as much as possible, to create a movie that contains in it, let's say, more of what humans care about, then you will be able to attract their attention.
- 1.37** This doesn't sound weird to you, I hope. The way it works, but it has to do with this contraction because that's what attention does. Attention already will bind multiplicity

together towards one. Like I said, that's the way you remember things. That's the way you know that—that's the way you tell yourself your own story. What a movie does is it'll take the salient aspects that we care about, and then it does a hyper move. Or stories do that. It's like a hyper move, where you have things you care about and attend to and remember in your life, but they're dispersed amongst other things. They're dispersed among other patterns, and they're kind of spread out into our experience. What a story does is it takes those and it smashes them together.

1.38 So you watch a movie about a love story. We all have our love stories, but your love story is interspersed with other things. You go to work every day, you're eating, you're sleeping, you're doing all these other things. Nonetheless, there is a narrative about your love story. What if I took those salient aspects of your love story and I cut out all the other stuff and I just bring it together into a 2-hour line? Then it's like hyper-salient, it's like hyper-care. Because we're recognizing something that is actually the way our lives are made, not maybe explicitly our particular life, but it has enough of that. Something maybe we hope for, something maybe we wish was part of our story, or something maybe we'd be horrified that would be part of our story. But we recognize as something that binds together a line of events that create that hyper sense of care.

1.39 The same thing happens with space. So space also necessarily has to be symbolic. So think about—the best way to understand this would be if you're lost in a forest. If you're lost in a forest, you're actually not in a place. Maybe you can understand it as the difference between space and place. That place has something like care, and space can just be this kind of expansive thing. You're lost in a forest. If you're lost in a forest, you're going to actually experience a breakdown of meaning. You're going to experience a breakdown of symbolism, which is why, in the stories, right, monsters are in the forest. The forest always has that dark ominous aspect to it. It's not arbitrary. It's because if you go into a forest and you get lost in a forest, you will have that experience.

1.40 At some point, you're wandering. You're just going around in circles. There's nothing to distinguish one place from the other. There's nothing to mark the place as having relevance to you. So you don't recognize anything. You're just circling around. It's also helpful that the sun doesn't come in as much, let's say. So it's dark, and you're wandering around. So if you wanted to get out of the forest, what would you have to do, let's say? You would have to find a marker. There's really not much, another way to do it. A good marker is the sun. That's why it's hard when in the forest because if you've got the trees covering, you can't even see the sun. The sun is directional. You know where it rises, you know where it's set. So you could maybe, maybe find a way to do that.

1.41 The best thing would be to find something that's higher than everything else. If you had a tree that was higher than the others, then you could see it above the other trees and you could say, "That's a marker of place, something that will give me a reference point

around which I can try to find. So if I'm moving away from it, I can look back and see that it's up there. If I'm moving towards it, I can look up and see that it's up there." That's how place works.

- 1.42** I'm going to tell you a story from the Bible. You've probably heard this story before, but in this context, you might hear it a little differently. This story is Jacob, right? Patriarch Jacob in Genesis. He's out in the wilderness, and the wilderness is something like the forest. It's the desert. It's the vacant space. It's just this vacant space that doesn't have anything distinguishing it that could attract our care. A source of water, source of food. It's just kind of this space. And so then he comes to a place, and it's not a place yet. It's a night, and he goes to sleep. He goes to sleep. And then in his dream, he sees a ladder, a ladder which goes all the way up to heaven. And on that ladder, he sees angels ascending and descending this ladder.
- 1.43** Then he wakes up and he takes a stone and he lifts it up as a pillar. He takes some oil and he anoints the stone with oil. And he says, "This place is the house of the Lord." All right? And then this will become the place. Traditionally, it becomes also the place of where the Holy Land will end up being. The place where his descendants will assemble and become a people. So first reaction, what a crazy story. This is a completely silly story. Like, what is there stone, pouring oil on the stone? Like, what's happening?
- 1.44** What I want to propose to you is that this is how all place works. All places work like that. In order for something to be a place, it has to be, it has to have an identity. It has to have something which marks it out from the chaos. It's like, "Where do you want to meet?" "I want to meet there," and I'm going to give you a name, and I'm going to give you reference points around it. In order for space to become a place, it has to have a name, and it has to have a reason why it exists.
- 1.45** A good way to, let's say, represent a place, if you want to know where you're going, you don't put street signs on the ground. There's a reason why you don't put street signs on the ground because you can't see them from far, you can't see them around. If you have a street sign, you put it up on a pole. Put it up high, and then you can notice that this is where—this is the street. It has a name, it has reference points. So now we have a place.
- 1.46** So let's say, when Jacob pours oil on the —when he anoints it, it makes it kind of like special. That's the way to understand it. And oil is nice because it's like liquid light. It's a good way to understand oil. You're pouring liquid light onto something and you're saying, "This is special." It's become a center. It's become the center around which my identity will gather. And so, now think about any place, historically, if you know a bit of history, that's almost always how places will be established. And there's no way around that. What do you do? Imagine it's a surveyor, just trying to set up boundaries. What will they have to do? They'll have to post pickets. They'll have to mark the borders, mark the identity of the space.

- 1.47 But think of it in a deeper way. So an explorer comes to a new land. What are they going to do? They're going to plant a flag. Plant a cross. They're going to plant some vertical thing that will rise up above the terrain to help you notice that now this has a name, this has a—this is a place. It's not just random space. The reality is that all places function that way, whether it's your office building, whether it's your house. Purpose-driven, named spaces that have a reason to exist is the only manner that we could recognize place.
- 1.48 And so time functions that way. Space functions that way. Now is where I'm going to try to help you see that science actually functions that way, too. We tend to think that science is just the descriptions of things. It's just an objective description of things. So how does a scientist do his job? The scientist will have a reason why he's looking at things. He has to. He has to have a reason why he's looking at things. Because if he doesn't have a reason, why is he looking at those particular things, right? If I'm trying to study, I don't know, like, mating patterns in frogs, that's the reason why I'm looking at things. And that's the reason why I'm not looking at rocks or at grass or at all the millions of other things that I could look at.
- 1.49 And so I want to study this. I name it. I give it a name. Not only that, but I will propose a theory. I will propose a pattern that I think accounts for the facts, necessarily, because what am I looking at? I don't know what I'm looking at. So I have a theory. I propose a pattern that I think accounts for the facts. And so the theory will direct the types of facts that I'm looking at, once again, necessarily. Then what I'll do is I'll gather data together. Not any data, right? Just the data that is subsumed by the identity of the theory and of the reason why I'm looking at the world in the first place. So I will gather that together. Then I will try to see how these facts connect to this identity. I'm going to see, do the angels go up and down the ladder? Does that happen? Is there a connection between the heaven, the top, the reason, and the Earth, the facts, the details?
- 1.50 If the facts don't fit with my purpose, with the theory that I'm proposing, you won't have a ladder connecting heaven and Earth. The ladder will break down and things will break apart. And if I want to rebuild that ladder, if I want to be able to have a proper ladder that connects heaven and Earth, then I'm going to have to propose a better theory. The facts will help because the facts are questions. They're like, "What is this? What is this? What is this?" Then if I'm able to propose a theory that contains the facts together, then they'll be connected together. Like I said, you'll have angels going up and down the mountain. When I look at—when I use the theory to look at the facts, the facts will make sense. When I look from the facts, but take the facts together and I look up at the theory, the theory accounts for all the facts. That's actually angels moving up and down the ladder. That's how I have now something which makes sense. This makes sense.
- 1.51 Once you understand that, you can see, symbolism precedes —so the scientific method is great. I love it. It's wonderful. It's beautiful. But often what happens with materialists

is that they have a blind spot. There's this weird blind spot where they can't see that they're functioning with this. They forget the theory for some reason. They forget the theory and they think that they're just describing the facts. But without the theory, why are you telling me about mating frogs rather than, I don't know, the different types of grass or whatever? It's all bound together necessarily. And so what happens is this symbolic structure, it restores something like the inevitability of meaning, the inevitability of purpose. That without purpose, you don't even notice anything in the world. You cannot notice things. You cannot care for things. If you cannot see their purpose.

1.52 Now, sometimes the purpose isn't formulated. Sometimes it's intuitive. Sometimes you have an intuition. Sometimes it's even unconscious. But nonetheless, it has to happen. If I'm moving from here to the door to get out, I'm not thinking about it. I'm not thinking, "Well, my purpose is to go to the door, and now I will organize all these facts in accordance to the fact that I want to go there." But it'll happen nonetheless. It'll happen unconsciously, but it will happen. If I need to get out of this room, all of a sudden, these things, this camera, this screen, becomes just obstacles that I need to avoid. That's how they become, in that purpose.

1.53 Now you say, "Are they just obstacles that need to be avoided?" Of course not. Depending on the purpose, they will have different identities. You know that because, let's say, a rock—it can be all kinds of things depending on the purpose. You can use it as a paperweight, but I can also use it as a weapon. The purpose will join the facts together into why it is that I care about it right now. And so you could say, "Well, it's crazy because it feels like now all of a sudden, all the world is falling apart." But those purposes, they're pretty universal. They're not idiosyncratic to you. The idea of using a rock as something to weigh something down or to use a rock as a weapon is a very, very objective category. It's an objective category. It's one which you could probably find universally across all nations.

1.54 And so it's not falling into a flaky or subjective world because sometimes people are afraid of that. They're afraid, well, if we start to see the world this way, then all of a sudden everything becomes kind of shaky. We think that it all depends on your whims, but I'm not proposing that at all. I'm proposing that these patterns and these purposes, they have a reality that is real, and you can see them across different phenomena. The best way to understand this, and this will help you to join a little bit, this kind of symbolic thinking with more ancient thinking, which is that all things are directed towards a good.

1.55 Now it comes almost in—it's weird because it all comes into like a religious way of thinking. But that's really the best way to think about it, is that the reason why things exist, the reason why things exist, is always an identified good. That's why I care about them. I care about them because they manifest for me a good. Now, this good could be very small. If I am standing here and I identify the good of leaving this building for some

reason, then that relative good will bind all the categories together in a certain order, and it will pull me towards the thing. It will pull me towards it. It's a good way to understand it. There's almost like a call of the good.

- 1.56** If I want to have a cup of coffee and I open the door, I look, and the good of the cup will call me because I want some coffee. I'll grab the cup, pour some coffee, and I drink it. And so this idea is that there's a good which draws us towards identity. This is now a really, almost in a metaphysical world. But this scales. So you can understand that different goods exist at different levels. So the best way to understand what I'm talking about is that the symbolic structure, the symbolic way that the world comes together, is something like levels of being. So there's multiplicity, there's a bunch of stuff, that that gets drawn into one, and that one can become a bunch of stuff that is then drawn again into one. Do you understand what I'm saying?
- 1.57** So think about it in terms of your experience. Just a simple ways is that I have in me all these biological processes. I've got blood flowing through my veins. I've got all this stuff going on. But nonetheless, I don't attend to that unless I have to. I don't attend to the blood flowing in my veins unless there's a problem with that. If I get cut, then all of a sudden, the fact that there's blood flowing through my veins becomes—I care about it quite a bit. But usually, I live in a higher good. All this good, which is going on, gets brought together in my experience. I'm moving around, I'm doing things, I'm doing different goods.
- 1.58** You can understand that that good of living my life has to be also bound in an even higher good, which is something like the good of society or the good of the community. Without that, then my individual good —we might have a problem. If I'm just the good for the most of us will bind my individual good, and the good for me will bind the way that I treat my body and the way that I deal with the aspects that constitute me. So you can understand that that scales. And it scales in time in the same way, and then it scales in space the same way.
- 1.59** A good way to think about is a house. A house would be a good way to understand how you have these embedded goods that are together. And so your house is inside a neighborhood. The neighborhood has some kind of identity, not so much in the suburbs anymore. At least in theory, it has some kind of cohesion in their neighborhood. But then your house is kind of made as a multiplicity. Like, there's a hierarchy in your house, the way it's set up. It has to do with this. It's like, think about this image of how the highest and the lowest connect, let's say, in a house.
- 1.60** In a house, you'll have a hierarchy of embedded goods. You'll have on your porch, where all the strangers come, and then you don't know them. It's like the edge of a wall of a city. You've got this porch. People can come, knock on your door, look through the hole, maybe you open it. If it's someone you know, someone looks safe, then maybe you open the door, you talk to them. If it's someone you know a bit, you'll invite them into your entrance, and then you can exchange. If it's more of an acquaintance, they'll

come into the common space of your living room. You can sit with them, you can have drinks.

- 1.61** If they're friends, maybe you'll move now into the space where you eat together, which is more intimate, that has that intimacy. Then you can keep going like that. Usually, you don't let people into your bedroom. Even your friends, they need to have a reason. That's where the most intimate space is, where you share with your spouse, also where you're comfortable to be completely, let's say, unprotected. You can see these layers of protection in the way that a house is made, which is the same structure as a city.
- 1.62** Think of an old fortified city would have a very similar structure, same structure as a church, actually. Maybe we'll look at that a bit later. But this hierarchies of embedded goods is really the way that things come together. So multiplicity into unities, into unities that moves up towards higher and higher goods. That's what you can understand that nihilism is something like just devolving to the parts. So you take something, wanting to devolve it to the parts.
- 1.63** I wanted to read you a tweet by Neil deGrasse Tyson. Neil deGrasse Tyson is one of my favorite guys because he really always has one technique, and his technique is take something that has meaning, devolve it to its parts, and then announce that it's meaningless or that it's random. So this is a recent tweet of his. He said, "To live an affliction-free life, we must confess to nature that we're a sack of chemicals, occasionally or frequently in need of help from other chemicals to live our fullest life." It's interesting, right? It's like, we're a sack of chemicals.
- 1.64** And so he's able to take the way that we experience life, which obviously nobody experiences life as being a sack of chemicals. But he plays a trick on us because if I say, "You're a sack of chemicals," you do a double-take because you're like, "Yeah, wait a minute. I am a sack of chemicals. That's interesting." And so it can almost trick you into thinking that he does have a point, but it can trick you into thinking that what he's saying is more true. That has been the disease of reductionism. It's something that is deeply ingrained in our thinking. We've been convinced from the last decade, I would say maybe a century, that if we can break things into their parts, then we will be able to account for more of reality. This has been the narrative. Narrative is, if we can get down to the lowest part, the lowest of all the parts, then we will be able to explain reality.
- 1.65** And it became so cheeky, right? If you remember when they were looking for the Higgs boson, they said, they called it the God particle. It's this cheeky idea that if we can break everything down to all its elements, then we will come to explain it all. And that's not what happened. And that's actually not how it works. Because one of the problems that the scientists have is what they call the problem of emergence. Is that they can't account for the jump from multiplicity to unity. Just incapable of doing it. And what they do is they just use the word "emergence." They might as well use the word magic

because it's like, "Here's multiplicity. Here's unity. Oh, how did we get there? Well, emergence. It's just emergence. It's an emergent property."

- 1.66** You've heard that people say that. "It's an emergent property of nature." It's like, OK, interesting. Now, that emergent property has a quality to it. It's universal. It has a quality that you can recognize. The problem with the reductionist is that that emergent quality —they act as if it doesn't exist because it can't be quantified. It can't be measured at the level of the lower particles. They just take it for granted. They just say, "emergent property, emergent pattern."
- 1.67** OK, fine. Well, that's the pattern. Let's talk about the patterns. These are the patterns by which we notice unity, by which we exist in unity. So we have to be able to break away from the nihilistic thinking because it infects everything. It's not just a scientific theory. It infects our lives. It infects the idea that we have come to think that the higher purposes are arbitrary, that they sometimes are just images of power, for example. Any constraint from above, any structure, is seen as a form of power. That's just a corollary of the reductionism. The notion, the Marxist ideas, let's say, or the kind of Postmodern ideas, they are extension of something like reductionism, where we don't like to talk about or we find the notion of a giving explanatory power to higher causes, to be annoying.
- 1.68** And so we also don't like to see in top-down patterns anything but arbitrary power. But those top-down patterns, they're inevitable. They're inevitable. And they have to collaborate with, let's say, the multiplicity above. And that's really what the symbolic pattern I'm hoping to show you. So if I put up a pillar and I say, "Here. Place," right now, we're in a moment where people will say, "That is an arbitrary imposition of authoritarian, of colonial, power on the land." You'll hear that quite a bit. It's as deep as that, but then it gets even more. This whole idea that human structures that exist on natural phenomena are something like arbitrary power that is imposed on a so-called natural world or a world of parts which is more real than the world that, let's say, tends to move towards order.
- 1.69** Now, this is a complete illusion. It's a complete illusion because that structure that I tried to show you, that structure of how the one holds the many together, is true at every level of reality. It happens all through, from the way in which, the way in which atoms move to molecules, all the way up to the way in which I can recognize that the United States is one thing. When the United States is not one thing, how can we even see that it's one thing? It's like a billions and billions of things. It's millions of people, it's billions of things, and it's like, why is it one thing?
- 1.70** But it happens at every level. It happens at your level because you are also made of stuff. But you have to understand what is going on. If I say something like, "Your identity is fluid," it's the same thing as the reductionism. You have whims inside you. You have thoughts inside you. You have desires. Those desires are more real than the top-down identity of you being Matthew, son of so and so, in a family. That's arbitrary

power. That's just this arbitrary patriarchal power that comes down from above. But you, these desires and whims that you have inside you, those are that which are real. There's a coherence between the systems. The fact that we are where we are in terms of social narrative, in terms of the way that we understand ourselves, how we connect to others, is a complete corollary to this scientific reductionism, which was the narrative of scientific reductionism that we brought about.

1.71 So the same with the idea of, let's say, just the basic revolutionary idea, the idea that all these people, they have to free themselves from any form of unitary order. It's like, until we free ourselves from unitary order, we will be slaves to the powers. Of course, it doesn't work. That's why revolution always leads to madness and bloodbath and tyranny, because we have to exist in these patterns. That's the first thing we have to notice. We have to be able to notice that. Now, can these top-down structures become excessive? Can they become tyrannical? Of course they can.

1.72 You'll find, we'll talk about it, we'll look at stories, we'll look at examples of where that happens, whether it's religious stories, whether it's fairy tales. You'll see examples of where, let's say, you could say something like, the ladder that connects heaven and Earth has angels going down, only down, and none of them going up. It's like, no, it's just trying to bind the world together. We don't let, let's say, the world respond in a natural way to the order. That's necessarily true. But the first thing we have to be able to do is to notice, at least notice, that this structure of having some kind of name, some kind of authority, some kind of binding agent which binds multiplicity together, is absolutely inevitable. We could not move from here to the door without something like that.

1.73 And if we break that apart, we get to absolute insanity. That's what insanity is. That's what, let's say, breakdown of personality. Multiple voices in your head, screaming at each other, trying to gain power, and not having something which is binding them together. So madness is an example of this breakdown. But it's also death itself. That's what death is. Death is multiplicity. Death is multiplicity. Death is my prime minister. He doesn't get this, and God love him. He says, "Diversity is our strength." That's what Justin Trudeau says. The reality is that diversity alone is decomposition. That's what diversity is. Diversity is death. Now, of course, we need diversity. Of course, we need diversity. But what we need is diversity in unity, obviously. We need them together. There's no way around that.

1.74 So think about, if I only had unity and no diversity, or no attention to diversity, and then I decide that I've got one purpose, I'm going to move from here to the door, and that's all that matters. Then I walk and I just bump into everything and I knock everything over. The diversity will give the flexibility, will bring the flexibility of the purpose. It will, let's say, make it land in reality. So you absolutely need diversity.

1.75 So same thing with establishing a place, for example. Imagine I'm like, I'm going to establish a place. I'm going to make this the new capital of my world. And I walk out

into the Sahara Desert and I'm like, just plant a thing here. And I'm like, this is the place where I'm going to start my new nation. You probably should have paid attention to the diversity of the land because no one's going to go live in the Sahara Desert. It's just not going to happen. And so if you create a place, you will both bring the unity of the fact that we're going to bind together around this, let's say, not chaotic, but let's say potential. But also we have to pay attention to what it is that's there, what it is that's revealing itself in its multiplicity.

- 1.76** So if I'm going to set up a place, I'll ask, is there water nearby? Is there—do we have places where we can grow food or whatever? That diversity is absolutely necessary. You need it. But that's the game. It's a play between unity and diversity. You could understand it like it's just a rhythm of being. It's just a rhythm that will represent the basic rhythm of the pattern—this attending to unity, attending to multiplicity, this moving towards one into unity, but being careful to attend to the multiplicity of the pattern.
- 1.77** It's the same with stories. It's like, good example is the hero's journey. Joseph Campbell pulls out the pattern of the hero's journey. He's like, here's the pattern of the hero's journey. The hero is in his place. He hesitates a few times, goes into chaos, encounters monsters, blah, blah, blah, blah. These are the kinds of characters that help him. Returns to home, brings the bounty back. It's like, I got it. I established the pattern. Then Hollywood people go with it. They take this pattern and then they just try to apply it as coldly and as, let's say, directly as possible. And you just get boring movies. It's just boring. Because the spice, the diversity, is what makes it meaty. It's what makes it fleshy. It's what makes it, what makes it fun.
- 1.78** And so you have to have a real character that is going through things that are coherent, that are exciting, that maybe are a little slippery. They're not exactly in the pattern. It's like that. It's this movement between unity and multiplicity. You kind of have this going. You can think about that like— if you know a Bach fugue is a good way to think about this. In a Bach fugue, Bach will establish the pattern. There's the opening melody. Then what will happen is that melody will start to vary. Then there'll be this variance in the melody. They'll be playing with it. So the melody will start to slip and slide, and you'll still hear it, but it'll move away from itself and come back to itself. Then sometimes in some of the fugues, it goes so far that, at some point, you can't recognize it anymore. It's like we're completely in another world. It's almost disorienting. What is happening? Where are we musically? I can't understand what's going on. It can cause even a little bit of anxiety as you're experiencing it.
- 1.79** Then suddenly, towards the end of the fugue, it's like, oh, wait a minute. You have this glimmer. Then the theme starts to reappear and you're like, oh, the theme is coming back. You don't see it yet. Then finally, it ends with this restating of the theme and it's like, wow, all right. Wow, that was amazing. That was this beautiful journey through change and through transformation, and then back to something that I can recognize.

You wouldn't want a Bach fugue, which would just be the theme repeated over and over for 4 minutes. That would be very boring. Actually, some of our pop songs are kind of like that. It's like verse, chorus, verse, chorus, verse, chorus. Oh, my goodness. It's ver y—those types of songs, that's why they also have a very short life. It's like they grab our attention really fast because they've got a powerful pattern. It's like, they got a beat, something that will really get your attention. Then by next year, it makes you nauseous to hear it. You just don't want to hear it anymore.

- 1.80** But if you listen to Bach, for example, if you listen to more, if you listen to Queen or groups that have brought that complexity and unity together, then it's like, you can listen to Bohemian Rhapsody over and over and you always discover something new and something—but there's still a pattern in that story. It's actually quite patterned, that story. What I want you to get is to understand that this is inevitable. Pay attention to—when you listen to people speaking, you can hear when people fall into this problem, so you pay attention to them.
- 1.81** Sometimes someone will say something like, you try to give something meaning. You try to show something meaning, and someone will use the the word "just." Just is a tripwire. For me, it's a tripwire. When I hear the word just, I'm like, laser focused. There's something going on here. It's just this. The answer to the just is that there is no "just." Anything that you can recognize as having identity is necessarily part of this pattern. Now, if you want to be tricky with me and you want to reduce it to its parts, what it is that I'm pointing to, those parts have the same structure. Let's take the sack of chemicals image. It's like we are a sack of chemicals. A sack is something. It has a purpose. It has a function. You know the difference between a sack and a tree. What's a sack? A sack is something which contains something else. That's a sack. Now, I would say that, even in his own purpose, saying that we're a sack of chemicals is a bit of a problem because what's the sack made of if we're a sack of chemicals? It's made out of chemicals. How can it be a sack of chemicals if we're made out of chemicals?
- 1.82** But what I'm saying, I'm mostly just trying to help you see that every time someone does that, like every time you hear Joe Rogan, God love him, say, "We're just a bunch of apes, clothed apes," right? Something like that. You hear it. It's like, wait a minute, wait a minute, wait a minute. Let's pay attention to that. And pay attention to this desire to reduce things to their constituents. Once you see that, then I'm telling you, you'll never be tricked again by that. Someone says, "The sun is just a flaming ball of gas in the sky." It's like, yeah, well, try to live. If the sun is just a flaming ball of gas in the sky, why don't you just stare at it for a minute and we'll see what happens. Why don't you live as if it doesn't exist? It's like, no. First of all, it's something else. It is the light which manages your world. It is the very clock which creates all of your rhythms of being. That's what the sun is, not a flaming ball of gas in the sky.
- 1.83** It is that. It's also that. But it's clearly not just that. And not only is it not just that, but the meaning that it provides to your life, the rhythm that it provides in giving light to

the world and making things grow, the things you eat, and how it is embedded in every meaning structure that you participate in, can maybe make you understand why people worship the sun. I'm not saying we should worship the sun, but if you were able to understand what the sun is, you might be tempted to worship the sun because, my goodness, like without the sun, everything that has meaning to you vanishes in a second.

1.84 And so that's what I'm hoping to bring all of you on. So today we just did this, let's say, helping you at least get the sense of what it is that we're talking about. And so what I'm going to do in the next session is we're going to look at someone who's mocking meaning a little bit, and then we're going to try to see how it's inevitable, even in the way that it's mocking. Then in the next workshops, I'm going to show you the basic structure. I've already hinted at it. It's heaven and Earth. It's like this connection between the two. What does that look like? Why is it that the culture forms that we have, why are they the way that they are? They are not arbitrary—the way that our cities are set up, the way that religious rituals are set up, the way that civic rituals are set up, all the way down to the rituals that we participate in our homes. And the same for stories.

1.85 All of these things actually have, they actually follow this basic pattern of how something like identity connects to multiplicity, how one and many connect together. To be honest, it's actually the pattern of your attention. Just even the way that you function with your eyes, that's how it works. Your eyes are focused machines. They focus on something. They foreground the thing that you focus on. Out on the edges here, it's something like a detection mechanism. You actually don't see what's out on the edge of your eyes. It's very vague, like black and white, and it's kind of just an alert system. If something appears, moves in the corner of your eye, then you'll shift your attention and you'll try to see if you should care for it.

1.86 So your very attention functions with something like that. Think of it like unity and variability, or like order and chaos on the edge, order in the focus and chaos on the edge of your identity. That'll be enough for this first session. Hope you guys are getting the sense of where I want to bring you, and see where we go from here.

Lecture 2: Hidden Patterns

At a glance — Hidden patterns: drawing on Aristotle and traditional thought, Pageau uncovers the recurring structures beneath appearances.

- 2.1** So I have two questions, if possible. The first one would be something that Aristotle points out in the Nicomachean Ethics, which is that, you know, as you mentioned, everything tends towards a good. Paraphrasing Aristotle, he mentioned that the good is one action that we tend towards a good. But then when we exit that action or that interaction, we go to another one, which tends to another good. So there's a sequence of goods and goods and goods. So practically, my question would be, do all these actions test to a supreme good? And if so, what would that supreme could be?
- 2.2** Yeah, so it's interesting because the, let's say Aristotle has this sense of these goods. But what you see happening in time, you see it in Dante especially, is that Dante takes up that notion. He says, "Everything we do, we do out of love." Basically, it's like everything you do, you do out of love, and you move towards a perceived good. Now, the problem with that, and that has to do with what you're bringing up, is that there are some goods which are relative to other goods. So, for example, right, eating is a good. Obviously, you need to eat in order to survive. But if you're not careful and you make that good, which is good, a supreme good, and you subjugate other goods to it, then you might run into a problem, like you just might start gaining weight, and then you'll just start gaining weight. And it's like, why am I gaining weight? Well, it's because your goods are not properly aligned.
- 2.3** And so when I, you know, I told you a little bit about this idea of this, how multiplicities are bound up in unities, and that's actually true of the, of the goods. And so if you take the idea of every sin in, like, Christian thinking, is something like a misplaced good, something which is good, but if you don't have it in its proper place, if you love it too much, if you love it more than other things which are better than it, then that's what's going to lead you out of control. And so it's actually—and Aristotle will probably agree, you know —evil doesn't have existence in itself, and evil is only a misplaced good is the best way to see that.
- 2.4** And so what is that hierarchy of goods? Exactly. So if it scales, right, if you realize that, let's say, eating is a good, but it has to be subjected to a higher good, right? Which could be something like general, let's say, general health, something like that. But you have that good. But that good is also not great because you know, people that all they do is train. And at some point it's like, what are you doing? Like, what's your life? Will you just spend all day in the gym all the time? You're just training for what exactly? Which are you? I guess maybe because they'll have some higher goods. Maybe they look good or they want to be attractive. But see, you have to have these properly scaled up.

- 2.5 And so some—and so what the Christians, what Dante, for example, will set up is that, in hell, you have these people that are suffering because they were obsessed with a good so much that they made it into something like a god, and they were willing to sacrifice everything. So think about someone who cheats on their spouse. Like, you've got kids, you've got a family, you've got this thing. And the question is, what is the higher good in this situation? And misplacing that, saying, "Well, I'm gonna sacrifice all this for this passion that I have," and you can wreck, like, you can wreck your family, you can wreck your kids, you can wreck all of this because you—and sexual union is a good, but it has to be properly placed.
- 2.6 So what Dante finds is, in hell, people that are obsessed with things that are good, like their appetites or pride, maybe, or you know, all these things that are not bad in themselves. And then it scales. It scales up. How do these good fit into each other? And, you know, and then the Christian mystics will come to—it's a hierarchy, which is that the virtues are something like higher goods. And so if you're able to subject your desires and these different things to virtues, then those will be properly aligned. And so the truth, love, hope, charity, all these things which bind our actions—if you do that, then all of a sudden things scale properly. Like, my life functions well, but I also can exist in my family, right? If I subjugate my own desires to, you know, caring for my family, then all of a sudden, it's not that, like I said, it's not that those desires are wrong, but that they're just embedded properly. And then if we as a family take those virtues as good, then we will be able to fit into society in the right way, etc., etc.
- 2.7 But the question, like you said, is, "How far does this scale up?" How much? How high can you go? And the answer for the Christian mystic would be something like being itself, or the source of being or love. Right? What's love? Love is the coexistence of unity and multiplicity, a good way to describe love. That's what it is. And so if you love something, true love or proper love, you don't want to, you don't want to—if I love someone properly, I don't want to, like, absorb them into myself. I want them to exist separate from me and their existence. And understanding that their existence separate from me is the reason why I can love them, is what makes us now one in our loving relationship.
- 2.8 And so if you understand the notion, like when we say "God is love," this is not just a kind of sentimental statement about God. It's about the notion that love, the proper manner that unity and multiplicity are held together in a balance, that's something like the highest image of reality. The highest image, the thing that we should worship, you could say—the thing that we should all corporately attend to and celebrate, because it's that which binds most of reality together.
- 2.9 And my second question would be, you mentioned the reductionism, which practically is devolving things to its parts, right? And Matthew, your brother, and you had yourself have spoken about this previously, about the material perspective of things. There's been like a fracture in thought thousands of years ago that have seen that we tend to

see things as "what is this thing made up of?" And then, you know, we go back to the basic structure would be and stuff, whereas you guys speak about the "telos", about the purpose of things. My question would be, what's the way back to recover this supernatural view of reality as a whole, meaning us here, the societies in America, or, you know, utopian, speaking like in a utopian, the world.

2.10 Yeah, world. Wow. The world one is tough, but we can start, we can start with the levels. Like, in some ways, you know, Jordan Peterson, I think we totally agree on this line that he has, which is something like, "Start with you," basically, right? Start with you. And then you become like a seed. And then the fruits will —the ripples, let's say, like something thrown into a pond, and the ripples will manifest themselves. And so I think the best thing we can do is to try to recover this way of living for ourselves. Just get back into, first of all, get, just get back into your body. Get back and understand, at least try to live in the normal rhythms of things and try to realize that the things that you engage with that provide meaning are not arbitrary.

2.11 And don't let anybody take that away from you. Don't let anybody tell you that "you could do this, you could do that, it doesn't matter, none of it matters." That's not true. It does matter. And it does—let's say, if you have the proper stance in life and you kind of align yourself, then that will transform your life. And then what happens is that that scales into something like family, for example. So families have a way that they exist. And the rituals of family are not arbitrary. The rituals of family are based on finding the way in which we bind together. And so we're going to talk about it later in the course. But, like, a family meal is a little religious ceremony. It has the same structure as going to church, but it's a lower one. It's not, we don't want to compete with these higher attentions, but nonetheless, it has that pattern.

2.12 So I think that the best way to do it is to—because one of the problems we have, and it's like, I fall into that, everybody falls into that, is to look at the state of the world and go, oh, despair. Like, you know, here comes, I don't know, like, here's the AI machine, like, heading straight at me, and I'm watching, you know, all social fabric, like, break apart and thinking, OK, we're heading towards some kind of apocalypse or whatever. But there's nothing I can do, honestly, about that stuff. What I can do is I can transform my life, and I can transform, and I can participate in the transformation of those around us. And in doing that, we're already rebuilding the right world.

2.13 And so, worst-case scenario—those, those little unities, like those, those well-built unities, will act like an ark, if things continue to fall apart. They will act as something which can carry us through the chaos, but they can also, surprisingly, replenish the world with meaning. And I think that. I do think also that we also need to realize that the things we celebrate, that the manner in which we recognize unity often looks like celebration. It looks like that which we rise up. What do we lift up? And we say, this is something that I want to celebrate. And if we pay attention to that, we can notice what's going on also around us. Like, what is it that we're allowed to celebrate? And

what is it that we're not allowed to celebrate? What religion is coming on the horizon? And once we see it, then we can start to modify in our own lives what it is that we celebrate. And we can see it.

- 2.14** Like a simple example, it's like, you know how people complain that Christmas is becoming just consumerism? And the answer is, yeah, it is kind of happening. You can see an inversion of goods, an inversion of celebration, which is that giving gifts is amazing. Giving gifts is a wonderful tool of cohesion. It's something that is thousands of years old and is like so—it's primordial in terms of connecting ourselves with each other. But it's a good that has to be embedded in higher goods, has to be embedded in celebrating higher things, celebrating their unity as a family, and then ultimately moving into religious, celebrating the story that binds us together with the Christmas story, ultimately moving into worship. That's the structure.
- 2.15** But if we lose the top ones, we start to devolve. And then all of a sudden, it's just about getting stuff. It's just about getting stuff. And then Boxing Day becomes more important than Christmas actually, because that's when I can get the deal. So, you know, and the same, like, Black Friday and Thanksgiving have the same, the same, the same structure. It's super interesting. You kind of see, it's like Thanksgiving flip into Black Friday as showing us what happens, like what is it that we're worshipping.
- 2.16** In the other session, you talked about the word "just" being a tripwire. And so a question for you on this is, you know, if something can be just wrong and what the implications of that would be. Like, I'm thinking of things that would be right now considered criminal, that we would say, "That is just wrong," but something that might have been "just" wrong 50 years ago, like, say, marijuana, people were saying, "Oh, it's just wrong to do that." Now it's legal, and it's normal in our society.
- 2.17** I mean, I think that, often the word "just" hides—"just" hides a blind spot. It hides someone who's not thinking about it, who just takes things for granted. And the worst part, the worst thing about that is, in some ways, in a normal world, most people would have blind spots and it would be fine. Your great-aunt dropped out. You know, they didn't go to high school or whatever. She doesn't have to. She just says, she'll say something about that, like, it's just wrong, and that's fine. Now, the problem is that usually there's a kind of a hierarchy, a moral or intellectual hierarchy, that is able to work out ultimately why something is wrong. But now we have the problem, which is that sentimentalism seems to have just taken over the entire sphere of morality, where we don't even know why, all of a sudden, everybody gets offended about this, which was 50 years ago, weren't offended by, and vice versa. It's like, why are we now—like, this is completely unacceptable, you know?
- 2.18** And it's like, OK, so we in a moment now, where in some ways we have to make more effort to be able to, let's say, show the reasons for things, and in some ways because, because people are so taken up by a kind of blind spot in arbitrary morality, then it will give, make us more forceful if we're able to find the reasons why things should be in

the proper order. But to answer your question about "just" wrong, this is going to sound horrible, but nothing is ever "just" wrong. Everything has its place. And it's always when something is out of place that it's wrong.

- 2.19** So it's like, killing is not just wrong, it's wrong if it's out of place. There are moments when you could kill someone, it would not be wrong. There are moments when you can, where you can—the things that we do, you just have to know what is the right place for it. So the idea that marijuana is "just" wrong, that's a ridiculous statement. People take medicines that are so close to marijuana that it's like, why would marijuana be just wrong? Now, we can argue why it's dangerous, just like other medicines are dangerous, and why it shouldn't be let loose into society, or why it shouldn't be just accepted. That's fine. But when someone says you're just wrong, they're not thinking it out properly. Yeah.
- 2.20** All right, so I guess building on that with, like, the just statement that you made about, specifically, Joe Rogan saying, "We are just apes," right—do you think that that specific type of reductionism can help us with, like, reorienting our perspective maybe towards, like, a different good? So, for example, with Joe Rogan, like, if he's helping people to reframe how they see themselves and maybe they're more likely to exercise as a result, is that helpful?
- 2.21** Yeah, but the thing is—OK, so this would be the way to see. It would be, you have biological processes. You have them; they're definitely part of you. And so you should act at the right level in order to assure that those biological processes function. And that's to say it's something like Joe Rogan. So it's like, yeah, we have bodies, and strength has a reason. Like, there's a reason to be strong. There are reasons to be alert and to have these kinds of reflexes, and therefore, you should train. But when he says something like, if you say, like, "we're just apes," it's like all those things become something like blind spots, right? Where he's not, he's not completely seeing the goods for what they, what they can be.
- 2.22** But then, but that's true. Like, let's say training, for example, physical training. Like, physical training is useful. It's great. But it's definitely not the highest good, right? You know, you can—if you put that as a good that is too high, then it will undo your life, just like anything that you put as too high a good, because it'll take over. It'll start acting like a weird parasite. It'll kind of infect. And it's not just that. It'll infect even your conversations. When people get obsessed with certain things, they get really taken up by certain things at some point, it's like, it just takes over their whole worldview. It's like they see the world through this lens.
- 2.23** It's like, what is the joke about CrossFit? It's like, people just meet someone. It's all they talking —they just talk about CrossFit. It's like, this is just not, this is not, I mean, it's fine, but to do it in a proportion, but then when it starts to take over and, like, it becomes the very framing mechanisms of their lives, then that is, it's something which, if you run for a long time, will at some point start to mess you up. And it's not even

complicated. It's the same for sex, too. It's like, you're gonna die and you're gonna get to a point in your life where all those things, you won't be able to do them anymore. So you better subject them to higher goods because you're gonna end very miserable if, like, your purpose in life is training and physical activity, if your purpose in life, like, highest purpose in life, is sex, and at some point, you're going to run out of that. And so how are you going to end your life if you haven't embedded your goods in the proper manner?

- 2.24** But I'd say if you subjected those goods to higher goods, like community, like family, you know, like loving others, then when you reach that point where those, these goods aren't available anymore, those higher goods are the ones that are going to carry you through. They're the ones that are going to carry you through. And so it's not a moralism. Like, it's not a—it's a very practical, very grounded thing that I'm talking about. If I say love for your neighbor and love for your family and caring for those around you is a higher good than working out, it's not just moralism. It will actually play out in your life that, if you don't focus on those things, you know, your bad hierarchy will send you to hell or to purgatory. You will have that experience when you end up alone and no one cares about you, and you're, you know, you don't have to wait to die for that to happen. It'll happen in your, in your life.
- 2.25** When you mention the story of Jacob raising the stone and anointing, would you say it's possible for us to do the same and raise a stone inside us to reach a better place or a better version of ourselves in the future? Or we are too attached to the, our past experiences and the vision we have of ourselves?
- 2.26** I think so. I think so. But I think it's going to look different. It's going to look a little different from what the modern kind of pop psychology wants it to look like. And so what Jacob is doing is establishing place by appealing to something which transcends it. Right? So think about this, these different levels of unity. So the unity of anything transcends its multiplicity. You understand that it's not, it's not a magical thing. It's not like there's forms floating up in the air somewhere. But it's like, for something to become one, the purpose has to appear as leading it or being beyond its multiple elements. Right? Does that, can you kind of see that? Does that make sense?
- 2.27** And so that is also the way—so if you think about establishing a place, so you have a bunch of stuff, and then you, I don't know, you claim it for the, for the king, right? You claim it for the king. And that, that transcendent aspect, the king, who's not, doesn't, is not there, who is the authority figure which is above giving you reason or capacity to unify things together—it's transcendent at a relative, in a relative way. So there's a relative transcendence, you could say. So, above all multiplicity, there's unity going up.
- 2.28** And so one of the difficulties with modern psychology is that it's all inside. It's all inside you. It's all you. It's all your memories and your things and will and all that. But I really honestly believe that, if you want to lift a pillar in your heart, something like that, if you want to lift up a pillar in your heart, it has to be anointed by something which

transcends you. It has to come from heaven. And people might think that sounds superstitious, but it's really just something which functions at every level of reality. So that's why you will have the types of traditional practices which will, let's say, do that within you, will often be things that look like prayer, right? Things that look like, let's say, meditation, or meditation is similar. It's like, I've got all this noise inside me, all these thoughts, all these things. And so if I want to raise a pillar inside me, I have to reach a place of silence, like a silence that transcends all the voices. Something like that.

- 2.29** But prayer is, prayer is similar. It's like, I call upon something above me to found my identity. And that'll happen fractally too, like, in terms of a person. It'll happen at different levels. And so you can do it relatively for relative causes. So you could say, I'm scattered, I'm messy. So I'm going to join a sports team, and I'm going to give my energy to that sports team. And what that will do is it will raise a relative pillar. It's not—it's a small one, it's kind of relative, but it will. It'll raise a pillar in your heart and will direct your energy and your attention towards a higher purpose and a higher identity. And it'll work. It'll stabilize you. So you could do that with a sports team. People do that with nations, like, do it with nationalism or joining the army, kind of giving yourself, or a cause. You're like, I want to help the poor. I want to do this. I joined this organization that's working to save something. And so I give my body to something above me, beyond me, and that's actually what will hold you together.
- 2.30** If you try to do it just within yourself, it doesn't work. It tends towards nihilism, towards narcissism, sometimes. And then ultimately the question of the goods then comes about. It's like, all right, it works. If I join a sports team, I get this good. I gather my energy together, but that has a limited lifespan, right? It's like, you won't be 75 playing sports. You won't be 75 in the army. So it's like, how can I bind these, this pillar in higher goods that will hold me more stably, like, in a more stable way? Then it might be family, it might be community. But ultimately, that's what religion is.
- 2.31** Religion is saying, "I am going to connect myself to the highest of goods, the highest highest." And what it will do is it should stabilize you at all the levels. So it's something like, if you play a sport, but you also have a good family, your pillar is way more solid. Like, if you play a sport, you've got a good family, and you're in a good community—if you play a sport, you're in a good family, in a community, and you're capable of worshipping the God of love, let's say. Then it's like, man, that pillar is pretty rock solid because you can take the lower things out and the higher things will remain, right?
- 2.32** That's the problem of getting attached to the lower goods. It's like, if I put all my love in my Ferrari, it's like, that Ferrari, if that Ferrari's gone, it's like, what am I doing? So that's, so it's, I think it really is an objective thing, of kind of binding yourself up into these goods. Make sense? All right. And so I think we're going to move on. I wanted to kind of take apart a piece of text that was written by Sam Harris. So Sam Harris wrote—he's very suspicious of meaning, meaning in stories, meaning in things. And so he wrote

a mocking interpretation of a recipe, of a food recipe. So I'm just going to read you his interpretation. Then we're going to try to see how we can reorient what he's saying towards something which would be, which would make sense. All right.

- 2.33** So he complains about people who try to interpret stories and give them higher meanings, like fairy tales or movies or whatever. So he says, "The problem with such hermeneutical efforts is that they're perfectly unconstrained by the context of the text themselves. One can interpret every text in such a way as to yield almost any mystical or occult instruction." He's saying, it's like you're putting meaning into something which isn't there. You're trying to make it mean more than what it actually means.
- 2.34** So he says, a case in point. "I have selected a book at random, this time from the cookbook aisle of a bookstore. The book is *A Taste of Hawaii: New Cooking From the Crossroads of the Pacific*. Therein, I have discovered an as yet uncelebrated mystical treatise. While it appears to be a recipe for wok-seared fish and shrimp cakes with ogo-tomato relish, we need only study its list of ingredients to know that we are in the presence of an unrivaled spiritual intelligence."
- 2.35** So then he goes and he lists the ingredients. He said, "Snapper filet, cubed. 3 teaspoons of chopped scallions. Salt and freshly ground pepper. A dash of cayenne pepper. 2 teaspoons of chopped fresh ginger. 1 teaspoon of minced garlic. 8 shrimp, peeled, deveined, and cubed. Half a cup of heavy cream. 2 eggs, lightly beaten. 3 teaspoons rice wine. 2 cups of bread crumbs. 3 tablespoons of vegetable oil. 2.5 cups of ogo-tomato relish." And so it's interesting because, like—it's interesting because a list of things is really boring. You ever noticed that? It's like, it's very boring. It's actually not a story, but let's go.
- 2.36** So he said, "The snapper filet is, of course, the individual himself—you and I —awash in the sea of existence. But here we find it cubed, which is to say that our situation must be remedied in all three dimensions of body, mind and spirit. 3 teaspoons of chopped scallions further partakes of the cubic symmetry, suggesting that that which we need add to each level of our being by way of antidote comes likewise in equal proportions. The import of the passage is clear. The body, mind and spirit need to be tended to with the same care. Salt and freshly ground black pepper. Here we have the perennial invocation of opposites. The white and the black aspects of our nature, both good and evil, must be understood if we would fulfill the recipe for spiritual life. Nothing, after all, can be excluded from the human experience. That seems to be a tantric text." This is hilarious.
- 2.37** "What is more, salt and pepper comes to us in the form of grains, which is to say that our good and bad qualities are born of the tiniest actions, thus we are not good or evil in general, but only by virtue of innumerable moments which color the stream of our being by force of repetition." I think I'm actually not going to read the whole thing because it's really boring. All right, you get the idea, right? You get the idea.

- 2.38** And so, now let me ask you a question in terms of a recipe. Do you think that recipe is meaningless? Is it possible for a recipe to be meaningless? So what's interesting about a recipe is that it's probably one of the best places to find, like, the deepest meaning in some ways. And the reason why is because a recipe is exactly a manner in which we gather things together and we bring them into unity. That's what we're doing. Let me ask you a question. Do dogs have recipes? No. Are there any animals that have recipes? The answer is no. Dogs eat meat. Animals eat the thing. Animals don't gather things together in unity, not this way. So what's going on? Why do we do that? What is happening when we make a recipe? And it's super interesting because we are actually participating, we're building a little ladder towards heaven when we are making a recipe.
- 2.39** So let's look at some aspects of what it is that we eat. So if we make a recipe—let me ask you a question, first of all. Would you ever eat spice? Just like, you know, just spoonfuls of cayenne pepper, spoonfuls of oregano, like, why? Why not? You know, spices, we can eat spice, right? It's food. Well, you wouldn't eat spice. Seems to have another nature. It actually seems to have another nature. It doesn't seem to be the same as the fish in a recipe. So usually a recipe has an identity. What are you eating? I'm eating chicken. I'm eating fish. I'm eating this. It has an identity. It has something which identifies it, and that will be the most important thing.
- 2.40** And so recipes are hierarchies. They're hierarchies of being necessarily, right? And so there'll be something which will identify, "What am I eating? I'm eating a steak. I'm eating a filet mignon. I'm eating something." You'll just name it—an omelet, whatever. It has a name. And then there will be variability on the edges. So there's variable amounts of ways that I can eat fish. They aren't indefinite. I can't pour motor oil on fish, and if I do that, I'll die. There are several things that I can't do to fish, because if I try to eat them that way, then I'll die. There's a manner in which we bring these elements together towards a kind of unity. And like I said, it'll have a hierarchy, and the hierarchy moves something, like, from identity towards something like idiosyncrasy, because that's some, that's what spice is.
- 2.41** So why do you eat? You eat to sustain your body. But is that the only reason you eat? No. Right. There are other reasons why you eat. What are the other reasons? Pleasure. But not just pleasure, right? There's other reasons why we eat. Like, if you made this—I didn't read you the whole recipe. It's a pretty complicated recipe. Like, why would you make a recipe like that? And most people would probably make a recipe like that if they were meeting with other people. You make a really complicated recipe, usually something that you do together. That, again, that's really interesting, because do animals eat together? Kinda. Kinda fight for the food, maybe a little bit, and maybe leave some food for the other. But the idea of eating together is very particular, very particular to us.

- 2.42 And it has to do, again, with meaning necessarily. It's like we gather together. It's like, why don't we just eat? Just, just, you know, just even if we were, like, several people, we could just eat. We just take something and put it in your mouth. But no, we, we gather these elements together and we have an identity. It's like, say, it's fish, and then we add idiosyncrasy, which is the spice. We add these flavors, which bring a kind of surprise and pleasure and all that stuff. But you can't, like I said, you can't just eat spice, and if you just eat fish, kind of boring. So we have this hierarchy of how the goods participate in each other.
- 2.43 So it's interesting because it really is the hierarchy of goods that we're talking about. So it's like, pleasure is important, but pleasure has to be subjugated towards, let's say, perpetuation of being. Like, the continuation of your being is more important than the pleasure. If you flip it in terms of recipes, you have a problem, right? I mean, everybody knows that. Like, if you just ate candy, for example, like, you would be in trouble very fast. There's an actual hierarchy of how it is that we engage with foods, and then that way of, that way of working then bleeds out into society. It bleeds out into the reason why we make these recipes in the first place. It's not in the recipe, but the reason why we make these recipes is so that, just like what we're doing in the food, we're going to do with each other.
- 2.44 We're going to sit together, we're going to bind together, around a common experience, and then we're going to offer this food to our common experience. It's very religious, by the way. Like, the idea of offering food to a god surprise you so much if you kind of see how that, how this works, how it is that multiplicity comes together. But it's funny because even in some of the things that he says, that he mocks in his, in his, in his description, they're, they're actually, some of them are interesting because he talks about, let's say, salt and pepper. He talks about black and white, salt and pepper, and he kind of mocks that, as if that's not part of how we experience salt and pepper, but it's like, really? We don't experience it that way?
- 2.45 Like, what color is pepper? No, it's not. It's not black. Pepper's not black. What are you talking about? Pepper is all kinds of colors. It's gray, it's brown. Like, there's all kinds of different types of pepper. Why do we think that pepper is black? You know, because it actually does function very much in the way that he talks about it. It's one of those places where we have opposites that we see as opposites and that we kind of understand them as opposites. Like, why is it that on the tables of restaurants there's salt and pepper, and there isn't, like, oregano or basil or whatever? Like, in every restaurant you'll find those two, salt and pepper. What, what's going on?
- 2.46 It's because humans have identified them actually as opposites, whether materially they're opposites—I don't even know what that would mean, materially—but in our experience, we have identified them as two extremes of experience. And if you look at what they are, it's interesting, because what does salt do? Salt increases flavor. And what does pepper do? It causes pain. That's what pepper does. Pepper is pain. So you

actually have pleasure and pain. This is what you're dealing with with salt and pepper. And the effect that pepper has on us is to cause suffering, but it's like a just dosed suffering, just enough of suffering to intensify your experience. Pepper is a little adventure, something like that, right?

2.47 And you know that, right? Because it's actually culturally inscribed that pepper is a little adventure because you have tough guys on YouTube who sit around and will eat chile peppers as a dare to kind of see who can handle the hottest pepper. And so it's actually the idea of what pepper does to us is inscribed in its —the way that it participates, the way that it participates in the food that we eat. So his vision that salt and pepper are opposites, it's pretty good, actually, because I really think that's what it is. I really think that it is about pleasure and pain and two elements that we recognize as opposites. And we place them next to each other and we identify them as black and white, although they're not, because some salt is pink. You have gray salt, all kinds of salt. But if I tell you "what color are salt and pepper?", right away your mind will go to black and white because they identify them as opposites. It's completely coherent.

2.48 Then the last thing, though, about Sam Harris's interpretation, which is very interesting, is that he mocks the recipe by attributing it, attributing to it, all these, like, mystical ideas and this idea of a mystical path. But the question I would ask him is, where does that mystical information come from? Where does he get that? The images he used of the enlightened person of all these things—like, where does that come from? Is it arbitrary? Right? Is it built out of something? It's built out of religious tradition, about something like that? So he seems to know what to say. He seems to know, like, these different qualities of what a mystical person will engage with. And then he uses that to mockingly describe phenomena as if there's no connection between the two.

2.49 But it's like, huh. What if, like the image of enlightenment that he proposes, for example, like the idea that we're, that our purpose in life is to move towards enlightenment—wouldn't it make sense to subjugate our recipes to that? Maybe not as explicitly and as ridiculously the way that he does it, but wouldn't it make sense that we would do that? Wouldn't you have, for example, types of foods for fasting? Right? Types of foods for feasts, and would those be coherent? Right? There'd be a difference between a feast, for example, and a fast? If you're a mystic and you're trying to be ascetical, would there be coherence in the types of foods you eat and the types of recipes you engage with in order to reach your goal? And the answer is, of course. Of course.

2.50 That's why religious traditions have had rules about foods that are very explicit. And the difference between the type of food you eat when you're engaging in spiritual practice, the type of food you eat when you're having, when you're celebrating a wedding, won't be the same. They will have a coherence, and the way you prepare it will also be part of what's going on. So, of course what he's saying is ridiculous. But the deeper thing that he's trying to get to is not ridiculous. The idea that recipes

participate, even in the mystical life, is absolutely, for sure, necessary. There's no way around it. And that's why monks eat certain things. And that's why when you eat too much of another thing, you'll get drunk. That's why if you ingest certain things, they will have effects on your body.

2.51 So often when you see someone playing that trick, you'll see it. People will play that trick. Usually, if you just pull out one step away, you can have the possibility of noticing a pattern that people wouldn't notice if they were in, too much inside the causalities. I'm going to give you a crazy example, all right? And sometimes, that's why sometimes it's important to pay attention to the things people say, even if they sound crazy. Just pay attention. When a story gains momentum in a culture, when all of a sudden everybody's saying something, even if it seems totally ridiculous, and completely crazy and conspiracy theory or whatever—if it's gaining traction, it has to be hooking on something, right? Attention isn't arbitrary. Care isn't arbitrary. If a story is landing in the culture, it means that there's something there to pay attention to. The question is, at what level can you pay attention to?

2.52 So, craziest example is when Covid started. I don't know if you remember. Some people started saying that the —what is it? The new Internet. I forget the name of it. It's like this new, the highest form of Internet. Whatever. These towers, these cell towers and these Internet towers—they were the ones that were causing Covid. Do you remember that, right? So these. Sorry? Yeah, 5G. Sorry. So you see how little I know about these things. 5G towers are causing Covid. And it got so far that some, some people actually, like, burned some down. Some people, like, attacked some of these 5G towers. And so, ridiculous, right? I mean, it's so ridiculous to think that these 5G towers are causing Covid.

2.53 OK, is it really that ridiculous? So the question is, at what level is it not ridiculous? So, often the problem is that we look at material causalities and then we look at those, and that's ridiculous. Like, I honestly, really—it's clear that 5G towers aren't causing the virus in your body or the symptoms in your body. But are 5G towers causing Covid? Well, that's a more interesting question to ask. So think about what happened during Covid and imagine that happened 100 years ago. Would we have had Covid? If that had happened 100 years ago, would they have shut down everything? Would they have shut down schools and stores, and could they have shut down everything?

2.54 And the answer is obviously no. If Covid had happened 100 years ago, people would have died, and people would have cried, and people would have buried their dead, and they would have mourned, and then life would have continued. Of course. What made it possible for Covid to happen? And one of those things is definitely connectivity. The Internet made Covid possible. Without the Internet, it never would have had the shape that it had. And so in the intuition, like in the intuition of thinking, what, 5G towers cause Covid, I mean, obviously, if some crazy guy in the street screams that out, you just ignore them. But if all of a sudden some story is like hooking into culture, it's like

it's getting its nails into the narrative, and for some reason, even if it's misinformation, for some reason, people are perpetuating this story. Why?

- 2.55** It can't be arbitrary. There's no way that it's arbitrary. It has to have something which is attracting care. And if you're able to pull out, you can gain some pretty interesting wisdom from some of the wildest and craziest things. And that is an example where I can answer something like, did 5G towers cause Covid? And the answer is, to a certain extent, yes, but not the way, not if you just look at the material causality, but only if you look at the meaning of what is happening. You can see a bunch of that going around. Like, pay attention to the crazy stories, like some of the wild stories that people tell. And a lot of them have a kind of weird mythological coherence that, if you're able to pull away from just the material causality, you're able to gain deeper wisdom.
- 2.56** And the answer is, what is it that you want? What do you want from experience? It's easy to just mock and point and say, "Idiots. Like, a bunch of idiots." And, I mean, I'm sure the people who went and burned the towers were not the smartest people in the world. Like, that's for sure that that was real. But if you want to be able to look at culture in general and kind of analyze culture from afar, then understanding how these patterns work will help you—and understanding how there are levels of causality that aren't exactly the same. Not all causality is just material causes. There are different types of them.
- 2.57** And if you perceive them, then you'll be able to interpret reality in a different way. And so another, I kind of like using the conspiracy ones because some of them are so crazy that you think there's no way you can, you can see meaning in this. So a good example is the lizard people. Do you remember the lizard people? So the idea is that there's, like, lizard people, and those lizard people, they are, they are hiding in the elite, right? And so, like, you see them as normal people, but ultimately they're lizard people. And it's the same. Like, it's the same thing. You think, like, OK, well, that's crazy, obviously, but why is that story landing? Like, why is it that anybody would believe something that, on the face, sounds so ridiculous?
- 2.58** And the answer is, like, just pull out a bit. Just pull away from the material causes and look at the story. I must look at it as if it was a movie. Look at it. Why would anybody care about that? Why would anyone pay attention to that? And then if you do that, you can see what's going on. So what's going on? Why were lizard people our leaders? And so, why lizards? Lizards, I mean, lizards are good because they're kind of a snake, like, right? They're snakes. And so they are—and also it's good because often they say, like, they're the descendants of, like the, of, like, the devil or something. Descendants of the serpent in the garden or some crazy thing like that.
- 2.59** It's like, oh, now, but are they the descendants of the snake in the garden? Maybe. Maybe. What's going on? And so think about that. In the Garden of Eden, did the snake want that which is good for Adam and Eve? And the answer is no. The snake wanted something else, something else that he wanted. He didn't want their good. So what's

going on? Why are the leaders snakes? Why are they lizard people? And once you see it, it's like, it's not that complicated. People perceive that there is an elite leader class which doesn't want our good. That's what they're perceiving. They're saying, "They're supposed to be our leaders, but they want to reduce the population," or, "They're supposed to be our leaders, but they don't seem to want what's good for us."

- 2.60** So they're like a foreign species. They're like aliens. Aliens is a good way to understand that. Like, imagine if aliens—there was actually a series called V, which had that story in it. So these lizards from outer space come to Earth, and they kind of act as if they're helping the humans, but ultimately, they have other purposes, their own selfish purposes, which go contrary to our purposes. And so that's what's going on. And so when someone has that kind of, that energy where they're angry and they have this idea that there're lizard people, usually comes from a perception, and that perception is something like that. It's like, our leaders are not ours. They're not from us. They're from something which is not us.
- 2.61** So globalism can do that just almost normally, because you have a sense, like, where is your allegiance? Who is your allegiance to? Your allegiance isn't to us. It seems to be to something else, some other body, some other thinking, some other way of seeing the world. And therefore, you're like a snake in our garden. You're hiding. You look human, but behind you, there's another purpose. There's something else going on. And so, like, the fact that, you know, the fact obviously, that lizard, we don't think that they're, that these people are physically, you know, biologically, lizard people. But to just discount this is not the right way to go.
- 2.62** Because the people that are bringing that—it's almost like the people that are bringing out these stories, there's something like mythological tuning forks. You can see it that way. They're like these mythical tuning forks, and they're kind of, they're noticing something's wrong and they can know, they know it. They know it just intuitively. They see that there's something off. Just like, I mean, just like if you meet someone who's lying to you, if you're sensitive, you'll see it in their face, right? You'll see that they're lying to you. But sometimes you can't explain why. You can't say, try to describe it. It's like, "Why do I think they're lying to me?" Well, there's just something about them that just looks wrong.
- 2.63** Well, that scales, too. It's not just individuals. You can have a whole apparatus of communication, which, when you listen to it, you're like, "Man, there's something off, something wrong about the way that I'm being communicated to, which hides—" and so these mythological tuning forks, they're kind of just paying attention and they're listening, and then it bubbles up as crazy stories. But the stories aren't crazy. They're almost couched in very ancient structures, like very ancient images. Mythological images. But it doesn't mean that they don't have any value at all. And like I said, if you ignore them, then you're actually ignoring a whole—how can I say this? A whole effect in culture that is real.

- 2.64 So let's say, let's say, I don't know, one-fifth of the population can feel that there's something off, something off about the way our leaders are dealing with us, something wrong about the elites. There's something in which the elites don't seem to care for us. Because think about it like in an ancient world—it's hard because we're so modern—but imagine you had a tribe and you had someone in that tribe that was more important, that had more riches, that had more things. It was incumbent on them to be connected to you and to make their riches and their power and their authority in service of the community, or else at some point, you just kill them and you get rid of them. Like, it's pretty simple, like a tribal structure.
- 2.65 But now it's why we have this problem. We have these elites that are floating up above us, and they have no responsibility to us, but they're nonetheless acting as elites. So if you just ignore that, because it comes out as a crazy mythological story about lizard people, then that'll just, it's just going to build up. It's just going to build up. Like I said, maybe one-fifth of the people feel that. And then maybe one out of 1000 will be like the tuning fork that is saying crazy, crazy things. And then the other tuning forks will hear that. They'll hear like, "lizard people," and be like, "Yeah, that's right. That's it. Like, that's right. It's got to be that. It's got to be that, right?" But they don't know why. It's like, they don't totally understand it. It's like a, it's a, it's a, it's an organic thing, but it nonetheless has—I kind of say, it has meaning and it, and it has—
- 2.66 So why am I saying all these things, right? It's like, I'm just trying to help you see that the approach that someone like Sam Harris has, there's a trick in it. And the trick is often reducing it to a caricature, reducing it to its material causes, then pointing out to how ridiculous it is. And the problem is that, often it's right. Like, it is ridiculous to think that, I don't know, like Joe Biden is a lizard. Like an actual lizard. There's something ridiculous about that. But it depends what you want from life, right? If you want to be able to get it, if you want to just be, just be baffled all the time about what's going on and just be like, "What's happening? Everything's falling apart. Everything's crazy. Why does the world look the way that it does?", then that's what's going to happen to you.
- 2.67 But if you're able to pull away and, like, that's what we'll look at in the next, in the next few days—to be able to pull away and to see the world as this pattern which is emerging and how, sometimes, you know, as it appears as stories, it can reveal you something nonetheless, even if it doesn't totally stick to material causality, it will reveal you an aspect of reality nonetheless, and one which will help you understand why the world looks the way that it does. So hopefully tomorrow we will get right into the actual thing and we'll look at these mythical religious patterns and how they're relevant to our world today.
- 2.68 So thanks for your attention, everybody.

Lecture 3: Heaven and Earth

At a glance — The pattern of heaven and earth as a fundamental symbolic axis, developed on the seminar's second day.

- 3.1** So, hello, everybody. We're on our second day of this symbolic interpretation seminar. Today we're going to dive into the pattern. Yesterday, I tried to get you to see the inevitability of meaning, the inevitability of pattern, in the way we perceive the world, in the way we engage with the world. And ultimately, what I'm trying to suggest to you is that it's not just how we perceive the world. It's not just kind of a psychological projection onto reality, but it is the only way we can access reality. So as far as we know, we're dealing with the pattern of reality itself. Like, that's what we're dealing with.
- 3.2** And that's something which is difficult, you know, because of René Descartes and because of modern thinking, we have this strange duality that we talk about. Like, we have this sense that there's the physical world, right? And it has a kind, its kind of rules. And then there's the viewer. There's the spiritual part that we don't talk about anymore. Now we kind of just take it for granted. There's the viewer, there's the people looking. And that somehow the viewer is arbitrary. Or either we don't talk about it. Either we talk about it as being just subjective, right? You've heard that kind of language.
- 3.3** But the interesting moment that we're in is that, in some ways, materialism playing itself out has led to a funny situation. Because we have this split, right? We have the philosophers who talk about spirit and matter, spirit and phenomena. And then we kind of think the spirit is maybe superstitious. Like, we start to not like it. We want to just talk about this material stuff, and we want to encompass everything in the material stuff.
- 3.4** And once we've kind of, let's say, accounted for the phenomena, something weird happened where it's like, well, now that we accounted for the phenomena, we have to also account for the thing that's looking at it, right? Because if the world is just these material causes, then the way we look at it, the way we encounter it, shouldn't be any different, should arise from the same processes, shouldn't be this weird, abstract, alien thing that just has no meaning and comes from nowhere. No, it should, should have the same patterns as cells and all the things we look at.
- 3.5** And that's when things get loopy. Things get very strange. Because all of a sudden, saying something is just subjective is a ridiculous statement, right? Whatever is subjective has to emerge from the same properties that give you the natural things in the world. So then when we take the kind of scientific eye, and we turn it towards consciousness, something very, like I said, something very weird happens. We have to discuss—it's very difficult to do because it's like the thing looking, trying to look back at

itself. And all of a sudden, the patterns of perception start to appear. And if we talk about the patterns of perception, the patterns of story, and the patterns of images, the way we frame things, if we talk about it with similar rules that we talk about the physical properties of the world, we have this strange door that opens, which is all of a sudden, we can maybe explain things that people thought were silly in the past.

- 3.6** So if everything is an emergent property of material processes, can we say something like, religion is completely stupid? Like, it's just ridiculous, it's a ridiculous thing. No, no, no. Just understand it, just like any other phenomena. Look at what it's doing, look at what it's aiming at, look at how it lays itself out, and figure it out. So there's almost like a disarming of the polemic that we've seen in modernism, you know, as if a lot of the materialists were attacking the ancient traditions. And now that is falling apart, there's still warriors in the, in that world. But hopefully you can start to see that when I talk about this pattern of reality, and I talk about the pattern of perception, it's not just, it's not just psychological, right?
- 3.7** Because you, like I said, you can't access any other pattern. You can't have another experience beside the experience of being a person in a body experiencing reality. And whatever information is given to you, whatever scientific data or whatever theory about the mechanical processes that appear in the world, is necessarily filtered through or taken in by the fact that you're an embodied person with senses and a way in which the mind works.
- 3.8** And that is the frame for—so every time someone tries to—just pay attention to it,—every time someone tries to pop out of that, like want to talk about reality as if they're not that, ask yourself, where are you standing when you talk about reality as if you're not in it? So that we're in—everybody that speaks is in the world and has to get back that perception as being the primary one. So that's what I'm kind of calling you to do.
- 3.9** So I'm going to kind of give you something that's going to be like a mythological pattern, like a mythological, all these mythological image, but remember that these mythological image always try to see that they're not just stories and they're not just images, but they are trying to account for the very structure of reality. But they're doing it in a way that is closer to our experience. Like I said, human beings, their first experience, is something like space, place, distance, center, periphery. These are the experiences that we live in, and these are the first ones. And so all religious mythological descriptions are dealing with the world as if we're taking the embodied experience of humans as primary. And that's great, because honestly, it is primary. It is the first, like the first filter through which you see the world.
- 3.10** And so many systems, many different religious systems, they'll have different ways of describing it. But often there's a sense in which at the outset of the system, there's some transcendent aporia or a unity, something that's like one, but you can't really describe it. You know, you have this idea, for example, you know, the cosmic egg that you find in kind of Indian mythology. You can have the sense of God in the Judeo-

Christian tradition, this idea that in the beginning, God. So there's something which is beyond all phenomena, all duality, all—so there's this kind of transcendent unity. And it really, it can be described in all kinds of ways. And some mythological systems don't talk about it. Some mythological systems start at the second part, which is the duality.

- 3.11** But there is a sense in which, I think in order for this to kind of come together into the highest good, like we talked about yesterday, there has to be a sense where there's this constant pull towards unity. And you see that, in every way, we identify things. Like, we identify things by their unity. And so there's a sense in which, if you can see that this is one thing and that it's bound in other things that move towards one, then that scales up. And like I said, there are a few systems that seem to start with duality, but this is not the way we're going to look at it. But let's not talk too much about the one. It's the one. That's it. It actually doesn't have qualities that are clear, at least at the outset. But it's easier to understand right away when we move into two.
- 3.12** And so in the beginning, God creates heaven and Earth. Think about this as the primal opposites. In some ways, at the outset, they don't totally have qualities, right? They're just almost like duality. So we're going to start to fill them with qualities. But those qualities are always analogies. All the things I'm going to use are going to try to help you get a sense of a notion of a primal opposite, because we don't have access. If I just say, it's just an opposite, right? It's like, well, what does that mean? It doesn't mean anything until you fill it, until you flesh it out. But that's really the way to understand it. It's just an opposite. It's, say, opposite itself. The possibility of things being opposite, right?
- 3.13** And so understanding that the world has this capacity, right? This, this type of symmetry that you find all through the world that separates things into, into two, OK? And this is a universal, this is a universal pattern, right? You've seen this image before, yin-yang, which is also heaven and Earth. And it has different qualities as well. This is a very beautiful way of representing it because it shows the dependence of the opposites on each other. So opposites always define each other.
- 3.14** And it's very interesting because you can actually—this is a trick people use sometimes when they try to convince you of something. They say, try to explain something, then you show them an aspect of it and they'll say, "Well, actually, that's the opposite." But the opposite is always contained by a category. The opposite of man is not orange. It's like, a man and woman are opposites because they participate in a relationship. They participate in a higher category which binds them together. And that's true of all opposites. So the opposite of up is down. Won't keep going. But the opposite of up is not my grandmother. There's all kinds.
- 3.15** So you have to understand that when we—so sometimes when you see opposites, even in political discourse, even in an argumentation, if you sometimes, if you're able to kind of pull back away from the duality, you can notice that they're opposites because they're actually playing in the same game, they're playing in the same

relationship. That can be really helpful to sometimes avoid falling into irreducible opposites. And so the opposites, they are fractal. OK? I've been using that word a little bit. But the way to understand that notion of fractal is that it's a pattern that repeats itself at every level. So a tree is a fractal because a tree has a trunk. It has offshoots. And every offshoot of the trunk, every branch, is another trunk. It has the same logic as the tree.

- 3.16** So you have a branch, the branch separates into two, then that other— then if you have another branch, that branch will separate into two. Separate into two, separate into two. So every branch, if you cut a branch and you hold it up, it's a tree. And if you cut a smaller branch and you hold it up, it's a tree. They all, every level, has the same pattern. And heaven and Earth will function that way, which is that, at everything that we can identify as having being, has a heaven and Earth. Right? This glass has a heaven and Earth. And then there's the cosmic idea of heaven and Earth that's described in, say, Genesis, which is just the primal opposite.
- 3.17** But everything you can identify will have something which is its heaven, you could say, and something which is its Earth. Sounds very abstract. Don't worry, it'll all hopefully land for you as we kind of get through. So this is going to be a little bit of an effort this morning. All right, so there are different ways to represent heaven. Of course, you can represent it as that which is above, and Earth is that which is below. But you can also represent heaven as something like a vertical. So you can understand heaven as the hierarchy itself. Earth is horizontal, heaven is vertical. And that is your experience of heaven. Heaven is up, right. Heaven is that which moves up, that which is above you. And so because heaven is above you, it can be experienced and can be seen as a vertical.
- 3.18** And we'll see how that makes sense as we go through. You're going to start to see the images and, of course, heaven and Earth, horizontal, vertical and horizontal, meeting together—that is a way to represent the connection between heaven and Earth. You can also represent heaven as a point, right? As a dot. Remember when I told you yesterday about the idea of a reference point? Like, let's say, you're in a chaotic space. How do you find something? You need a marker. That marker has to be high up, because if it's not high up, you won't be able to see it.
- 3.19** So you raise a pole up into the heavens, and then that becomes your marker. Here, this is now not just space. This is a place, and that can appear as a point, like a dot, something above you, which will bind everything together. It has all kinds of iterations. We're going to see them, like, think of, think of something like a royal crest, and it has all this stuff inside. And what are they going to put on top? A crown. Put a crown on top. This point that brings it all together. There are different ways of representing it.
- 3.20** So here is an icon which is called the Ladder of Divine Ascent. So in this image, what you're seeing is something like Jacob's ladder. We talked about Jacob's ladder yesterday. We're seeing monks, spiritual practitioners, that are going up the ladder in

order to go to where? To go to heaven, right? They want to go to heaven. And so down here is the Earth and up here is heaven. And now they are moving up the ladder in order to go to heaven. And on both sides, on each side of the ladder, you have, on one side you have angels. What are the angels doing? They're helping the people go up. And on the other side you have demons, and the demons are pulling people down.

3.21 OK? All right. At the top you have Christ, who is the divine logos. Whether you believe in that or not at this point is not important. But to understand that he is the summit, he is the highest thing, and he is calling people into heaven, calling people to move up towards that which is above them. OK? So you can see how the vertical itself is the ascent. Like, moving up different levels, going up towards heaven, and down here is the Earth. We're going to look a little bit about what that Earth means, but this is something like the ideal, right? It's something like the thing that we're all trying to become like. The thing that we're all moving towards, the thing that we think is what we should be aiming at. That's what's above.

3.22 So it has a moral quandary, like here obviously it's moral, but it's not moral if I ask people to join me near this building. It's not moral if I just have a center of town or some steeple atop where I can say, "oh, just, it's there." And I point people towards the place which I can see coming together, that binds us, that drives us to move towards something, right? And it's not moral if there is this little heaven. Like, this glass has a heaven. It has an ideal, it has a purpose. It has something drawing it together, not physically, but like, in the fact that I care about it. And if it doesn't attain that, I'm not going to use it, right?

3.23 If it doesn't do what it's supposed, if it doesn't move towards its goal, towards its ideal, if it doesn't contain water, if it isn't the right size for me to hold, if it doesn't do all the things that a glass should do, then I'm not going to use it, right? It's not moving up towards its purpose, right? And so there's a chance that I'm going to smash it and throw it away and then it's down here in this fiery pit and send it to hell. I'm going to send this glass to hell, if it doesn't play the role that it's supposed to play. Just trying to get you to see the images.

3.24 But it's not, of course, this—sometimes this is hard for people to look at this because you're like, "Well, I don't care about religion. I'm not a religious person," but I hope you'll be able to see that, ultimately, I'm using this to help you see how it's structured in a pattern. And the thing about religious stories and religious images, why they're so good at doing that, first is because they aim at the highest ideal. They try to identify what is the highest thing that humans can aim at. And so they tend to embody the pattern of reality more than kind of boring everyday life things. But everyday life things are made of the same stuff. Everything is made of the same stuff.

3.25 It's a little bit like what I told you yesterday about the difference between your love story in your life and a movie. The movie kind of compresses things together and helps you see it better because it's like, it's trying to get to it, like trying to compress it

together. And that's what a lot of religious imagery and religious stories do. It's like, for thousands of years, people have been trying to get to see this and to aim at it and to see what's going on. And so a lot of the religious imagery is the best type of imagery to be able to interpret this pattern of reality. Right?

3.26 OK. And so what is heaven? So let's start with the experience of heaven. Like, the actual physical experience of what the heaven is, right. The heaven is where light comes from. Right? The heaven is where wind is. That heaven is where we experience sound. Sound moves through the heavens, moves through the air, right? The heaven is where invisible things are. What I mean, invisible things are, I mean, the wind is not visible. Light is not visible. Light is invisible. Wind is invisible, but it makes other things move, and it makes other things visible. So wind moves things, and you see them move, but you don't see the wind. Light makes things visible, but you don't see the light. OK?

3.27 The other thing that happens, we're so modern that we don't realize this, but the heavens are the place where there are regular patterns, mathematical regular patterns. We have patterns down here, but they're messy. Kind of messy. Now, there is a pattern to reality. Trees have patterns, but they're more idiosyncratic, like they're a little more embodied, more messy. But the patterns up there, right? There, there's a clock. What's going on up there is a clock. People studied for thousands of years the movements of the stars, the regular movements of the stars. And just the movement, the pattern of the day. It's a regular pattern, and it's a pattern that is not just regular, but that is the one that makes your life regular.

3.28 The pattern of the sun, the pattern of the procession of the sun in the sky, and how that is the regular pattern that, let's say, manifests itself in the seasons down here below, in the night and day, down here below, those are that which manage your life. They're the patterns that manage your existence. The other thing about heaven is that it's above you. And there's an actual embodied experience of something which is above you. It is completely embodied. It is the things that are above you—let's say it this way. This is my brother who came up with this thought experiment.

3.29 So imagine you're in a room and you've got a bunch of people. We're all standing here. Let's say that it's a party. Everybody's standing and discussing with each other. One of the things that's going to happen is that I can't see everybody if we're all in a crowd, a big crowd. Like, I can see, you know, you're behind him, and everybody's kind of talking to each other. So there's a, there's a less of a unity in the experience I can have down here below. So what if I want to talk to everybody? What should I do? It's pretty simple to put a chair down, step up on the chair, and then all of a sudden, what happens? It's very simple. All of a sudden, everybody can see me, I can see everybody, but all the people here can't see all of each other. So I immediately become a focus. I immediately become a point of attention.

3.30 When I talked about that dot, that point, up high, it's something which happens completely embodied. There's no way to avoid it. It's very natural. And that's why so

many things will be represented that way. Like, you know, a king on his throne will have steps and will be up above everybody. If you want someone, like, if you want someone to talk to everybody, you want to make sure that everybody can see them. Think about football play. Like, if the captain of the team wants to give the play, he has to be in a spot, like in the middle, maybe standing up above everybody, maybe in front of them, so that everybody can see them, even though he might not be able to see everybody, OK?

3.31 And so that is a simple characteristic of what heaven is. If you want to have a little experience of heaven, it's not hard to do. You just go up a mountain, right? So you start at the bottom of the mountain, and you see, you know, a bunch of stuff, a bunch of trees, you know, like very, you know, very particular things. And then as you move up the mountain, what's going to happen? You're going to see less detail, but you're going to see more encompassing vision. You're gonna have a more encompassing vision. As you go up the mountain, you will start—phenomena will start to gather together under you, and you're gonna start to see more and more. And when you get to the top of the mountain, then all of a sudden, you have this experience, which is astounding, which is all of a sudden, you have a 360 vision of the entire Earth. It's not the whole Earth, but you have that sense where it's like, I see everything.

3.32 And that's what heaven is, right? It's the manner in which multiplicity moves into one. And like I said, you could just have that experience. So it's not surprising that stories, religious stories, will always have guys going up mountains, like Moses goes up a mountain. And it's a very normal pattern of religious storytelling. And this is not at all arbitrary. This is completely coherent, if you want to understand what it is that these things are talking about. Now, what I described to you is the, something like the phenomenological experience of heaven.

3.33 But then what happens in humans is that because our experience is made of that experience, because our other experiences are made of that primordial experience — almost, there aren't many more primordial experiences than the relationship between above and below, between the relationship between light and dark, these primal opposites—so what happens is that, as we develop thought, as we develop consciousness, as we develop all these things, then that primordial experience becomes embodied or becomes encoded into the way we understand the more abstract versions of this. And so that's when heaven becomes an image of things that are less embodied.

3.34 So a name, right? If I look at you, can I see your name? No, but your name connects you to the world, right? It connects you in terms like, again, I can't see your name, but we're in a crowd. I want to get your attention. What do I do? It's like, "Hey, Jimmy." And then all of a sudden, I get your attention by knowing your name. That's pretty amazing. It's an amazing thing. So your name is related to heaven. Or you could say something like, your name comes down from heaven. That's how your name works.

Because, like I said, it has to do with knowledge, it has to do with pattern, it has to do with your connection to me through meaning. Your connection to others in the world of meaning will happen through your name.

- 3.35** And then in general, patterns in general, right? Patterns are invisible. We can only see embodied versions of patterns. And the patterns, they're interesting. I'm going to keep using this glass. It's like, so this glass has certain amount of elements which are needed for it to be recognized as a glass. And that pattern is completely invisible and cannot be seen. And the reason it cannot be seen is because it has indefinite iterations. There's an indefinite amount of glasses that are possible, but they all have to have certain characteristics so that I can recognize it as being what it is. But the pattern itself is not visible, right?
- 3.36** And so, and that's true of anything that is a pattern, whether it's a sound wave, whether it's anything that is a pattern, whether it's even like a rhythm. Let's say a musical pattern cannot be seen and the pattern itself cannot be—you can't see the pattern. You can only hear it in the instruments and in the rhythm that's actually someone hitting a drum or someone playing a guitar. Then all of a sudden you're like, "Oh, wait a minute. This isn't just random noises. There's a pattern." But the pattern is not in the world the same way. It's in the world in a different way. It's in the world in the way that heaven encounters Earth.
- 3.37** All right, so identity, unity, purpose. You cannot see the purpose of something. The purpose of something is that which drives it. But you can't see the purpose. If you, if you don't know what—let's say, I don't know, you're from another planet and you find an object which we identify as being a guitar. I don't know, like, whatever it is, if you don't know its purpose, you can't see it in the object. It's not in the material stuff. It's in the way that all of that is gathered together.
- 3.38** The purpose of something is in the capacity I have to recognize it as being something in the first place. And objects can change depending on their purpose. I talked about that yesterday. A rock can be all kinds of things, and it's completely coherent. The purpose drives the manner in which I engage with it, and that's invisible in the thing itself. And so, same with authority. Authority is not visible. If you have a—people try to make it visible. So if you have a group, and someone in that group has authority, what's the difference between them and the other people? Can you see it in their body?
- 3.39** Like, if everybody took their clothes off and we're standing there, could you know who has authority? You wouldn't. You can't know. It's an invisible property. We try to embody it, right? We'll give people uniforms, we'll give them a crown, we'll put them up on a pedestal. We'll do these things to embody their authority. But that's not their actual authority. Their authority is invisible. OK? So you're starting to see this quality. And usually heaven, in most cultures, in most traditions, is identified with masculine. This is where people in the modern world don't like that. And I get it, OK? But you have to understand the masculine strict—like, if you understand the phenomenological

manner in which reproduction works, you can get it. You can understand it. You can understand why the masculine is identified with heaven.

- 3.40** Because what does the, what does the masculine offer in reproduction? Right? We say it, it's seed, like the masculine offers seed, like its little point, little dot, like something that hasn't, doesn't have body yet. The pattern, right? Nearly, it's not completely invisible because it is still embodied, but the image of that. And then the woman is the one who provides the body. And then you can't—how can I say this? When you see the child, or when the woman is pregnant and is having the child, you can't see who the father is. It's invisible. It's there, but it's invisible. You can see who the mother is, obviously, because she's got the child in her womb, you know? And so these are the ways in which you can help us understand it.
- 3.41** Another image is, of course, seed itself. Seed is an image of heaven. It's an image of heaven because, right, it's the pattern of the plant, but it has no body yet, so you have to put it in the ground. And then when you put it in the ground, then it develops body. So then we move now to Earth. And so Earth will be the opposite of heaven, and so it will have the characteristics. So Earth is darkness, water. Earth has a lot of qualities because it's—can I say this? Because it's like the principle of embodiment, sometimes it will even have opposite qualities, but we'll see why as we move towards.
- 3.42** So darkness is simple. It's like light stops at the Earth and it doesn't keep going. So down there, it's dark. Up there, it's light. And even when it's dark up there, there's still lights up there. There's still the stars. But down there, it's dark, completely dark. All right. It's opaque compared to being transparent. It's chaos in the sense that it's not ordered in the same way as what we see above. So we can understand that the experience of Earth as having something like lack of identity—so dirt, it's just, it's dirt. Like, it's hard to, it doesn't have an identity. We see. We see that things come out of the dirt, that have clear identity, that are alive. It's like the dirt itself, like it's inert. It seems to be, seems to be, seems to be a lack of identity.
- 3.43** I'm just trying to explain to you at least the phenomenological experience of what it is. So above, you have light, you have air, you have spirit, you have the thing that moves things. But if you go down in the water, you die, right? You can't breathe. There's no spirit, and so you die. If you go down in the Earth, it's the same thing. If I bury you underground, you will die because there's no spirit. There's no air. OK? So all of that is what Earth is. And so, but it's also, at the same time, a kind of stability. So it's what's interesting about the symbolism of Earth, is that it's potential, it's kind of chaos, but it's also that, there, the place where we find stability.
- 3.44** So what Earth appears as, in terms of its, let's say, its more abstract qualities, will be something like the Earth appears as a question. So darkness appears as a question. Like, what is there? If we walk into a dark room, that's what you're going to experience. Like, what is there? And then what you want to do is you want to shine light into the darkness. And then the potential of what could be there will manifest itself out of that

darkness. So that's the way to kind of understand the relationship between the two. You know, you take a seed and you plant it in the Earth, and it's hidden, and you can't—it's hidden, it kind of gets swallowed up by the Earth. But then out of that comes the body. So the Earth is multiplying. Like, it multiplies identity. It fleshes things out.

- 3.45** So this glass, like I said, it has its move towards an identity, but there's an indefinite possibility of how it would be made. And that indefinite aspect, right, its body aspect—that is what we would call the Earth. That's why it's potential. Like, the best way to say it. It's the potentiality of things. How much of it, like, what's the limit of how much can be embodied by that identity? At some point, it has a limit, like, in terms of specific things. Like that, you know, if I, I don't know, like, if I was holding a ball, it wouldn't be a glass. It would not be something that—or if I tried to make a glass, you know, out of fire. I can't make a glass out of fire, right? There's a, there's a limited potentiality about how, how things move, how things can embody something. And that is what the Earth represents.
- 3.46** Now, of course, in terms of the primordial Earth, then it's something like chaos itself, right? It's the ocean. It's the monster, too. It's like this, it's this chaos or potentiality that is unbounded, that is completely, that there's no limit to, right? So that's why, let's say in the Biblical narrative, it says "was empty and void," like the Earth was empty and void. It's like this void that calls to be, to be filled is the best way to understand it.
- 3.47** OK. And so it becomes the enactment of anything would be considered moving into Earth. The notion of power, right? Because patterns don't have power. A pattern is invisible. It has to take body in order for it to have the power to do what the pattern is calling it to. So, right, it's like I could have the idea of a glass, which would be totally useless to me, because what I want is to drink water. So I need to gather power into that identity so that I can have a real thing that functions.
- 3.48** So you can understand if you think of it sexually, in terms of, in terms of reproduction, right? It's the same. It's like the man gives his seed to this, to the woman. And then where does all the body and power come from? Well, it has to come from her. If she doesn't eat, if she's not healthy, if anything happens to her, then that will diminish the power that will bring about that child. And so she's the source of power for the identity.
- 3.49** So now the analogies that you'll find in stories. So if you look at stories, you look at images, you look at religious rituals, all these things, you'll find certain analogies which will be relative versions of this. And like I said, the thing is that it's a fractal system. And that's why analogies are possible. So analogies aren't arbitrary. Like I told you, if I'm telling you that there's this abstract opposites of, like, identity and potential, it's like, "OK, yeah, well," but then I tried to show you that the experience of heaven is actually strictly analogical to this thing. And the reason is because that's what the world is made of. The world is actually made out of this.

- 3.50** So because it's made out of it, analogies are not arbitrary. And some people, you know, you've heard this idea where people criticize what they call magical thinking. They don't like analogies because they think it's kind of magical thinking. Some of it is. But strictly in terms—if you want to understand stories, if you want to understand, let's say, even politics or the way that things move in the world, then you have to be able to understand these analogies because they are what's feeding the— as things flesh out, they will take on these opposites and they'll interact with each other in that way. It's almost inevitable, right?
- 3.51** So if you have a political system where you only have two parties, they will automatically, without—there's no way around it—they will automatically set up as opposites, and they will ultimately split the population pretty much 50-50. There's no way around that. And so people who think that they can get out of this, that somehow, if you set up something with two opposites and that they think that it's going to be vastly more on one side and vastly less on the other, that's just not how it works. We actually do tend to see and interact with the world in opposites.
- 3.52** Images of heaven, in stories or in images will be the head versus the body. The intelligence, sight, speech, all the things that actually come out of your head, actually, right? Seeing, speaking, your spirit, meaning, comes out of your head. Right. Spirit—air—comes out of your head. And so your head is a little image of heaven, very strictly. Just like wind blows up here. Just like patterns are seen up here. Just like light is up here. Well, your eyes are here. Your meaning-making thing is up here. Like, all of that is a little image of heaven. So your head versus the body, right? And then something like intelligence or plan or pattern or whatever, versus the work. A king and a kingdom, right? A pole, a tree, a mountain. All these things that are vertical, that rise up, will be images of heaven. And then the human person itself is an image of heaven.
- 3.53** We are the only species that stands straight, right? We connect heaven and Earth. And again you'll say, OK, now we're in superstitious world, but honestly, I don't care, because that is the way that people from the beginning of recorded history have understood humans to be. Because we are meaning-making beings, because we are the beings that can see patterns and can reproduce patterns, can engage in patterns consciously, then we are this pole that connects heaven and Earth. Now, whether you think that it's silly to think that our actual stance is part of that, that's fine, but that's at least the way that people understood it.
- 3.54** And if you understand, if you don't understand that properly, then you're going to not understand a lot of the stories. Because there's a relationship between standing up and lying down in stories. Standing up, being vertical, being conscious, being alert, and then laying down, losing consciousness, falling asleep, being dead, OK? Becoming Earth, literally decomposing and becoming potential for something else. That's the human experience. And so it's very good to understand that.

- 3.55** And so then what will happen also in the stories is that the man will be seen as the vertical, as the meaning-making. And then the animal will be seen more, will be seen closer to Earth, representing Earthly aspects. And that's really important as well, because we are also—our body is still animal. We have animal aspects of us. And so in stories, what will happen—and you'll notice it if you think about it—the animal will represent aspects of us. Like, let's say, if you break down man into several aspects, then the animal will often represent different aspects of us, right? Different desires, different passions, different things about us, but they're lower on the, on the scale, let's say.
- 3.56** And then, of course, this notion of question and answer, or frame, right? Let's say, the frame of something. And then the answer that comes from above. So the Earth will appear as a—the question is the best way to say it. So it's not complicated. It's actually quite simple. So you have, you have—sorry, we're going to use this for all during the entire class, so you have to get used to it. Just like using the same example is good because keep bringing you back. So you have a reason, right? You have an identity, you have a, you have a purpose, and then you have a question.
- 3.57** Now the question is going to be something like, what about this? Is this a glass? Does this function as a glass? And then the pattern itself will answer yes or no, right? So you can understand it, like, you can understand it, if you want to understand it in evolutionary terms, it's good. It's like variability, mutation, and then selection. So the Earth produces variance and difference. And it's asking, what about this? What about that? Does this work? Does this function? Does this connected? Like, is this something we can do? And then there's a mechanism from above that says yes or no. And it's a completely natural process, right? It's a completely natural process.
- 3.58** Through the very qualities that you're wanting, like through the very identity of the glass, the question will get answered. Like, you know, if you propose, if a glass is proposed, it doesn't hold water, then the answer is no, right? It's like, no, but that's how it works. So you have question and answer, you have proposition, you have variability, and then you have constraint and identity, which comes from above, OK?
- 3.59** And this is as true for human interaction as it is for even at the most basic cellular level, you have that going on. You know, it's so interesting. I was talking to this guy who works on pharmaceutical companies, and he was describing to me how we produce antibodies. It was super fascinating because it's basically this. He said, OK, so a pathogen comes in, and then the body starts to produce antibodies, and it produces like thousands and thousands of small variants of antibodies. And then the antibodies come up to the pathogen and they try to grab onto it. Just try to grab on. And they have these like wiggly arms, like two wiggly arms. They just come up and they just, like, try to grab onto the pathogen.
- 3.60** And then there's a T-cell that goes around and checks, and whatever, whatever antibody is able to hold on to the pathogen a little then sends a system, sends a signal, make a lot more of that kind. They make a lot more of that kind, with some variability.

Then you get a second iteration, the antibody goes, the antibodies go out, and whatever holds on a little. And then this version now is going to have half of their arm frozen, and the next half of the arm is still floppy. As I go up, try to grab on, try to grab on, try to grab on. And then finally the T-cell sees, oh, that one is holding on better. Make a lot more of that kind. And it keeps going until you produce a version of the antibody that is completely latched on to the pathogen.

3.61 So it's like, that's it. Question, variability, selection. Selection based on a purpose, based on a telos, based on a reason, right? There's a reason why there's selection. So because this is fractal, that's why we can represent it as a ladder. Because the whole process, because there's an analogy between all the different heavens and Earths. Then that's why you can easily represent it as a ladder. So you can understand this ladder in a lot of ways. There are very basic ways you can understand it. Think of a, think of a hierarchy. Like, think of a military hierarchy, is a good way to understand this ladder.

3.62 So you have a—I forget, I don't know the military words—but you have like a platoon or whatever. You have a group of soldiers, and then they have a head, right? They'll have a corporal or whatever you call it. And then those, all these groups now become one. So it's like, you have a bunch of soldiers, they have someone above them, that's their chief, and they're all at the same level. OK? And so then those things become identities. It's like platoon one, platoon two, platoon three, platoon four. And then they, they all come together and will have something above them, someone above them, that will have authority over them.

3.63 It'll be—and then they'll be part of larger groups that will be like, oh, all these platoons are part of this division or whatever, and all these are part of this division. So you've got a level, you've got a head, you've got heads. And then those fit into higher heads. And you just keep stacking like that until you have the general above. And the general, he gives the plan, right? That's what the general does. The general gives the plan, and the plan filters down through the hierarchy. And everybody at their level knows what it is they're supposed to do at their level.

3.64 Like, what is it? You know, what do we tell the actual soldier to do? What do you tell the platoon to do? What do you tell the higher group to do? These are all set up and they all fit into each other in a way that looks like this ladder. The more you move up the ladder, the more you move towards the pattern, you move towards the plan, you move towards the big picture. And the more you go down the ladder, the more you move towards the enactment, towards the particular, towards the, towards the power, right?

3.65 Because the general has no power. He sits in his office. What is he going to do? Can't do anything. The power comes from below. The power is the capacity to gather the troops together and then to have them enact the plan that is coming down from above. OK? And so that's one of the reasons why we will see this pattern of reality as a ladder. Now, the ladder is not obviously just a ladder, a military ladder. It's any ladder, right?

It's any type of structure where you have multiplicity that fits into unities, that moves up. It can sometimes just be generalization. That works.

- 3.66** Think of taxonomical categories, right? You've got, you know, you've got a category called dog, and then you've got—in that category, you've got categories below that, and in those categories, you've got specifications. And you can do it indefinitely. You could separate indefinitely going down. In the category of dogs, it's like, well, every dog is an individual dog. Every dog is one dog. Why do we group them together? We group them together because we see, oh, these have similar characteristics. So we create—don't just create it, it emerges to a category of dog. And it's like, you keep going up, then you get to dog, but that category structure keeps going up. You can continue to go up, right?
- 3.67** But it can also be like we talked about yesterday. It can be a hierarchy of virtues. It can be a hierarchy of embodied ways of living. And that's where now we go much more into the political or the religious vision, which is that in a religious vision, you will have ways of being that have to depend on higher ways of being in order to be fruitful. So I gave a few examples yesterday. Things that are good, let's say, eating, you know, let's say physical activity, sex, all these things are all goods. But there's a manner in which these, in order for them not to become, let's say, not to become out of control, they have to fit into higher virtues.
- 3.68** And so what are those higher virtues? And so ultimately, theologians will come to say love, truth, goodness, beauty—these are the things that lower aspects of reality have to embody themselves in, in order to make sense. Now, you can, of course you can—these hierarchies can, say, they can break down, and they usually break down because there's a part that is trying to be the whole. And that's probably the best way to understand how, how, let's say, these types of hierarchies break down.
- 3.69** So if you have something, a desire, a behavior, like hunger, and you eat, but then that part of the hierarchy, which should be fitting into higher aspects, starts to take over, starts to think like, "I'm the thing, I'm the one," right? "I am God." Like, that's the, the cliché of the devil. "I am God," and then tries to subjugate the rest of reality to it, then things start to wobble, and things start to get out of control, and then things start to break down.
- 3.70** Addiction is obviously the simplest version of that, the easiest one to understand. You become addicted to something, to some behavior, a bad habit, or to a drug or whatever, and then all of a sudden, or let's say someone who's addicted to gambling. Someone's addicted to gambling. Then all of a sudden they start to reorganize all their other priorities under this addiction, and they start to subjugate what should be higher participations to this secondary good. And then things start to get completely wacky. And usually the way that happens is through a tyranny, OK?

- 3.71** And so this is why, you know, when you talk about hierarchy, people right away think tyranny, right? They right away think of —that hierarchies are power and authority. But usually the best way to understand it is, if a hierarchy is actually properly ordered, it should naturally flow. There should be little need for compulsion from above, although it's possible there should be less need of compulsion. It's usually when a part tries to be the whole, that's when you need tyranny. So a simple way to understand it is, you're in the army, right? And you're following your group, and you know, you, there's an order of authority, right? And it comes from the legitimacy of the president himself, the president who's elected from the people. That's the legitimacy out of which the flow of power comes.
- 3.72** And when you're a soldier, you know that that's where it ultimately comes from. Sometimes it can get distorted in the process. Messy things can happen. That's usually what happens. Now, let's say there's someone, there's a general, or there's someone in the hierarchy that has their own intentions, right? Maybe political ambitions, maybe they want to have a coup, or maybe they want to, they want to, they want to get money for themselves, or they want to be corrupt or whatever. All of a sudden, what they're doing doesn't flow from above. It doesn't come from above. It's this closed thing.
- 3.73** And then the only way to get that to happen will be a kind of violence, a kind of imposition, because you have to justify your authority, right? That's why, that's why revolution often leads to tyranny, because —I'll give you a mythological story that tells you this about the problem of hierarchy and revolution. So if you know the Theogony by Hesiod, which is a description of the order of the Greek gods, very old text. And so Hesiod tells the story of heaven and Earth. He starts with heaven and Earth. So he has the God of heaven and the God of Earth, right? And they are in relationship, and that is how the world is born. And so they have a sexual union, and out of their sexual union are born the gods.
- 3.74** Now, in that story, from the point of view of the gods, they don't like that. They feel like they need some room. They feel like heaven is pressing down upon them. And so one of the gods, Kronos, castrates his father, right? So think about some of the images that I, that I gave you, right? It's like, what is, what are these images of heaven? Seed, heaven, all this. So he castrates his father. He removes the seed from his father, and so the father vanishes, like, kind of goes away. But now Kronos has got a problem because he's the son of heaven, and now he just castrated his own source. He just took power for himself from his own source.
- 3.75** So what is he going to do now? How will he justify his own authority on his children? If you kill your father, why wouldn't your children kill you? How does it work? That's why in the Bible it says, "Honor your father and your mother." It doesn't say love them, it says honor them. Because if you don't, how will you justify your own children in regards to you? So Kronos castrates his father. So what does he have to do? He eats his

children. That's how you deal with it. He just prevents them from having autonomous existence by pulling them into himself completely.

- 3.76** Now, that's tyranny. Tyranny is an authority that tries to reduce the normal levels of being that exist below it, try to, like, suck it into itself so that now it's the thing. OK? So you can see, I hope you can see the difference. You can see in the Theogony, they're actually describing this very procession of being that I'm showing you. But in their version, then, because the son castrates the father, it creates this revolution, which is difficult to stop and often ends up being, ends up with a bunch of things, of parents eating their children, and the children also trying to kill their parents. And there's this devolution that happens. OK?
- 3.77** If you think about communists, if you look at the Russian revolution and what it led to, it's precisely that. You killed the king. Now what? Who's in charge? Who gets to decide? Where does the authority come from? So someone tries to rise up and take power, and the only way to do it is to kill, kill, kill. So Stalin succeeds, takes power, and what does he do? All the people that helped him, all the people that would have been that normal lower rung of authority for him because they helped him move up, he has to kill all of them because he has no way to justify his authority except for brute force. OK?
- 3.78** So here's another way to represent the relationship. So another way to represent the relationship is a mountain, a pyramid, a triangle. Quantity to quality, two to one, right? Multiplicity to unity. And so, like I told you, if you go up a mountain, you have that experience, and then all these will have iteration. So this is a perfectly coherent image of this. So you have above, you have the eye standing in for attention, standing in for meaning, standing in for light, standing in for the head. All of these things come together completely coherent. OK?
- 3.79** And because it is heaven, it is this, it is not totally, it's not touching the pyramid. At least in this version, it's not touching the pyramid. And then below that, then you have the normal order of the world. So layers of bricks that move from few at the top and then just become more and more and more and more at the bottom, right? And so the lower the bricks are, the more they have to be, more quantity. They're the ones who provide the strength for the whole structure. It's a completely, it's a completely reasonable way of representing this structure. And then above it says, I think it means, "He sees" or "he agrees," or like, as if, like God sees and agrees with what we're doing. And below, it's this idea of the secular order, right? The order of the world. OK?
- 3.80** And so here again, this is an image of Moses. Look at the way it's made. It's super interesting, because at the bottom of the image, there's actually, like, water down here, right? And then there are the animals, because the animals are below. And then you move up. And then Moses goes up the mountain. And what does he receive? He receives the pattern. He receives the reason. He receives the name. He receives the name of God. He receives the pattern of behavior. He receives the architectural pattern of the tabernacle, which is the structure of place. Right? How space becomes place.

- 3.81** And then he also, there's a—you don't see it in this particular image, but in the—God tells Moses in one of the ascents that he should leave all the people and the animals at the bottom of the mountain, that he should ascend with 70 elders. And then he should leave those 70 elders at one level of the mountain. And then he should keep going up with his highest counselors. And then he should leave those counselors at that step in the mountain. And then he should go all the way to the top of the mountain alone. So what is he setting up? He's setting up the very structure that I'm telling you about. Right?
- 3.82** Think of it as a military—it's not a military structure, but think of the way I described the military structure to you. That is what God is setting up. So in terms of name, pattern, place, and subsidiary, or let's say, a fractal structure of authority, which comes back down onto the world. OK? All right.
- 3.83** You can represent it like this. Now it's more embodied. This is Mont Saint-Michel in France. Like, the perfect example of everything that I'm saying. It's built in the water. Not all year, but it's sometimes in the year, like, it's actually, you can actually—the water comes right up to the, to the wall of the city. At the very middle top, you have this spire that goes way up, right, and points to the heavens and is like the center of the city, almost like the top of a pyramid or the top, you know, the top of a, you know—and then the whole city lays itself out at the top. You will have the church, right?
- 3.84** And then you will have, like—usually the way it works is you have the church in the middle. You'll have civic buildings or, you know, the king's palace or whatever next to it. And then as you move down, then you will have the different embodiments, people living there, different craftspeople, peasants, whatever, that kind of move all the way down. And then on the edge, you have the wall. That is the limit, the frame, right? The edge of the identity. So it's a city. It has an identity.
- 3.85** And so if you go into the church, then you have a microcosm. You have a repetition. That's why I keep telling you it's fractal. You have a repetition of the same pattern. So a traditional church, it's subtle, but a traditional church is actually an ascent. So if you move up all the traditional church, the altar should have at least a few steps that bring you up towards the altar. The altar has to be higher than any of the other places in the church. And the altar, the church has three sections. It has a section on the most inside, which is the altar area, the holy place. And there, usually it's only clergy that are allowed to go. And then you have something called the narthex, not the narthex, the nave, which is where everybody gathers together, you know, in the, in the church. And then you have a place called the vestibule or the narthex, which is like an in-between space. And then that's where you can probably talk to each other and you can have, you can discuss. It's not completely in the church.
- 3.86** So you have this structure, and then on the table of the altar, you have, again, another little microcosm. So it's like, you have the whole church that's kind of moving from quantity to one. You have that point in the middle with the altar. Then on the altar, you

have this chalice, and you have this piece of bread. And the priest, what does he do? He lifts it up like that. It's like, that's the center, that's the top. And then what he does is he takes that, brings it down, and then he distributes it out to the people. And he'll do that with the actual host. But he'll also give you the pattern. He'll read the Bible to you. He'll tell you how we're supposed to live. He's going to give you the pattern of how we should embody these things. OK?

3.87 So the image of a church and how it works is the same image as Moses going up the mountain. All right? So you can represent it like that. And then you can represent it like this. Represent it as a wheel. A wheel is a good way to understand it. So the top or the middle of the pattern can also just be a center. Right? So the center of the wheel, the center of the wheel, the axis of the wheel is, actually, doesn't exist in the wheel. Did you know that? The actual axis, the center around which the wheel is turning, has no physical existence. It's an invisible point in the wheel. It's like an invisible physical thing that balances the movement of the wheel. So if you have a physical object, like if you had a spoke in there, like, it would, it would hold the wheel together. But that's not—the wheel is not—the wheel is turning around an invisible center of movement. OK?

3.88 And so then you have, so you have one. You have the source of its movement. You have the source of its being. You have this invisible point in the middle. And it's one. It has to be one. You can't have two centers in a wheel. If you have two centers in a wheel, you have a wobbly wheel. You don't have a wheel that turns properly. And so it's the one in the middle. And then you have spokes that move out. You have multiplicity that moves out from the center, out into the edges. The further they are from the middle, the further they are from each other. So it's a specification, it's an individuation. As the spokes get closer to the middle, then they are closer together as well.

3.89 So think about my military hierarchy again. So imagine you've got the president, you've got a bunch of generals, and you've got a bunch of groups of armies. The soldier that is digging a trench—does he know what the plan is or does he know what the other soldier in like, platoon 20 is doing over there? No, he doesn't. He doesn't have to. He doesn't have to, as long as he's connected to the middle. He doesn't have to know what everybody's doing. And so that's why as the wheel grows, it moves from one to many, it moves from the pattern and the source, towards specification, towards individuation, and, you could say, towards a kind of fragmentation, because as the wheel gets larger, it'll start to have a—there'll be a kind of a regularity.

3.90 The further you move from the middle, regularities will start to appear in the movement of the wheel. It's normal, like the force that the wheel is operating will start to diminish with entropy as you move out towards the edge of the wheel. So the bigger the wheel, the more force you need, the more danger there is that, towards the edge, it's going to start to get wobbly and actually going to start to not, manifest the wheel. So you can understand that it's the same again with this military hierarchy. It's like, the

lower you get, the more you get to the soldier, the more there's a chance that they might maybe kind of misunderstand and maybe not do the right thing because they're not totally connected to the very top. Like, they're kind of, they're kind of off-key.

3.91 So think of a city like that. Think of Mont Saint-Michel. You have the king, you have the priest or the bishop or whatever, and then you have the aristocracy, the people that are kind of in charge. Then you got the people, regular people, and then maybe you got a few people that, you know, like, they're not criminals, but they're kind of off. You know, they're a little shady, but you know, it's like, as long as they don't cause too much trouble, you just let them be. You don't necessarily have to bring the hammer down, but it's like, there's this, like, normal procession, normal hierarchy, where there are people on the edge which will manifest more idiosyncrasy, and that idiosyncrasy sometimes will be a little bit in conflict with the pattern itself. But it's like, if things are properly running, then that's OK. All right?

3.92 So there are many versions of this. Going to go through these, and then we're going to stop for now. So this is a Native American medicine wheel, which has exactly this notion. So you have a center, you have four spokes with four different colors that represent the specifications of different aspects of reality, depending on how you want to frame them. They're actually quite, quite coherent and quite coherent. And that moves out now to the edge of the wheel.

3.93 Right, if you look at a mandala, mandala has the same structure. You have a center. Usually there's a ritual aspect to a mandala where you're supposed to kind of enter into the center of the mandala, deal with all the elements on the periphery, but the elements on the periphery will be an extension of that which is in the middle. So the middle will be like the source of all the multiplicity around it. And just like the wheel, it has four aspects. We'll get to why there are four aspects, but think of a—I forget how that's called in English, where the direct wheel, the direction wheel—and so you have four. You have a central point where you are, and then you have an extension of that out into the different directions. These are all different versions of this symbolism of the wheel, right?

3.94 And let's say, the ancient swastika is the same thing, right? So it's basically a center with extensions, and then something that is kind of like the periphery of the wheel. It's not an actual wheel, but it's hinting at the same type of symbolism that we're dealing with when we look at what a wheel is, right? So central—you need at least, for a wheel to be functional, you need at least four spokes, because that's the way to make it solid. And so those will be the least amount of spokes that you see.

3.95 And then, of course, a cross also has that type of structure. So it's the connection of a vertical with a horizontal in different ways. There's a center, the heart, the middle of the cross, and then there's a vertical extension, which is the hierarchy, which is heaven. And then there's a horizontal extension, which is the way that heaven connects to the

Earth, but that can also be multiple. In a cross, you can sometimes have multiple bars because it is a ladder as well.

3.96 Remember, so Earth is not just one. It's fractal, right? At every level that you can recognize unity, you have a heaven and an Earth. But if you represent it as a vertical, it's nice because you can just put a bunch of bars and you say, well, here's the heaven and then here are all the levels that kind of connect with each other, all right? And it's like, if you think about it, this is completely your intuitive way that you think about it. We say it like, talk about the corporate ladder, the way we talk about going up a hierarchy. You know, when you go up a corporate ladder, you're not actually going up into physical heaven, but it's completely coherent for us to understand that that's what we're referring to, that ascending a hierarchy towards authority, ascending a hierarchy towards less specificity, more pattern, more encompassing power, having more encompassing authority—that is going up the ladder in your company or whatever, all right?

3.97 And so this is the basic pattern, right, of how this structure that I'm trying to get you to see works. And so in the next part, what we're going to do is we're going to look at how—I'm going to give you a very, very simple example. We're going to interpret Christmas, and I'm going to show you how Christmas just repeats, repeats, repeats, repeats, the same image if you can see it. All right, so see you after breaking.

Lecture 4: Christmas Symbols

At a glance — Christmas symbols as a concrete case study, showing how the abstract pattern manifests in a specific tradition.

- 4.1 I want to bring down some of the things that I talked about into a specific pattern. We're going to look at Christmas and look at some of the different traditions of Christmas, even in different places, and see how it connects to the things that I'm talking about.
- 4.2 What is Christmas? In the Christian tradition, Christmas is the moment where the Son of God, the logos, comes down into the world and is born into the world. The Anointed One. I am a Christian, but even if I wasn't a Christian, you could say the Messiah, the Anointed One, the one that's chosen, the one that 's above. Remember that pillar that Jacob put up? Now, do you know why the pillar is a vertical now? You get that, right? It's like the pillar with the oil poured on that—the anointed one. That's the one, the middle, the center, the reference. Keep laying it on.
- 4.3 So the story of Christmas is that that person, the one that is all those things, is born in the world. What's interesting about the story is that he 's born as something like a seed that is hidden in the Earth. So he's born in a place that is like, there's no room for him in the world. So they go to the city, there's no room. He doesn't fit in the current system.
- 4.4 That makes sense because, in some ways, what he's wanting to do is to start a new thing. He 's going to start a new world. So in order for that to happen, there can't be room for him in the world that already exists because that's what he 's going to do. He's a new beginning. If you plant a seed in a tree, it's not going to grow. If you plant a seed in another plant, it's not going to grow. You have to plant a seed in the Earth so that you start a new being.
- 4.5 And so this is an image of the Nativity. This is one that I made myself, that I carved. In this image, it's a traditional Orthodox image of the Nativity, of the birth of Christ. And so if you look at it, you'll see some elements that I pointed to, and we'll come back to this one later. This one's in color. It's easier to get the elements. OK. So we have a mountain. OK, so the mountain is that hierarchy that moves up to heaven. Up above, it's broken up, but this is the glory of God.
- 4.6 Usually, sometimes it gets represented abstractly, as just a bunch of circles. Sometimes there's a hand. It doesn't matter. Say, it's God, but I can't represent him because he's beyond all the representations. So I put a signifier here. I put a mark, something here, so that you know that above is God. Now, already just basic, I know it's so obvious because we don't think about it, but the very fact that this image appears this way and that heaven is at the top of the image and Earth is at the bottom of the image, I know it reproduces the way we actually experience the world, but because we're in a reality

that is so twisted, we can forget that it's just a very simple structure. The actual image at the top of the image is heaven, and at the bottom of the image is Earth.

- 4.7 The top of the image is made of gold. It will be gilded because it represents things that aren't corrupted. It represents light. It represents all these things. It represents the top, the highest metal, the most precious metal —all these ways to get you to point towards what it is that's going on in the image, OK?
- 4.8 So what do you have above? You have the angels, you have the invisible beings, you have the invisible patterns of reality that are up above. It's completely coherent. It makes sense that the angels, they have wings. Angels don't actually have wings. But why do we say they have wings? Because they're in the heavens. Right? They're up there. There are these beings that are up there in the sky. These are all images to help us understand what it is that are these invisible patterns, these invisible beings, that legislate reality. They're like, they're principalities. They're like little princes that then legislate the rest of the world below. So they're above.
- 4.9 What do the angels do in the story? They sing, right? That's what they do. Here's, again, the same thing. You can represent it in different ways, by the way. So angels that sing, that are manifesting a pattern, a melody, a pattern of meaning from the heavens. Then in the story, there's another thing. There's a bunch of other people also that see something. Like these guys here, the wise men, they don't see, they don't hear angels singing, they see a star that's moving above. There's not much difference between those two things. Pretty much the same thing in terms of story structure. There's a pattern in the heavens that is showing us what is happening. It's showing us, it's giving us the pattern of reality. It's revealing to us that there's something important that is happening.
- 4.10 Of course, we don't believe in astrology. I get it, but there is something that moves in the heaven that tells you that something important is happening every day. It's called the sun. It comes up in the morning, and it tells you that you have to get up, and it tells you that you have to go through your day. We actually do use the heavens as a way to help you know when something important is happening. And it's the same with—it's like, that's how you calculate the dates, the days. In a world where you don't have printed calendars, you know when your birthday is, when the date of this celebration, it's all up there in the heavens. That's what's telling you what's going on and what's important.
- 4.11 And so that's what they see. They see a star above. Here's the star, right there. The star is there. Then the angels are there. You have the mountain. Then you have this nice vertical ray that goes all the way down and points to the baby. You can see it more. You can see better in my carving. You have this vertical ray that comes all the way down and points to the baby because the baby is that. It's the seed. It's the pattern that is now coming down into the world.

- 4.12 And it's hidden in the Earth. It's hidden in a cave. It's hidden in the Earth at the bottom of the world. How do you represent that? There's a bunch of ways. You put it in a cave. It's a good way. Another way is you make the place he's lying in a feeding trough for animals. If you want to get to the bottom of the world, you want it to really be at the bottom. So you say, he's born in a manger. By the way, everything I'm saying, I'm not—this is so hard for modern people. I'm not saying that this didn't happen because I'm giving meaning to it. It's very important. I'm not doing that. I really believe symbolism happens. I'm trying to show you that symbolism is the actual pattern of reality.
- 4.13 So I'm not suggesting that these things didn't happen. I'm trying to show you why they're completely coherent, and that there's nothing arbitrary about the way the story lays itself out. It's a completely coherent story that reveals to you the pattern of reality. So here is the manger. There are two animals. It's important, but we won't go into that there now. Then the mother, like a bowl, like a container, she's lying below as if he's still in her womb, almost. She's the cup in which the world is held. She's the Earth in which the seed is planted and out of which the seed will grow.
- 4.14 Down here, you have water. I told you a bit about the idea that the original Earth is water, so you have the baby being washed at the bottom of the image, which is actually not in scripture. But there's also another interesting bit there that's not in scripture, but it's interesting that it's there because what's going on here—you can see it better in mine. This is Joseph, and this is the devil. And the devil is disguised as a shepherd. He wears this hairy clothing, like he wears a garment of hairy skins. And the devil is bringing doubt to Joseph. And he's saying, "Is it really?" It's like, you know, "Whose son is this child? Is this really for real?"
- 4.15 So what you have at the bottom is a question. It's doubt. All of that is at the bottom—the image of water, question, doubt. But ultimately, the gift is him. Now, if you look at the way that the Christ child is represented in these, it's fascinating. Is that a manger? What do you think? What does it look like, let's say? It's a tomb. It's also a tomb. That's a really traditional understanding, is that it's already, in some ways, the place of death. In this image, it's suggested that, say, implicit in the incarnation itself, is the death and ultimately the resurrection is implicit in the very entering of Christ into the Earth, entering of Christ into the womb, entering of Christ into the world. So it's pretty cool. That's a lot of stuff in one image.
- 4.16 What's interesting about Christmas is that we have our own traditions and fascinating love—like, let's take the Christmas tree. What's interesting about the Christmas tree is that you'll have people arguing, people telling you this is a pagan practice. It comes from this or that. Who knows? It's some thing from Northern Europe and pagan, blah, blah, blah, whatever. The answer, what's interesting about looking at the world the way I'm trying to present it to you is, who cares? Who cares? What is it doing? What is it gathering together? And what is it gathering together towards? That's what's

important. The arguing over the historical origin of something is far less important than understanding, "Why was it selected in the first place?"

- 4.17** So think again on my biological example. Imagine the pagan world, or the world before Christmas appeared in that world, had all these traditions, maybe a hundred, thousand of traditions, and then, what has been selected to be brought forward, and why is it selected? There's a reason why it's selected. And that's more important than where it comes from. Where it comes from at this point then becomes a kind of potential out of which we gather things that fit with the identity of what it is we're trying to do. And the Christmas tree definitely does that.
- 4.18** So what do we put at the top of the Christmas tree? Or a star or an angel, obviously, right? You have to have a star or an angel at the top of the Christmas tree because it's the pattern. It's the singing angel that's showing you the pattern. It's the star that's pointing you, that's above and manifesting the pattern aspect of what is going on. Then what you have is, you have a pyramid. You have a mountain that moves from that star, from that point above, then it moves down into quantity. This tree, it's the world. It's the world with all its multiplicity. So you move from one and then all across here, you'll have a bunch of ornaments, a bunch of lights, a bunch of precious things, things that we think are beautiful, things that we think are precious, because they are held together in the world.
- 4.19** And it's the star and the purpose of putting up a Christmas tree is revealing, let's say, the light or the glorious aspect of reality. That's why lights are so important. Christmas, like, you want lights. Why? Because it's a revelation of something important that's happening, and the good way to represent that is light. It's not weird. There's nothing surprising about that. Imagine now this is your mountain, you move down, and then what do you have at the bottom? Often people would have the manger at the bottom, right? Put the manger there at the bottom, the manger scene with the shepherds, and Christ in the manger, and Mary and Joseph. It makes sense because it's that. It's like, you have that structure, then hidden under the structure, hidden in the Earth, hidden at the bottom of the world, you have the event that's actually happening.
- 4.20** But the event, the event that's a little baby being born in a manger, is the result of uniting all that together. It's the result of all that coming down into that spot. And you know, you can be cynical about that, that that's what's going on on that day. That's fine, but that's still what's being represented. How can I say this? It's like, 300 years after that, the whole Roman Empire converted to Christianity. So, whether you believe it or not, it's like, what happened down there in the manger secretly had all this in it. Took a while for you to see it, like a seed that has a plant to grow. It took a while for you to see it, but it happened. All the principalities and all the hierarchy that managed the entire world became aligned with this and this together.
- 4.21** It took a while, but it happened. Like I said, you can doubt that that's what was going on, but that's what happened. At the bottom now of the tree, you also have the gifts.

Now, what's important about the gifts is that they're hidden, they're secret, they're hidden in the Earth, you could say. When they will be revealed on the day of the birth, that's when the gifts will be revealed. There's this hidden thing. It's hidden in the Earth, and that the light—now I'm going to say it very religiously—the light of Christ will reveal the gifts, and they will reveal, say, what it should be, which is, will reveal the love we have for one another in giving each other things. It's like, that Christmas tree is beautifully and perfectly coherent with what Christmas is.

- 4.22 It has the same exact structure as this. Interestingly enough, this is an Eastern image from the Orthodox tradition. The Christmas tree is a German tradition, like a German-English tradition. It's not at all connected with this image. People that developed the Christmas tree had never seen this, never seen this image. But it's still, it's just, it implicitly ends up being the same structure, OK?
- 4.23 Now, let's take this guy right here. So now we have the same problem. Someone says, "Santa Claus was made up by Coca-Cola." Right, you've heard the thing. Santa Claus is made up by Coca-Cola. It's just a commercial thing, blah, blah, blah, blah. And you know, whatever. That's fine. The question again is, "Why does it stick?" That's the best way to think about it. Why does it stick? Think of the world as throwing up stories. Just stories being thrown up constantly, being proposed, being just tossed up. Then sometimes those stories stick. There's a reason. It's not arbitrary. It's not arbitrary why the stories stick. So the question is, why does it stick?
- 4.24 Now, honestly, I don't think that's true. Santa Claus is not just made up by Coca-Cola. Santa Claus has a very long history related to St. Nicholas and to figures that Father Christmas and all these figures that were joined together in America, gathered together. In ancient traditions, the Saint Nicholas was celebrated earlier in December. Then in America, it all got kind of slammed together. So Saint Nicholas, Father Christmas, all this, all Christmas. But interestingly enough, right, it all follows the right pattern. The whole thing is mythological. It has a perfect pattern in terms of what it is we're talking about.
- 4.25 OK, so where does Santa Claus come from? He comes from the North Pole. He comes from that axis. He comes from heaven. It's the best way to understand it. He comes from heaven. Then what is he doing? He's got these flying reindeers. Why are they flying? If I told you they were angels, I know it's a bit of a stretch, but it doesn't matter. They're flying. Why are they flying? They're flying above. They don't fly in the water. You fly above, you don't fly in the water. And what's fascinating about Santa Claus, by the way, is that Rudolf is a very recent addition. There's actually a copyright on Rudolf, by the way. You're not allowed to write a Rudolf, the Red-Nosed Reindeer story. It's like, it's copy-written. Someone in the 20s or something came up with this character.
- 4.26 But the question is, again, why did it stick? There's plenty of stories about Santa Claus. People wrote poems and stories about Santa Claus. Why did this one stick? It stuck because it made sense. But you need a light at the front of this. You need a light at the

front. You need a thing bright at the top of the pyramid. And then you need, hidden at the bottom, you need the hidden gifts that are hidden in the bag that aren't revealed yet. So I can help you. If you put it this way, it's easier to see. So it's like, you have your light above, then you have your jingling flying beings, and then you have Santa Claus and his hidden gifts in the sleigh. The sleigh is like a container. It's like a body. It's like a bowl that holds the gifts together.

4.27 Then it's not hard. You can look at a lot of other Christmas traditions. You'll see that it's the same thing. What does Santa do? How does he get into your house? Comes down the pole, comes down the vertical, comes down the ladder from heaven, and then comes down to the bottom of the world where it's soot and fire. Then he comes down there and he hides the gifts in that place, just like Christ hiding in the cave, just like the seed hidden in the earth. That's what's going on in that story.

4.28 So Santa Claus comes down, brings you the gifts. Then there's a nice little version of it right above. Again, same thing. It's like, why would you put gifts at the bottom of a sock? Isn't that weird? Isn't that strange? Does it still sound strange to you, though? There's nothing strange about that. How do you represent the bottom of reality? Let's just iterate them. It's like, oh, a manger, a place where animals eat. A cave, a place where it's dark at the bottom of the world. Just keep going. Then it's like, oh, at the bottom of your sock. That's a nice image of the bottom of reality. The actual hidden place where you touch the ground—we're going to put the gifts in there. Not bad. Completely coherent.

4.29 The older traditions about Santa are interesting, too, because there's a manner in which the —I'm going to show you. It's going to be a peek about what's coming tomorrow, or maybe I'll touch on it a little bit. So you have the ladder of heaven, and then you have heaven above. But the bottom part, the lower part, separates into two, separates into, let's say, the good and the bad, the right side, the wrong side, the right side, the left side. So there's this sense in which, let's say, the light which comes above, Christ is something like a judge. That which is above is something like a judge. And that, depending on how you embody the ideal, it'll appear as, say, mercy or judgment, or good or bad. So you have the church here, then you've got hell down here.

4.30 Well, that's happened to Christmas, too. The old traditions of Santa was that he would bring either two things. What did they put in the sock? Put an orange or a piece of coal. A nice, bright shiny ball or a dark, very dirty thing. It's like the process reveals the aspect of Christmas—like the light side, the gathering side, and also the dark side and the destructive side. You're going to ask me—but you won't, but you should —is that in the Christmas story? Do you know the Christmas story? What happens? What happens when King Herod finds out about Christ? The Christmas story has a very dark aspect to it. People sometimes forget.

4.31 So on the one hand, the seed is planted. On the one hand, there's a gathering of reality together that is the orange, the light side happening. And at the same time, there is the

killing of the innocent children that is happening at the same time. Christmas has two hands. That 's the best way to understand how Christmas works. In the Santa traditions, they actually have a—they sometimes have Santa and a darker character. Sometimes it's Santa and a demon called Krampus. This Santa moves and goes around the towns in Europe, and Santa gives gifts to the children, and Krampus is, like, whipping children.

- 4.32 So the idea that there's a judgment in the ideal, right. The ideal is also a judge because it decides what's in and out. That's what an ideal does. The ideal of the glass is the judge of the glass. It will judge whether or not it's a good glass. That's what happens with the top. That's what happens with heaven. Heaven can act as a judge. I understand that it's a moral question. People get annoyed because they're like, "God is bad because he judges us." But it's actually just structural, ultimately. Anything that draws you into it is also a judge. There's no way around it.
- 4.33 Think about something that you love. Think about playing a sport. You play basketball. You love basketball. Basketball is the ideal. It's this thing that's pulling you. It's this good that you are—it's like, is there anything as ridiculous as just bouncing a ball on the ground? That's completely ridiculous. It only makes sense if it's bound together into something higher. It's like, OK, dribbling makes sense in basketball. And so you're practicing this ridiculous thing because you're attracted towards a good that is drawing you towards it. So it's like, I learn to dribble, I learn to shoot, I learn to pass. I follow all these rules in order to aim at that good. But that good is also a judge, right?
- 4.34 Because if you don't embody the ideal, you lose. You're not going to win if you don't embody the ideal. If you're not able to embody the thing that's pulling you towards it, then it will act as a judge and will, let's say, at least send you to purgatory. At least send you into a loop of practice and improvement and wanting to now do more in order to embody the ideal, OK? Just kind of understand it as a—I'm not saying I don't want you to believe or not in purgatory, I just mostly want you to understand how these things are structured.
- 4.35 Now, the last thing about Christmas that's important to understand is, you've heard people say this, right? It's like, Christmas is just the solstice. Didn't you know that there's a solstice that happens at around Christmas? It's a few days off. But the sun in the sky moves with two patterns. Every day, there's a rotation. The sun comes up and goes down. But then through the year, the sun moves down in its arc and the days shorten. Then we move into winter. Then after that, the sun moves up in its arc, and then the days get longer, and then we have summer. So the solstice is the two extremes of that process. You have in 24th of June, when it's the longest day of the year, the sun goes as the highest in the sky, and you have the longest time of sunlight, and then you have the—it's not the 24th, it's around the 22nd or whatever. Then around the same time, 22nd of December, you have the shortest day of the year where the sun is the lowest in its arc. You know about how that works.

- 4.36 A lot of people in every culture, every culture in the world, they have a celebration around that time, which celebrates this heavenly phenomena. A lot of people have said, "Christmas is just solstice. It's just Christians take over the solstice celebration of other cultures," and it's like, that's what Christmas is. The answer is, "Who cares?" Seriously, who cares? Because what's going on? Is it coherent? First of all, it's actually not true in terms of mechanical causes. The date of Christmas was not chosen at all in relation to the solstice. It has to do with a tradition at the time when they thought that important people died the same day they were conceived.
- 4.37 If you look at the very early church, the Annunciation of Christ, is very, very close to the death of Christ, but it changes because of the weird calendar thing. But the idea is that, at the very beginning, it was the same, seen as the same day. If you go 9 months from that, you come to December 25th. It's like, and so that's how they calculated it. But still, it's great that it's on the solstice because it totally follows the story of the solstice. It's a perfect image. What happens? The sun is going down, the sun is becoming hidden, the days are getting shorter, the sun is moving down towards the Earth, is becoming hidden.
- 4.38 So you can think about it like—imagine like, you never—imagine you had never seen that happen in the sky ever before. Now the sun, you notice that the days are getting shorter and shorter and shorter, shorter. It's like, what's going to happen? Is the sun just going to vanish? Is the sun just going to go away? But there's a trick that happens, which is that, on the day of the solstice, then the day starts to increase. But the thing is, you don't notice it right away. You can't tell. It 's still the darkness, but something's happened in secret. Some secret thing that you don't know what has happened, which is now making the day get longer. There's this ascent which is starting from the secret place. Think of it like the sun. Sun is going down into a cave, and now the sun is going to come out of that cave, and the days are going to get longer.
- 4.39 Christmas is that moment. It's that hidden seed, that hidden new pattern, that hidden new year that is just starting, but that hasn't been fully expanded yet. Then after that, in the early Christian tradition, you had these festivals of lights. About a week or two weeks after that, you'd have these, at the end of the Christmas season, you had what's called theophany, or epiphany, which is the revelation of Christ, the revelation of the light. You had the image of all the moments where people see Christ, the baptism, the three mages, but also the wedding of Cana. All of these were celebrated as, like, now everybody sees the source of this.
- 4.40 There's a complete coherence, and it just happens. I don't think it just happens, but it follows the natural pattern of how the world lays itself out. It follows the way the lights in the heavens move and the way in which the year has a natural order to it that manages our lives. Because you can imagine that for us, because we have electric lights, we don't notice it as much. For the ancients, this was primordial. It was so

important—that this cycle, to live in this cycle, and what it did to how they perceived their experience in this cycle.

- 4.41 All right, so I wanted to just kind of give you a sense of how that works. Just the basic pattern. I gave you the image of Christmas. I could have probably given you—I gave you the image of a church. I could have given you so many others. It doesn't really matter. It's good to point to one that has a good concentration because you can see it more powerfully. But this is something that you'll find in most structures, you could say, that you can be able to notice it. So the last thing I want to talk to you about today is what I just hinted at in terms of the orange and the coal, which is that you have the center, you have the spokes, you have the periphery, you have the mountain, you have the top, you have the slope, and you have the bottom.
- 4.42 But what you also need in order for this to function is you need something like a concentric and eccentric force. I use the word force. Don't worry about the word force. Just follow as we move towards the example, you'll get a sense of what I mean. You need something which is moving you towards the middle and something which is moving you away from the middle, or a way to move towards the middle and a way to move away from the middle. The eccentric force moves towards multiplicity, variation, difference, all of that. And the concentric force moves towards identity, heaven, purpose, all that as well.
- 4.43 But you need both. You need both a concentric and an eccentric force for things to exist. You can't just have things pulling towards the identity because you need a body. You need the multiplicity to hold the identity in it. So you always need an eccentric force and a concentric force. In the example I gave you about the development of antibodies, you have an eccentric force, which is this explosion of multiplicity. It's just like, we don't know what we're doing. We're just proposing variations, variation, variation, variation, variation. Then all of a sudden, it's like that. Now there's a concentric force. The concentric force is a constraining of variability. That's the best way to understand it. It's just a constraining of variability. It's like, no, in this. Then it's pushing. Think of the pyramid almost like pushing, pushing, pushing. It's moving things up towards their purpose.
- 4.44 But they still have to be embodied. But there is no—how can I say this? There's no pure antibody. An antibody has a shape. It has those little arms or whatever. It has a reality to it. You always have to have a balance between those two. So I showed you this. Now you can see it in this image. You can understand it that way, right? You have the concentric force in this one, moving towards the purpose. Now in this one, you have the eccentric force, the devils that are bringing you into hell. That's a positive-negative, right. That's often the way that we understand it.
- 4.45 So this is an image of the Last Judgment, one of the first images of the Last Judgment. And Christ gives this image. He says, "When the Son of Man, when the Son of Man returns, he will gather all together and he will separate them to the sheep. He will say,

'Come into my kingdom.' And to the goats, he will say, 'Move away from me.'" Now you have those two sides. You have a concentric side moving towards the center, and you also have an eccentric side moving away from the kingdom.

- 4.46 This is, let's say, a fuller version of the Last Judgment in which you see this happen cosmically. Remember before I showed you that other image where there was the church at the bottom and the hell at the bottom? So now you have the same situation. Here at the bottom, you have paradise, in terms of the idea of the garden. Here on the left, you have the fire. Then you have Christ at the top. Then Christ, with his hand, with his right hand, he's pointing up. He's, let's say, bringing up. You can understand concentric also as moving up the ladder, going up towards the purpose for the identity. And eccentric also as going down the ladder, moving away from identity.
- 4.47 On this right side, you have all these images of gathering. You have Abraham with all his children in his bosom, which is a weird image. In the Bible, there's this image that the paradise is the bosom of Abraham, that people are gathered in his bosom. You think, what a weird image. It's just so strange. But think about it in terms of gathering. It's not a strange image if you understand it. If you understand that—remember I told you about that just regular hierarchy of procession, of military hierarchy, or whatever? But you can understand that as just generations. You have a single father, Abraham. Abraham has children. Those children have children, and they just keep spreading, and it becomes a pyramid of Abraham's children, where the further you go and they get differentiated.
- 4.48 At first, it's Abraham and his sons, and then they get separated into 12, and then those 12 become 12 tribes. Those 12 tribes continue to separate. And so you have this hierarchy. And so the idea is, how can you represent the concentric image? How can you represent moving into heaven, moving into paradise, moving into the middle? It's a very nice image. It's like going back into our father. We're gathered back into our father. It's just an image, but you can understand why it makes sense, why it is a beautiful image of gathering and moving towards above, moving towards that which is our common origin, out of which this procession manifests itself. OK?
- 4.49 And so then you have Mary, who gathered into her womb also, who gathered the Christ into her womb and becomes the mother of the church, the mother of all, in the sense that she gathered reality into herself so that the seed could come from above and manifest inside her. Right so, just so you kind of see that this is this sense of concentration, of ascension, all of this is going on on the right side of Christ. It's opposite from you. What's going on here is the right side of Christ. What's going on here is the left side of Christ. It's a cosmic image. On the right of him is the sun. On the left is the moon. Can you understand why? Why would the sun be on the right and the moon be on the left?
- 4.50 The sun is the source of light. The moon is the mirror of light. So think about the sun and water. You have the light above, and then you have the light reflected in the

myriads of things that are below. A beautiful image of that is the moon itself because the moon is actually a mirror for the sun. But not only that, the moon is variation. That's what the moon is, because the moon shifts and moves from light to dark in itself. In the sun, you have a different thing because the sun, when it's there, it's light; when it's not there, it's dark. But the moon's not like that. The moon has that wave in it. It has that shift. It has that change from light to darkness in itself. So it's a perfect image of variation, of multiplicity, of change. Of change is a good way to understand it.

- 4.51 And down here, what we have are people that are tortured by their secondary goods. It's the best way to understand that—is that the people that end up down here are people that have taken secondary goods as being primary, have not been properly attached to the highest good. Because of that, the highest good judges them. The highest good acts as a judge to them. So think about—a good example for this would be, let's say, modern design. Think about like wild, you've seen like wild modern designs of chairs, where the chair is designed by some designer, and the purpose of the designer is not actually to design a good chair. The purpose of the designer is to attract attention to his chair, to attract attention to himself. Then what happens is you have very uncomfortable chairs that people maybe want to look at, but that nobody wants to sit in.
- 4.52 And so the chair—you could say that that's the chair that's moving towards hell because the good of the chair is judging it. How is it judging it? People don't want to sit in it. It's pretty simple. It's not arbitrary. It's not magic. It's like, the good of the chair is judging it because it's not playing the proper role that it's supposed to play.
- 4.53 If I become a slave of gambling or a slave of eating or a slave of sex, then that good is not playing the proper role. And so the highest good, because I'm not an idiot, I know—the guy who gambles his money away doesn't feel good about it. He knows that he's destroying his family. He's destroying his friendships. He can't help it, but he knows what he's doing. He's not unaware. That good that he knows is the right good is going to burn him. What else could it do? You don't have to even imagine it as an active thing. It can even be almost portrayed as a passive thing, where the very good that he knows is the right thing to do, if you don't do it, it'll burn you. If you stay attached to these lower goods, it will burn you.
- 4.54 So that is the fragmentation, the breakdown, that happens below. It's interesting. It's nice because it's imaged as the actual mouth of a beast, like the actual mouth of the Leviathan or some creature. The image here that represents the mouth of hell is based on the fish of Jonah. Some of the early images of Jonah's fish that comes up from below and swallows him up, swallows him up. That's what this image is based on—the mouth of hell. The thing is that there's also—so if you look out now above, you've got the disciples that are spread into two.
- 4.55 Now it's interesting because you also have Mary and John the Baptist there. That's actually probably a good way to understand it because, at first glance, what it looks like

is that the concentric is only good and the eccentric is only bad. But in the image, if you look at it more carefully, you'll realize that there's other things going on as well, and that the concentric is her, the eccentric is him. We'll just look at these two. We could look at others, but if we look at these two, you'll understand it. You'll see that, in this case, it's not, it's not good or bad. It just is. That's just how it works.

4.56 So she's down here already, the right. Now she's brought up here, same person. She is the one that gathers together. She's the one that—she also has this compassion, let's say. She represents mercy and compassion. She's the one that gathers. You could say—I'm sure, even if you're not Catholic, just pay attention to the structure, at least to understand it. She gathers our prayers, too. She brings them. She prays for us in that way. She gathers us together. She is an image of the church that is also the gathering of the people. That's where we come together. We manifest the body of Christ. She's an image of the body as this gathering. All of this is like, yeah, she's the right one to be on the concentric side of this equation.

4.57 This guy here, what does he do? He's out in the desert, in the wilderness. He's where there is no place. The wilderness is where there is no place. It's just vagueness, the vagueness of wilderness. That's where he is, and he's screaming, and he's telling people, judging them, in the wilderness, and he wears hairy animal skins at the same time. He also eats grasshoppers and honey, which is part of this. It's harder to understand the grasshoppers and honey, but you can maybe understand it, if you think of—if you know your Bible a bit, in the Old Testament, God says to Moses, God says to, I think he even says to Abraham, says, "I will bring you in a land of milk and honey."

4.58 What's that? Why milk and honey? It's the two sides. It's the two sides. It's actually these two sides. It's milk and honey. Milk is the nourishing food that comes from the mother. It's the one that comes from the very place that you came from. You came out of that body, and now the food is coming out from the same thing. It's exactly this beautiful image of togetherness or this closeness, OK? And honey—it's made by things that hurt you. It's made by things that buzz around and sting you and hurt you. It's a very, the very image of the wild.

4.59 If you still don't believe me, Samson has a great image, in the story of Samson, where he finds honey in the carcass of a dead lion. If you want an image of that side, it's like, there's a beautiful, powerful image of that side. First of all, he finds sweetness in a dead thing. Second of all, it's the honey. It's made by these things that sting you. And third of all, even for Jews, a lion would have been an impure animal that you couldn't consume. And so it's like, this is the secret of the eccentric side, you could say.

4.60 And John the Baptist represents exactly that. And how did he die? He's split apart. That's how he dies. He gets his head cut off. You could say that in that, you get this sense of what we call the right hand and the left hand. So you have to understand the right hand. It's good because most of you, not all of you, most people are right-handed. Your right hand used to be, traditionally, in almost every culture, right hand is

the hand you eat with. Right hand is the hand you use to bring things towards you. The left hand was the hand you cleaned yourself with. I won't do the gesture, but it's the hand that you pushed your things away from you. Pushed the things that had to be pushed away from you was the left hand. It's a very coherent thing.

- 4.61 It also happens that the right hand is the hand that you control very much, and the left hand is the hand that you don't control very well. The right hand, even the word right often means straight. If you think of orthodontist, making teeth straight, where ortho is right, the right hand. And left, in many languages, means crooked. It's like this thing that's off. Awkward. The word "awkward" comes from "awk", and awk is an old, I think, English word for left.
- 4.62 So you have concentric, eccentric. You have straight control, then you have, let's say, the breaking of control. You have a variation, lack of the capacity to hold on. It's like it's built in your body. It's not something that was made up just by people. It emerges from the very structure of our being. Now, think about it. Let me show you one more image. I hope we got time.
- 4.63 The problem with the left and the right hand, which makes it often difficult to understand it, is that it depends on your position. That's why if I shake your hand, I'm going to cross over like this. If I'm standing in front of you, my right hand is your left side, and your right hand is my left side. It totally depends on your position. But it's important to understand it in terms of transformation of how things are transformed into other things. Because in order—
- 4.64 So let's say, think of Alexander the Great. Alexander the Great goes and he founds his empire. He's gathering things into his name. He's gathering things into his identity. How does he do that? Is that how it's experienced by the people that are on the other side? No, it's the opposite. They experience it as a breakdown, as a loss of what they have. It's like when Alexander comes to the Persian king and he's like, "I'm taking over this place," that means that the Persians or the Egyptians or the Greeks are losing their identity to Alexander. All right?
- 4.65 So gathering is always a loss of identity of that from which it's gathered. This basic image of heaven and earth that we saw at the beginning, it's a total image. But in reality, there's always a play. It's a fractal. There's always a play. So if I eat an orange, by the time that I've ingested it, it's not an orange anymore. It's me. But in order to do that, I have to break down its identity, necessarily. And so that, to some extent, happens in a little way at every level. This idea that it crosses over, that the gathering into one thing is necessarily a breakdown of the other. The breakdown of one thing will feed something else. That's how this play is happening.
- 4.66 Think about, once again, let's say you're playing basketball. You're playing a basketball team. You have a bunch of individuals. So you have all these different allegiances. You have all these things that characterize you, that identify you. But now you want to

become a basketball player. Now, you will necessarily have to break your allegiances to the other things that you were a body for, in order to play this game. Let's say, I don't know, you play video games. You like playing video games. It's like, you're a body for this thing, this purpose. You're playing video games, spending a lot of time like, I want to do something else. You necessarily have to remove yourself. You have to cut yourself. You have to break that in order to participate in this other thing.

4.67 That happens fractally, which means that when you go to basketball practice, don't call your girlfriend. You have to give up your allegiance to the thing that you're attaching yourself to. And it's not an absolute thing. Once you leave that hierarchy, once you leave practice, then sure, you call your girlfriend. But don't, if you're on the court talking to your girlfriend on the phone, it 's not going to work. That play, that play of concentration and breakdown, that play of moving into the many and moving towards the one, is this breathing. It's a breathing of reality. It's actually true at the most basic level, which is breathing itself. That's what breathing is.

4.68 I inhale, exhale. My heart gathers the blood in, pushes the blood out. The blood goes out into the extremities, and then it's gathered back in. It moves out. It's just really the basic, basic rhythm of how reality works. It 's moving in and out of identities. It happens. It's a complex process. It happens at many levels at the same time. But you need to understand that, to be able to understand the basic structure, the basic mountain. Let me get to the mountain here. Let's do it with this. This is a good example that can help you understand how it works. It'll be a last example.

4.69 So you have the top of the mountain, which is the church, the steeple of the church. It is the common point of attention. It's the thing that we know that that's the center. That's the place where we manifest the patterns of who we are. We get baptized, we get married, we get buried. All of this is happening through this thing which gives me identity and binds me together with the others. And so I go up here and then I go to confession. I try to extirpate myself from all the parasitic patterns, all the little patterns that are holding on to me. I try to break away from them, so that I can go into this place and I can now move towards the purpose that I recognize as being the highest good.

4.70 That happens both in myself because I have to go through these different sacraments, but it also happens among each other. We literally come closer together, like the spokes of the wheel, in this building, to be together and to sing together and to have our attention focused on the same thing, to celebrate the same thing. All of this is binding us together. Then the priest comes out, gives us a pattern, tells us how to live our lives, gives us some moralism or whatever, but gives us a pattern. Like, "You should do this, you should do that." It's annoying, right? Nobody likes that, but that's how it works. You have to get your pattern and the way in which you embody.

4.71 So then you go there, and you do that. And then what do you do? Then you move away, you leave from the church, and you go back down into your life, into your practice. You try to carry as much as you can from that into the rest of your life. But

naturally, the reality of being far away from the purpose, the reality of moving out into the world, will start to, let's say, dilute the effect or dilute that which bound you together. So that 's why you have to constantly re-engage. It's like every week, everybody goes back, gets that cohesion, moves out, moves out into the world, does all their multiple things, does all these things that are eccentric, that are good. If they're still connected as much as possible to that.

4.72 You're a baker, you're honest, you make good bread, you serve your neighbor, you do all this stuff, you're a cobbler, you make good shoes. All of that is going on. But it is possible that you go out here and then you start to manifest things that are not connected or that are disconnecting. Then you start stealing, you start cheating on your wife, you start doing all these things that are breaking down the unity that you 're supposed to find up at the top.

4.73 So that's this breathing in and breathing out, this rhythm that happens during the week. It's the same rhythm that happens during the day, from waking up to going to sleep, to waking up to going to sleep. This is the rhythm of reality. If you don't understand the waking up and going to sleep, it's not complicated. You wake up, enter into consciousness, you enter into activities, and then you move out of consciousness, you go into death, and then you start over the next day. It's like, it is very much this breathing in and breathing out.

4.74 So hopefully you can see a little bit how this crosses over and how this applies as much to this kind of beautiful image of a village and a church and everything together, but how it applies to something as simple as playing basketball or engaging in your daily life. So tomorrow, we're going to do some—we're going to do a bit more—let's say we're going to look into maybe some movie interpretations. I'll try to show you how this can apply even to pop culture and to even understanding politics. Look at the right and the left. You'll see that it actually strangely fits with what we're talking about.

4.75 So see you tomorrow. Thanks for your time.

Lecture 5: Fractal Narratives

At a glance — Fractal narratives: pushing the basic symbolic structure hard to show how stories nest and repeat at every scale.

- 5.1** I am going to push what we've been looking at for the past few days. I'm going to push it pretty hard. And so we're going to take the basic structure. I just kind of mentioned, gave you some analogies. Heaven, Earth, masculine, feminine, and how this can kind of come together as this image of a mountain, this image of a wheel. Tried to make it a little more, very simple, and in some ways, it is very simple. But the problem is that it's a fractal structure.
- 5.2** What I mean by fractal is that, you know, I talked about this ladder and how you have these different levels of things that fit into each other, the military hierarchy, how it all fits in. Now, the structure is, let's say heaven and Earth, and then it's heaven and Earth, heaven and Earth, heaven and Earth, heaven and Earth, all the way through. So because of it, it can be confusing at the outset when you look at the basic structure. Right?
- 5.3** So a good idea would be, OK, so let's say, I think about it and I go, heaven and Earth. OK, so you have the king above and the kingdom below. It's like, oh, that makes sense, right? You have a point above. He's the person everybody kind of looks towards. He's set aside. He's different. He, he's the principal. He's the prince above the masses. And so everybody can see him. He kind of sees the layout.
- 5.4** He doesn't know everybody in the kingdom, but the people in the kingdom know him. You're like, oh, yeah, that makes sense. Like, I can get that. I can see that. But then you think, OK, well, then, what's a queen, then, huh? That's complicated, right? Because I said, OK, masculine, feminine. So how, what's the relationship to something like a queen? And it's actually a good way to understand it. The best way to understand it is that there's something like a coupling at every level of the hierarchy.
- 5.5** So if you understand heaven and Earth, or masculine feminine, it's going to happen everywhere. And so a good way to understand it would be that every place that heaven meets Earth is something like a coupling, right? A place where the principle or the meaning or the purpose or whatever encounters some level of body, some level of embodiment, and then that point here will look like heaven for the part underneath, right?
- 5.6** It's like, it'll always kind of look like—so it sounds complicated. It's not that complicated. Right? You are a soldier. You have your corporal or your leader, who is something like the influence of heaven on you, but he's also something like Earth for that which is above him. Does that make sense? Because all the corporals will get together, and then the person above them will tell them what to do, and then they'll go back down, and then they'll tell all the people down there what to do.

- 5.7 And so that's how this coupling happens at every level. And so that appears, of course, structurally, if I talk about the military, but it appears imagistically. And that's why, sometimes when you're trying to interpret stories, you're trying to interpret images, if you're not able to think that way, it'll be difficult.
- 5.8 Remember yesterday, I talked about this grand structure? I brought you here on Mont Saint-Michel, and I talked about this grand structure, right? The whole city moving up to a point, the church in the middle. And then in the church, you've got the same hierarchy repeated, and you move all the way up to the altar, and there's the priest standing at the center of the center of the center. And then he lifts up. What does he lift up? He lifts up a little round piece of bread. And he lifts up a cup, and he puts them like this, right? With a little piece of bread above the cup. What is he, what is that?
- 5.9 So you've got it right down in the middle, the same thing, something like the sun, something like the heaven, which is round above, and then the cup, which is feminine, which is the Earth or whatever. So you have the seed, the cup, right in the very middle as this original coupling. OK, does that make sense? Now, this happens, you know, it happens in every version of this, and you just kind of have to see it. It's difficult sometimes to see it.
- 5.10 If you know, if you know the Bible a little, a little, you'll know about the tabernacle. The tabernacle in the Bible has the same structure. You have this hierarchical structure where all the people are outside, and then you have a certain amount of priests a little bit more inside. And the priest, the priest, right, the high priest at the very inside middle of the, like, the holy of holies in the church. And then what does he have in front of him? He has a box with the glory of God descending on the box.
- 5.11 So he has the influence of heaven, which comes down, and you have a box which is something like the Earth, which is a container at the bottom, right? The same thing as the priest who's got the cup, and he's holding the bread from heaven above it. All right, so this structure is going to be—so that's what this idea, this fractal idea, is what makes it more complicated, but it's also what makes it richer. And if you can see it that way, then you really will be able to understand the stories and the different, the different elements.
- 5.12 And it's also positional, right? Everything is positional. That is, everything is just in their place and isn't necessarily a moral question. It can be a moral question, but it's not always a moral question. OK? And so, for example, if you think about the edge of the wheel, right, or the edge of the city, and I gave you this image, for example, that right on the edge of the city, what you have on the edge will be the bad guys or the thieves or the—why do you have a wall? You have a wall because you're trying to protect the city from another army, from people coming to rob the city or whatever. And so you've got this edge, and then on the edge, you'll have soldiers that are looking out, and then you'll have soldiers that are looking in.

- 5.13** You'll have the soldiers from the bad army coming to attack, and you have the soldiers from your army standing on the border looking out. And it's positional. That is, the soldiers on your side and the soldiers on their side have more in common than the soldiers have in common with the king or the priest. They're very similar in nature. It's just that one's facing in and one's facing out.
- 5.14** A prison guard has more in common with the prisoner than with the person who's sitting at home watching TV. It's a positional question. And once you get that, some of the things will—sometimes it'll be easier to understand the stories or the different way in which things happen, let's say. OK, all right, keep that in mind. We're going to, going to give you two basic concepts. One is that fractal idea where everything's positional and everything is coupling all the way through. And then the second one is going to—I'm going to complexify for you this right hand and this left hand problem, right?
- 5.15** So you have a concentric force which is moving towards the center, moving towards identity, moving towards the one. Then you have an eccentric force, which is moving away from identity, away from the one. The problem with this is what I told you yesterday, is that it crosses over. And so eccentric and concentric will look like opposites even within—like, they look different depending on which way you're looking at it. So if you think of a concentric force, right? So if you look at the graphic, you'll notice it. So if I have a concentric force, I'm bringing things towards myself. What I'm doing is I'm trying to solidify myself, OK? I'm trying to gather things into myself to make, to stabilize my identity.
- 5.16** So think about it like, that's why you eat food. That's why, let's say, you have someone that you want to—a stranger. So it's like, I will get to know you so that you'll be in communion with me, and that will solidify us. Like, it'll solidify something, right? So that's why I want to get to know you, OK? But in order to do that, I have to loosen myself towards you, right? I have to open myself to you. So it'll appear as solidifying myself but as mercy at the same time.
- 5.17** So you have the, you have the hand of Christ, who says to the sheep, you know, "Come into the kingdom," and he's exercising mercy, but he's also solidify—he's solidifying, stabilizing. So sometimes this, this, let's say, this right hand that goes out can have a, let's say, a solid image. It can look like something solid, and it can also look like loosening, depending on what you're doing, depending on from which perspective you see it. And the same thing happens to the other side.
- 5.18** So let's say, it's an eccentric force. So I'm saying, "Get away from me. I want you to move away from me." So when I do that, I'm pushing you away. So it's harsh, right? It's a harsh hand. I'm not opening myself up. I'm closing myself away. I'm closing myself from you. But what that does is that makes you move away. It makes you broken in terms of my, my identity, right? You're less connected to me. And so if you look at the image of the Last Judgment, you have that sense.

- 5.19** So Christ says, "Go down. Go away." And then what happens? So this is the harsh hand. It's the hand of rigor. But then what happens here is a dissolution, a people that are, let's say, broken into their passions. So the left hand can appear as, let's say, drunkenness or, you know, like sexual depravity and all these things that are kind of breaking apart. But it can also look harsh if you look at it from the side of the rule or the side of the judge that is operating its rigor. And so they're related together, right? You can understand it like, someone who breaks down and is not able to hold together, is falling apart in terms of their personal life—well, the rule or the purpose will appear as harsh to them, but what's actually happening to them is that they're falling apart.
- 5.20** On the other hand, someone who's trying to do it right, trying to follow the rules, trying to aim, trying to go towards the rule, well, then the rule will appear or the ideal will appear as opening and as merciful towards them. Right. So it looks like something that's contradictory, but it's actually very, very simple. It's so simple that it's actually hard to see because it's very simple. But it helps. So this can help you understand a lot of politics. A lot of politics you can understand by this.
- 5.21** What happens in the discourse? It's funny because people on the left are saying people on the right are controlling. They're tyrannical. They want to control everything. Then people on the right look at people on the left and they say they're tyrannical. They're controlling. They want to control everything. What the hell's happening? How can that be possible? It has to do with this crisscrossing. Has to do with this crisscrossing.
- 5.22** So think of something like above and below. Think about something like, I'll give you the —I'll just talk it through you, and you're also going to start to see it. So the person on the right says, "We should free up all the regulations for business. You know, like, people should just do their business. There shouldn't be all these taxes. There shouldn't be all these regulations and taxes. The government shouldn't control the way that we handle the economy."
- 5.23** But the person on the right is saying, "You know, I think abortion's wrong and I think traditional marriage —you should marry someone from the opposite sex and you should have kids and you should live your life this way." The person on the left is completely flipped. The person on the left says, "You can live whatever, however you want. Just do whatever you want. There's no rules on behavior. Like, do whatever you want. But we should definitely control the money, right? We should control the income. We should control the taxes, which should regulate the way people do business."
- 5.24** So can you see how it crosses? And the same, both sides have a harsh side and a soft side, but they're crossed over. They kind of flip this way. And so the same, and so the person on the right will say, it's like, "I'm a libertarian." Sometimes they'll say something like that. It's like, "I'm libertarian. We should have few rules, you know. We should have not too much police, not too much control over our private lives. But then it's like, put a wall on the border, though, right? Stop the people on the outside from

coming in because they're the ones that dangerous. The people in our community, they're safe, like we know each other. That's why we get along. Figure it out. But stop people from the outside."

5.25 The left is completely flipped. Same. Completely flipped. "Family is dangerous. Religion is dangerous. All these local things, they're racist. They're dangerous because they have an identity. What's really good is being open to others. You should be open to others. You open to people outside. And so open the border. Let everybody come in."

5.26 And that's good because our identities are tyrannical. So you can see how it flips. And the thing is that, once you understand that, you realize that both of them are just seeing one side of the equation and they can't see the full picture. Maybe we need both of them to be able to see the full picture. Because is it true that identity can be tyrannical? Of course it can. We talked about that yesterday. Especially if identities aren't bound up in higher goods, right? So certain identities, whether its tribal identities, whether it's, you know, certain hierarchical positions, the idea that "because I'm in higher status or whatever, that's what makes me important"—that can be very dangerous if it's out of control.

5.27 So identity can become something like tyrannical. But it's also true that, without identity, you can't exist. So the other side is looking and saying, "Well, you can't just let everybody from the outside in because it's a flood. We'll basically just stop existing if that happens." And so it's like I said, understanding how this crosses over will be very helpful for you to understand the political discourse because sometimes if you don't have that vision, if you don't understand this relationship of right and left in a more like, let's say, in a more meaning sense, sometimes it's confusing.

5.28 It's like, why is one side, it's just one side's on one side of the issue, on the other side of the issue. It's like, why is it that—a good example—why is it that the right sees abortion not as a question of freedom, right, but as a question of, let's say, moral code that should be followed? What they'll see, they'll see the economic question as a question of freedom and not being related to a moral code. And it has to do with this strange crossover that you'll see. And so you can work it out. I just gave you a few examples. You can work it out on your own. Try to think about it. Try to find examples. Hopefully, this will help you to get a sense.

5.29 All right. And so now what we're going to do, we're going to start to apply all of this down a little bit into the stories. So this is the basic structure, basic pyramid. Has everybody heard about what's called the hero's journey? Right? Everybody's heard about that? And so the hero's journey is like a basic, a basic story structure that's based on Jungian archetypes that was kind of, was developed by several people, and it's the basis of many stories. So you have the main character, the main character moves. He's in a stable place, like he's somewhere, and then he gets a call to move out of where he is, and then there'll be all these different steps.

- 5.30 He moves out. He goes down into darkness, down into chaos, down into a kind of abyss with some help along the way. And then he will come back up and then return. And he doesn't totally return to the same place. He usually returns —sometimes he can return to a higher place. He can return with something, some kind of prize, some kind of boon that he's gotten.
- 5.31 So Star Wars is based strictly on the hero's journey. It was really George Lucas met even with Campbell, Joseph Campbell, who developed this idea. And they actually worked together somewhat on the Star Wars story. So Luke is a great example, right? He's this innocent young man who lives on a planet with his uncle and his aunt. And then he gets this call, right? This call from Obi-Wan to leave where he is, to kind of engage on this path, and he hesitates. And then tragedy happens, right? Everybody dies. His family dies.
- 5.32 He's pulled into this world of monsters and chaos, and he ends up even in, in the trash compactor. He's down in the abyss. The trash compactor scene is a great example. He's in the trash, he's in the water. He's down in the deeps of the world. And then through help of Yoda, through a mentor, he's able to kind of reach up, defeat the evil empire. And then they end with Princess Leia giving him the medal. And now he's kind of in this moment of glory where he's back in the place where things are stable, but he's brought —he succeeded. He brought things with him.
- 5.33 Now, this is really complicated. You've got all these little steps and everything, and they've made it very, very detailed. But really, it's just this. This is the story. Like, this is actually pretty much every story. You have a mountain. You have a descent. You have an ascent back up on another mountain. OK? You can understand it this way. And so if you think of the levels, the structure, and the analogies that I gave you yesterday, you will realize that that's what happens.
- 5.34 The character starts with a certain type of stability and identity. You know, something hold, that holds together. Then something will happen that will break that unity. Some monster attacks, something happens, this village gets burned, whatever. All kinds of things can happen that will call the person out of that stable moment, and then they will descend into the unknown. That will usually mean sometimes actually leave, going far away from where they are. It means encountering things that they don't understand yet. It means encountering monsters. Hostility.
- 5.35 And the monsters are really important, by the way. Do you know what a monster is? Ask that. What's a monster? Something like that. Yeah. Why is monster chaos? So you know what a cat is, right? You know what a glass is? Do you know what a monster is? It's a monster. It's not one thing, is it? A monster is actually not, it's not, it's not a species, right? It's a category of things. It's a category of things that don't have a name. It's the best way to understand it—that don't have an identity. So monsters are always a mixture of different things, or too much or too little. Too much of something. Too

little of something, or else a mixture of things together. That's how you recognize a monster.

- 5.36 So if you—if I just put a normal person in front of you and I say, "That's a monster," you'll be like, "Yeah, well, maybe in his heart or whatever," but obviously, like, he doesn't look like a monster. And there's a way in which also a monster is not totally, like a, like a moral thing, right? It's just, it's like a—the monster presents itself in a certain manner. And so the dragon is a mixture of a lizard, right? A snake, a bird, a bat, sometimes even like a mammal. Like, the medieval dragons were really, very clearly a mix between a mammal, a snake, and a bird with wings together.
- 5.37 And so it's like, it's not one thing. It's like a bunch of things. Then you have giants, right? They're just too much. Or you have leprechauns or little beings that are too little. So it's actually identity that's off, right? Identity that doesn't come together properly. And sometimes it's just about unknown. Sometimes just because I've never seen it before, because I've never seen it before, at first it presents itself as a monster, and then I will tame it, and then I'll get to know it, let's say.
- 5.38 And so the best way to understand that is the stranger question. If you've ever—I'll give you a little experience. Most people have had that experience before. You meet someone, you're talking with them, and they have a stranger's face. You could say, they have a certain face. And as you're talking, you realize, wait a minute, I know this person. Then you recognize them. If you've had that experience, the face, their face will change. Your experience of their face will actually change so much that you won't remember the way you saw them before.
- 5.39 I had a crazy experience. My brother sent me a video, and he said, "Watch this video." And I'm kind of watching, like, "What is this stupid video?" And so I'm like, I stopped watching. And then he wrote me again, so "watch the video." So I'm watching the video, and I'm watching it. It's like a 15-minute video. Then at some point during the video, a name appears at the bottom of the screen, identifying the person. And I realized it's my cousin that I hadn't seen in, like, 15 years. And then all of a sudden, I see her, and I'm like, "Oh, that's my cousin. Of course it's my cousin." And, like, I totally recognize her.
- 5.40 And that's the difference between a monster and something you know. Right? It's the difference between a stranger and that which—you know, a stranger is very similar in terms of the category of monster, right? A stranger is not a species. A stranger is not a, it's not a tribal identification or racial identification. It just means that that's not that which is not me. That's all it means. So you could have —there's an indefinite amount of strangeness, an indefinite amount of strangers, right? It's a category of knowledge. It's not a category—it's not the same kind of category as a taxonomical category, right? As bird, fish, and all that, OK?

- 5.41 But it's very important because that's what happens as you move down the mountain, right? Identity becomes less and less clear. The connection to the point, to the reason, becomes less and less obvious. And so you can imagine something like, you can imagine something like a glass, and it has a clear identity. And you can imagine that this glass can be stretched, right? And you can have another category next to it.
- 5.42 Let me give you a better example. Like, you have a chair. That's a category. Then you have a couch. That's a category. And there's a way—you don't know how exactly; it's not totally clear—but you have a way that you know that one's a chair, one's a couch. You can stretch that, right? You can stretch it, stretch it, stretch it. And then somewhere you'll find something that is ambiguous. If you ask, "Is it a chair or couch?", you're not sure. It's like a monster, and that's fine. It's like an in-between thing. Thing that is in between two identities. Like, it's ambiguous, and it's totally fine. Those things necessarily exist.
- 5.43 But obviously, let me say it this way. Like, you have a spoon, you have a fork, you have a spork, but the spork —it only exists because of the spoon and the fork. That's the only reason why you can recognize this monstrous thing in the middle. That's how monsters work. They just kind of happen in between things. And so think about it. Think about it the way that I'm showing this. So you have two identities, and then you go down. You encounter monsters. Then you go back up, and then you're back in a normal identity.
- 5.44 You have Roman Empire, the Persian empire. You have Rome, right? And so you have the capital cities of these empires where their identity comes from. In Rome, for example, they had the center of the world, that a place that they literally called the center of the world. The Greeks had the same thing. They had something called the belly button of the world, the "omphalos mundi," and it was in Delphi. It was a stone. It was just a stone, a magic stone. And it was like, this is the center of the world. And you think, "Well, that's ridiculous. Obviously, it's not the center of the world," but that's how it works.
- 5.45 It's the same thing as the Mont Saint-Michel question. So as you move away from that and you move towards the stranger, at first you'll encounter strangers that you know, right? So if I speak English and French, those are the two languages I know. So if I hear Spanish, I kind of understand some. If I hear German, I kind of understand it. But you can, if I go further, like, if I hear Russian, for example, don't understand it. I can kind of follow tonality, though, so I can kind of get some mesh, some, some sense of some meaning. But if I hear Cantonese, then I'm like, it's just noise. Just noise to me, right?
- 5.46 That's the experience. That's the experience moving out into the strange. So you can imagine that ancient maps were actually made that way. So you had your center. Think of—a medieval map would have had Jerusalem in the center. And then as you move out, you have these different groups, different empires, that have become stranger and stranger. And then on the edge of the world, what do you have? Monsters. That's where the monsters are. That's where the dragons are.

- 5.47 And it really is interesting. So one of the most famous monsters that you would find in the ancient storytelling was the dog-headed men. So this sense that on the edge of the world, there are dog-headed men, like human-animal creatures that are there. And what's fascinating is that people would meet the dog-headed men in different places, right? Makes sense. And it has to do with the experience of the strange. Like, I told you about this idea of not recognizing someone. So you don't have hooks in your mind to put down what you're seeing.
- 5.48 So imagine you're like, I don't know, you're some person who was raised in Greece in the third century before Christ. And then you go to Africa and you encounter a tribe that changes the shape of the skull and that has scarification. Files the teeth. You know, it's like, you have no idea what you're looking at. It's like, "I don't have categories to make this work. So all I see is a monster." It's an inevitable process.
- 5.49 When the Spanish arrived to South America, the same thing happened. The Spanish got off their boats. Imagine this. Imagine you're some, some person, like some South American farmer, and you see this creature riding a horse. Like, they've never seen horses, never seen anybody riding an animal. So you see an 8-legged thing shining in the sun because he's wearing armor, and the horse is wearing armor, coming down from the ship. You have no way to—you don't know what's essential, what's secondary. You don't know what's important, what's not important. You can't differentiate the different categories. And all you see is a monster. There's no other way. That's all you can see, right?
- 5.50 And so it's an actual phenomenological experience we can have —this encounter with the monster. So it's not in the story. It'll be obviously exaggerated and excessive and big. But in reality, you know, when you start a new job, it's a little bit like encountering a monster because you move into a space that you don't know and then they're like, "Do this." And you're like, "I've never done this. I don't know what the steps are. I don't know how to work." And so you have to tame the monster in order to make it understandable to you. You have to break it down so that you can understand what it is you're doing. Right, and that's a very intuitive and practical process.
- 5.51 So this, right, this is just the pattern of moving away from identity and then back to identity. And that appears. It has several images. It can be, often it can be going down in the water, it can be dying. There's all kinds of ways to represent it. That's why in movies you'll have characters that dying. Such a cliché now, right? Rocky gets beaten up, beaten up, beaten up, beaten up. And then he's on the ground and he's like, is he going to get up? Is he going to get up, right? And so it's like, Thor is on the ground. Is he dead? Is he alive? Who knows? Like, he has to go down, all the way down into death, and then rises up and then beats the bad guy, right?
- 5.52 These are deeply satisfying tropes that are based on, you know, ancient, ancient stories of characters like Ulysses or Aeneas or these ancient mythical characters that go down into Hades, actually go down into hell, and then will get something there, will gather

some wisdom, gather something which will give them the capacity to go back up. All right?

5.53 But this can be also a love story. It could be the same. Can also be a love story. So, right. Someone's living their life. They're just, they've got it, they think they've got it covered. The Hallmark love story is the best example of that because it's so cliché. But still, that's what a love story is, right? So some lady, she's living her life, everything's pretty stable for her. She thinks she's got it covered. And then, unexpected thing, she encounters this guy and he wrecks her world. Everything is like falling apart. And she completely lost her—she loses her bearing, right? She loses her bearing.

5.54 She doesn't know what's more important. She's trying to reorganize her priorities and then she realizes, she decides, it's the guy and she's going to move to that little town or whatever, right, OK? But it can be a love story. It can be all kinds of story, right? It's just breathing, right? It's breathing. It's the rhythm of your heart. It's this moving out, moving in. You know, it's, that's what is going on in a story, right?

5.55 That's how you recognize a story in the first place. And it's, it's—how can I say this? It's structural and it's related to attention, because, like I said—I tried to explain the first day—there's a bunch of things happening all the time. How do you recognize that now it's a story, right? What's the difference between, let's say, a grocery list and a story? It's not the same. It doesn't have the same structure.

5.56 So if your spouse is giving you, is telling you a grocery list, it doesn't have, it's not the same kind of experience as the story. The story has a tension point, which is the beginning, and it has to have an attention point, which is the end. It has to have something that marks the beginning and something that marks the end. You have to know, when do I start paying attention to this thing and when do I stop? Right? And just that, just having that will force this structure. It'll force it on you. Right? And you will find yourself, if you tell a story, you'll find yourself using that pattern. And sometimes it can be even a little twisted or a little forced.

5.57 Like, you know, I grew up in Baptist churches. Then you always have someone go up and tell their testimony, and everybody's testimony looks like this. Just always like that. You know, especially people that kind of grew up in the faith, they kind of have to have that. They have to. They have to have that moment they say, "Oh, you know, like, I kind of started doubting, blah, blah, blah, and I kind of moved away. But then, you know, Christ called me back." And so it's like, there's always, it's just like it's inevitable. If you tell a story, you will inevitably fall into this pattern. And I'm joking, but it's not, there's nothing wrong with that. Like, this is actually how we recognize a story in the first place. That's how we recognize that something is happening because it has that pattern. OK?

5.58 One of the ways that it can appear is as a disconnection of heaven and Earth as you move down and also a reconnection up. So it doesn't necessarily always have to have

the same structure, but the idea is that, above at the top, like, heaven and Earth and meaning are connected. And as you move down, then you will, things will start to break apart. It's like things will start to dissolve and die, and then they kind of bring, they come back together again.

- 5.59** All right, so now let's look at a few fairy tales, and we'll do it super fast, because you all know these fairy tales, right? Everybody knows Cinderella, Snow White, Sleeping Beauty, Beauty and the Beast. And then all these fairy tales have the same pattern. What pattern do they have? They have the pattern that I showed you, but you have to understand it as structural again. If you understand it as structural, you'll see that sometimes the direction of the elements—who's good, who's bad—like, in our understanding, like, what direction the different characters are having will change, but their place in the structure won't. Right?
- 5.60** So you can encounter monsters down in the below, but sometimes you'll encounter a monster that'll help you. It's still a monster, but you'll encounter a monster that'll help you. But sometimes you'll encounter a monster that'll fight you. Sometimes you'll encounter, like, let's say, a prince will encounter a woman, and that woman will be like the princess that he's going to marry. Or maybe he'll encounter a witch, and then that witch will be the opposition that he'll have. But the relationship is structural, and it's not always just masculine-feminine, right? It can change.
- 5.61** But the way you see the structure is if you compare the elements inside the story to each other, so it doesn't always have to be a guy that's the hero. It can be a woman, of course, but then the same structural elements will find themselves in other guises through the different analogies that I proposed to you at the outset.
- 5.62** All right, Cinderella. Cinderella. Her father dies, or her mother dies first. Then her father dies. She finds herself with the strange woman. That's the idea. That's what the stepmother is. She's the strange woman. She's not my mother. She's just the strange potential that doesn't recognize me as being part of whatever she is. So because of that, right, the strange woman is like a witch who doesn't care for Cinderella. But Cinderella means—you know what Cinderella means? It means little ash or ash in one. So Cinderella has to hide in the ash, right?
- 5.63** Remember when I told you the story of Santa Claus comes down the chimney, and he puts the gifts under the tree, or he puts the gift at the bottom of the sock. And this is what's going on in the Cinderella story. Cinderella is the most beautiful one, but she's hidden. No one can see her because she's in that strange land. She's in the forest. She's not in the forest. But giving you all the analogies of what is possible. She's not connected to her father. She lost her father. She loses a relationship with a man. And then she goes down into this strange feminine. She gets hidden there as this precious gift that is invisible to everybody.

- 5.64 And now there's another woman that appears who's her godmother. Right? Which is so weird. Fairy godmother. What is happening? What's a fairy godmother? Right? It's an angel. It's another word for angel. It's the idea that it's something from above, like a feminine principle from above. So you have the evil, wild, and, let's say, strange woman. And now you have the woman that cares for you. You may just see it that way. There's a woman that appears, who cares for her, and wants to help her reveal her beauty to the world. And so she transforms reality around her in order to reveal her beauty.
- 5.65 And the purpose of that is so that she can marry the prince. She can become the spouse of the prince. So it's like she loses her father. She goes down into the world of the feminine, encounters both sides of that. The strange woman, also a feminine principle that wants to help her to reveal her beauty. And then she marries the prince. So it's like down, up. All right. Can you see it? Yeah. Makes sense? All right.
- 5.66 Snow White. Snow White is same story. Stepmother—she doesn't care. She sends her out into the forest. Now, she's not hidden in ash. Now she's hidden in a house of monsters. OK? She's stuck in the forest in this house of monsters. And the monsters are something like the, you could say, the incomplete masculine is the way to understand it. OK? And so she has all this—she falls into the world where she has all these problems of what it is to be a woman. Traditionally, she, like, has to work. She deals with these grumpy old men, and she has all the problems of it without any of the goodness that comes from, let's say, being in a marriage.
- 5.67 And so she goes down into the forest. She's in this house. She's cleaning, she's cooking for these half-men, and then she dies. She goes all the way down into death. She falls asleep. She dies. Doesn't matter. Either one. It's the same in stories. And then she's awoken. She's awoken by the prince. Now, the prince is important because a prince is the top. That's what a prince is. A prince is a principality. It's the head of something. It's the king, it's the chief, it's the whatever. But the chief is that point at the top of the mountain. So it's not arbitrary that, in these fairy tales, you marry a prince because you're going back up and you're encountering the reason. You're encountering the purpose.
- 5.68 So what Snow White does—a good way of understanding Snow White is actually to understand it as the transformation of a child into an adult. That's what's happening. A young woman, she starts puberty, and then what happens at the beginning of puberty, it's like, what the hell is this? I've all these problems? To deal with this thing, with blood and, like, and this, like, chaos. What is this for? And then she has to learn what it is to, like, clean the house and to do all this stuff. And it's like, so it's just pain? Is that all it is to be to be a woman?
- 5.69 And then at some point, right, there's a discovery of the reason, right? The reason for all of this thing. What's the reason for the menstrual cycle? Well, it has a reason, right? There's a reason for it, but you don't see it at first. And then you encounter it in the

prince, right? She marries the prince, they have children, and then it kind of all settles. Obviously, life is more complicated than the fairy tales, but you can see the structure, right?

- 5.70** Sleeping Beauty. Can you see it? Can you see that it's the same thing? Sleeping Beauty. There's a witch, a witch that's excluded for the naming. OK, so we're christening this girl. We're going to give her a name. Remember all these things from above, like identity, name, pattern, reason? So they're in a church or whatever, and now they're going to name this child, and they've gathered the kingdom together in order to name the child. And because she's a princess, the naming of the child is related to the gathering of the people, right? The king and the kingdom. So you celebrate the king, and the kingdom comes together. So they celebrate the princess, and the kingdom comes together.
- 5.71** What happens? The witch, the bad fairy, whatever, is excluded. She's not part of the name, right? She's not, she doesn't, she's not connected to the name. So because of that, she curses. She curses Sleeping Beauty. And she says, when she becomes a teenager—again, same idea, right?—when she becomes a teenager, she will die. And then there's a mediation. It's like, she'll sleep, but it's the same. She'll die, she'll sleep. It's the same, right? Think of the Snow White story. It's the same sleeping death, OK?
- 5.72** And then Sleeping Beauty goes through her life, reaches the teenage, teenage world, and then she bleeds, she dies, and everything falls asleep until she encounters the prince. She'll even grow thorns, like, outside to protect herself, because —and so you could understand, they're different. It's not just about puberty. There are other ways you could apply it to the world. You could apply it in different ways, but it's still the same pattern.
- 5.73** So the idea of Sleeping Beauty, for example, pricking herself on the spindle is the same as Snow White having to work and not knowing what it's for, right? It's like, here's this object of work where you're turning flax into thread, and she pricks herself on that. She only gets the pain of it. She doesn't know what the meaning of it is. OK? Does that make sense?
- 5.74** All right, Beauty and the Beast, last one. Can you kind of see it? Now it's different, but it's still the same. It's the same. OK, Beauty and the Beast. Her father betrays her, right? Her father betrays her to the Beast. So the man in her life abandons her. She loses her father and she finds herself in the world of a monster. Now, it's almost strictly about masculine, the problem of the masculine. So Snow White had the same issue. Snow White with the 7 dwarves is the same as Beauty with the Beast. Just a little more extreme, right?
- 5.75** It's the incomplete masculine. It's the monster aspect of the masculine. It's the aspect of the masculine which hasn't been tamed, which hasn't been integrated. So, what's the Beast like? He's tyrannical. He's possessive. He's all the bad things that a man can

be. And then she will transform him into a prince. Right? Now, it's not another person, but it's like, it's as if Snow White had transformed the dwarves into the right mate for her.

- 5.76** But now, Beauty and the Beast, that's what it's about. She goes down from her father, down into the world of the monster. She has to face the monstrous aspect of the masculine, the animality, the all that stuff. And he is, like, he's a werewolf-kind of creature. He's a monster. He has all those characteristics. And then she's able to transform him into a prince and then she marries him. And then that's the coming back up on the other side. OK, is that, does that make sense? All right?
- 5.77** Now, this story, this structure, right? It's, it's basically the structure of everything, like I said, any story. So let's bring it into the more sacred, let's say, and see how there's this—the same pattern is there in the Gospel stories. Of course, now it's like the ultimate version of this. So we showed, I showed you the image of the Nativity. Christ appears, goes down, comes down from heaven, down into the feminine, down into the cave, down into the animality, the water, the, even, like the doubt—all of that is there. That's where Christ is coming down into.
- 5.78** So the image is great because it's kind of brings together the actual story. But in the image, you can kind of see, this is an image of the descent. And this descent, like I said, this manger, the place where animals eat, is also a tomb, which is that, because that's the point, right? That's why Christ is coming. Christ is coming to die. And there's a reason why he's coming to die, right? Because he's going to go all the way down to the bottom of reality, and he's going to come back up. When he comes back up, he resurrects, but he doesn't stop there. He doesn't just resurrect. He ascends into heaven.
- 5.79** So Christ ascends into heaven. He has to go back to where he came from. But when he goes into heaven, there's a transformation that has occurred, and it's the church, right? So he goes down, he gathers the stuff that's below, and he brings it together to unify it. He goes down into the people. And so that's why the image of the ascension looks the way it does. So you have Christ above, who's going up. He's becoming the prince, he's becoming the top, he's becoming the head, the king, that all this imagery of what is above. He's surrounded by angels, just so you know that it's above. He's connecting with the pattern. He's the source of the patterns of reality, and the source of the moral patterns, but also the cosmic patterns.
- 5.80** That's what he is. He's revealing that. And then below you have the 12 disciples that are gathered together around the mother, who is the Earth, and she's like this, right? This is an ancient image of prayer. What does that look like? Remember when I showed you the cup, when I told you the priest holds the cup and the host together? That's it. Right there. Right there. Right? It's the proper relationship between heaven and Earth, which is now being shown to you. So heaven above, the prince, the logos, that which is above, and the Earth as gathered together.

- 5.81** Where are they looking? They're looking there. That's why they, that's why they're together, because they're looking up towards the reason why they're together, and they're gathered into the cup, the Earth, the box, the church. Right? Think about the actual building of a church now. You gather together inside this building, and you all look towards the altar, towards the place where communion comes down to us. So it's like, that's what's going on here.
- 5.82** And what's interesting about this image in particular is that there really is an emphasis on how this is not just a snapshot of a story. The tradition is really trying to show that this is structural, that it's actually an image of a cosmic structure, that it's not just like, well, yeah, Jesus did go up to heaven, so let's make an image of that. No, it's structural. And the reason you know that is because there's a strange fellow here. Right here. That's St. Paul. Hmm. If you know your Bible, St. Paul was not at Ascension. He wasn't there. He wasn't yet a disciple. And so universally, though, we will have St. Paul represented at Ascension.
- 5.83** Why? Because it's not just an image of an event. It's an image of the structure of reality. It's an image that shows you how reality works. That is, the manner in which people gather together into a body is that they all look to the same point of attention. They celebrate it. They make it the thing that they're looking towards. Right? And of course, this is true of the church, obviously, but it's true about everything. It's true of everything. Any group that you can identify as a group will have that structure. The difference between a crowd and a group is attention. That's all it is. You can change a random crowd of people walking around into a group in a second. Just give them a common point of attention, and they'll mobilize as a group. It can happen very fast. Right?
- 5.84** But that's true of a sports team, right? If a sports team will function as a sports team, they all have to look together towards the reason why they're together. And if they don't, then one of the players will start to wander. Right? If someone in a team has a different purpose, that's what we call corruption. Right? It's a good way to understand it. That's when corruption gets instantiated into a system.
- 5.85** So you can think about it. Let's say, a group of police officers, police station, a group of police officers, they're supposed to follow their chief. They're supposed to follow the rules. They're supposed to serve the good. They have something which is bringing them together, right? Their uniform is there to bring them towards, to manifest that purpose in them. But if one of the police officers decides that, "Wait, this is an interesting opportunity for me to get something, to get money, to get favors, to get whatever," then all of a sudden you start to see corruption in the system, right?
- 5.86** So you could say the same for the church, of course. Is that the church? This is how the church works. But there's always necessarily the possibility of corruption in any group, any team, because as soon as someone starts to move away from the highest good, even just identifying lower goods as the thing they want, then they will corrupt the

purpose of the team. A good example in a sports team is a good example. It's like, the purpose of the sports team is for the team to win. Then you'll have a player in the team who's the best player. And then that player can start to think that the reason for what he's doing is actually just to get attention for himself.

5.87 And that will work to the extent that he subjugates that attention to the purpose of the team. He can shine. He can be the star player, as long as we win, as long as the other team players are in the team enough because you can't win alone. But if that star player starts to subjugate the reason for the team to their own glory, then the team loses. Everybody hates him, gets frustrated, gets traded, whatever, and his career might even start to wane—because you can be a star player, but if the team you're playing in doesn't win because you're hogging the ball, because you're trying to do the thing yourself, then who cares how good you are? Doesn't matter, right?

5.88 And so now, this story, it's interesting, because this story, there's another part to it. This is what's interesting about a story. You can kind of, you can clip it, and it has a structure, right? Beginning and end. This is a good end. But there's a way in which there's a—let's say, there's another end. And that other end has to do with this one. All right, so this is the death. This is a traditional image. It's the death of the Virgin. So remember when I showed you the image of heaven and Earth, right? The vertical and the horizontal? This is a great example of it.

5.89 So you have Christ as the vertical. You have the mother as the horizontal. And then he is holding her soul in his hands. And so he's gathered the Earth, and the disciples are all gathered. There's actually, it's actually, these Christian traditions, the one outside the Bible, they're kind of wild, like the traditions. The further you get away—how can I say this? Traditional storytelling also works this way. So you have basic stories. Then the further you get away, the kind of wilder and more slippery they get. So the story, for those who don't know the story of the death of the mother of God, when she dies, all the disciples that are all over the world, they all get magically gathered together. They all kind of come together at her funeral, even though they're all over the world.

5.90 But it's like, OK, you can understand it, right? You can understand it based on this, right? It's the same thing happening here. It's the same thing that's going on. It's another version of it, but it's to help you come to this image, right, which is now the gathering of—this is an image called the Crowning of the Virgin. It's the gathering of the church up into the purpose. And so this is a stand-in, of course, for all of us, you know—that is, all those that are a disciple of Christ, that are in the church, can be lifted up, brought into the purpose, brought into Christ. And we have all these images that we use to talk about that.

5.91 But that's the way, that's the basic image. So you can see it. So you can see, actually, the image I showed you before is down here. So you have the female as the feminine, as the Earth. That's gathered into heaven. That's gathered into the meaning. And that appears as the gathering of all the disciples together towards that meaning. Then

ultimately, the highest image of that is the crowning of the Earth, let's say, the crowning of manifestation. So it's like down, up, but the story can also go the other way. This is something that Joseph Campbell, for some reason, didn't see. I don't know why. The story doesn't always about coming down the mountain and up the mountain. Sometimes the story is about going up the mountain and then bringing something down from what you find above.

- 5.92** So if you frame the story of Christ in this way, then you have that too, right? At the Ascension —let me show the Ascension image—so Christ goes up into heaven, and then everybody's surprised. What's going on? And then they turn to the angels that are here. And when they asked the angels, and what did the angels say? They say, "Just as he went up, so too will he return." And so then in Christian mythology, you have this idea that Christ will return. He's going up to the Father, and now he's going to bring back judgment. He's going to bring back the kingdom, down from above.
- 5.93** And I'm just going to give you one example of this in terms of fairy tale. Jack and the Beanstalk is a good example of that. Now you have Jack at the bottom of the world. Interestingly enough, it's the opposite as the other ones. Jack doesn't have a father. Jack only has his mother. He has— this is gonna sound crass to you, but it's just, that's the story, and I hope you have to still see it. Jack has a mother. Jack has a cow. That's what's the situation he is. He has milk, right? And now he has a problem because he wants to connect that to something else. He wants it. What does he want to connect it to? What's the story? What does he get for his cow?
- 5.94** Do you remember the story of Jack and the Beanstalk? Bean. Gets beans. What's a bean? It's a seed, right? So Jack trades his cow for a seed, right? That's what he's missing. He's trying to get that because he's in a world of just the Earth. He only has his mother and his cow. So then his mother doesn't see the value of the seed, so she tosses it out. And what does this seed do? The seed connects heaven and Earth. It becomes that vertical that I've been showing you. It becomes that tree. It becomes that pole. It becomes that ladder. It becomes—however you want to see it—becomes a ladder between heaven and Earth.
- 5.95** And so Jack wants to go up there, and his mother doesn't want him to. She wants to keep him down here, you know? But he has to get that. He has to, let's say, he has to acquire the heavens. That's what he needs, because he only has Earth. So he goes up the beanstalk, and then he goes up three times, and every time he gets something different. First time, he gets something precious, he gets the bag of gold, and he brings it down. But that bag of gold runs out. It's not enough. Goes back up. What does he get? Remember the story? He gets a chicken that lays golden eggs. So why does he get a chicken that lays golden eggs?
- 5.96** He gets the cause of gold, right? So at first he gets the gold, then he gets the cause of gold. He gets something higher, right? Because what's higher, gold or the cause of gold? Right? What's better? You could say it this way—what's better, a fish or knowing

how to fish? Knowing how to fish is better than fish. Because if you have knowledge and you have the pattern, then you can implement it many times, right? If you just have the gold, like I said, it runs out. But if you have the way you get gold, then not bad. You're not bad.

- 5.97** But then Jack goes up a third time. Does he have to go up the third time? He's set. He's got a chicken that lays golden eggs. Like, he doesn't need riches anymore. He doesn't, in terms of just dealing with the everyday issues, he doesn't need it. But what does he get the third time? You guys remember? He goes up the beanstalk into the house of the giants, and he gets a harp that sings. Now, that's weird, right? Why would he get a harp that sings? What does that give him? What did that give him? What is he getting?
- 5.98** He's getting a pattern. That's what singing is. Remember when I told you that the angels sing in the heavens to announce the birth of Christ? The ancients had this idea that the heavenly spheres make music, the music of the spheres. And materialists think, "Well, that's stupid, right? There's these spheres rubbing against each other and kind of making sound? Is that what's going on?" But no, it's just a pattern. I told you, what's above in the heavens is a clock. It's a clock that shows you the order of how things happen. If you master the clock, then you master the seasons. If you master the clock, you know when to plant, you know when to harvest, right? You know all these things, all these things that you have to do.
- 5.99** If you master the clock, you know where to go. You can be out in a field, and all you need to do is know how the clock works, and you can get back to your village, right? You're stuck on the ocean, on a boat. If you know how the clock works, you can find your way. And so what Jack gets the last time he goes up the beanstalk is the pattern of reality. And so he gets heaven and he brings it down to Earth, right? That's what he's doing every time he's going up. He's just getting more and more. Remember, it's this fractal. It's a structure. It's a ladder. And so he gets levels of it.
- 5.100** First he gets the shiny metal, right? He gets the most precious, highest metal. Then he gets the cause of that metal. Then he gets basically the cause of everything. The pattern of all things is the best way to understand it, right? And so that's the story of this as well, right? Moses goes up the mountain and he receives the pattern. God gives him the pattern, then he brings the pattern down to the people. Now, in this story, it's interesting, because the coupling that I told you is there. So how does he get the pattern? He doesn't just hear it. It gets written on stone, so it gets embodied above, and then he brings that down to the bottom of the mountain.
- 5.101** Do you remember what happens when he gets at the bottom of the mountain the first time? When Moses goes up the mountain, gets the law, when he comes back down the mountain, he finds these people that have made a golden calf and are worshipping this golden calf. Remember when I told you what's at the bottom of the mountain? One of the things at the bottom of the mountain, one thing's at the bottom is animality, right? Animality is at the bottom of the mountain. And so they're making a god out of the

animal. They're making a god out of a lower good, because there's nothing wrong with animals. Animals are good, but they're making a god out of it.

5.102 It's like they're acting as if this thing that's below is at the top, right? And so because of that, the pattern—trying to come back down—the pattern of heaven tries to come back down, and it encounters this problem, this idol, these people that are worshipping lower goods. And so the pattern smashes. Smash the pattern. Moses takes the tablets, throws them to the ground, shatters them into pieces, right? Breaks it into a million pieces.

5.103 That's how it works. It's positional, right? The whole thing is positional. So the pattern that he receives is something like, you could say, the name of God. That's the first thing he receives. Receives the name of God. And then that gets multiplied into Ten Commandments. So you got Ten Commandments. Then those Ten Commandments get multiplied into, like, hundreds of commandments. So that's how it works. That's the mountain, right? From the name and a hierarchy of patterns. So as he's going back down, that would be normal, that the one becomes the many. So at the bottom of the mountain, there are many, many, many, many rules at the top of the mountain. There's one reason.

5.104 So in this version, it appears like, it smashes, it breaks. There's too many. It just splinters into infinite. But as you move from up down, there will be more and more rules. This is not weird. There's nothing like, nothing esoteric about that. Think about you learning anything. Think about you learning to play the piano. How does it start? Do this. Hold your fingers this way. Do this. Put your feet this way. Sit straight. Do this. Millions and millions of rules at the bottom of the mountain. What's the purpose of these rules? The purpose of the rules are for you to bind it together so you can see the reason, so you can see the purpose.

5.105 So as you master the piano, the rules will start to coalesce. They'll actually start to vanish. They won't vanish. You still have to hold your fingers this way. You still have to place yourself in a certain way in order to play the piano, right? But they'll start to be assimilated into higher practices. And at some point, you won't need any rules. You won't need any rules to play the piano because you have embodied it all into the purpose of what you're doing. And so the rules are still there, but you don't need them. They've been brought into the purpose. Right? Does that make sense?

5.106 So Christ says—what's the essential of the law? They ask, "What's the essential of the law?" And Christ says, "Love your neighbor. Love God, love your neighbor." That's it. But that implies a bunch of stuff, right? It's like, yeah, it's true that if you truly love your neighbor, do you need a rule that tells you not to steal from them? Of course not. But that rule is implicit in "love your neighbor." So the lower you get on the mountain, the more you'll need to make those rules explicit. And then the higher you go, the less you will need those rules to be explicit. The more they will become implicit into the

purpose. And that's true, like I said, of anything that you come to master. Any purpose you come to master will happen that way.

5.107 But it's also the story of Jack and the Beanstalk, right? It's the story of Moses going up the mountain. It's all these stories that, say, have that pattern in them. All right? All right. So I think that's enough for now. So I hope that you're able to start to see it more and more, and also see how it's complex, but the complexity fits into the basic structure of heaven and Earth. It's just corollaries of that first structure that multiply and kind of fill up all the different aspects of the world. All right?

5.108 And so, give you guys a break, and then we'll come to our last session after this.

Lecture 6: Timeless Patterns

At a glance — A closing question period drawing the timeless patterns together.

- 6.1** All right. And so we are going to have our last question period. And I'm warning you, I will judge how much you've understood by the quality of your questions. I'm joking, though, but does anybody have any questions? Yeah.
- 6.2** So in terms of a relationship with heaven and Earth, I was curious about your description of it within the confines of a marriage, and how you would explain the relationship between a man and a woman within a marriage outside from the sexual part, because that's a little obvious.
- 6.3** Yeah. So the way that St. Paul talks about it, right? He talks about, he talks about the head and the body. That's the way he talked about the relationship between Christ and the church, but also the relationship of the husband to the wife, but then also to the family. Right? So it's not just the wife, but the wife—if you look at the image, if you look at the image, this image—this is a good image of a family, is a good way to understand that. And so you have the husband.
- 6.4** This is—it's weird. I'm sorry. Symbolism is weird sometimes because Mary, in the imagery, is both a mother and the bride. And in some ways it sounds scandalous, but it's not a big deal because they're both virgins anyways. But the notion is mostly that she becomes in some way—she encapsulates all the imagery of the feminine in herself. So she's both the mother and the bride. Here, in this particular context, she's really represented as something like the bride. And so you have the husband and the wife, and then you have the gathering of the family together. That's the way that it's traditionally represented.
- 6.5** So there are different ways in which this—it's so hard to talk about this because it's so politically charged, but there's something about the very process. So even just beyond the sexual, the sexual relationship, which, you know, it's like, when I showed—I know when I showed this, like that's, that's it. Like, that's the relationship between a man and a woman. But in terms of how, let's start just with the, with the gestation of the child, right? And so the woman gives body to the child. That's just how it happens. She gives body. Then she gives food from her body.
- 6.6** And that becomes an extension. It extends into the home, let's say. So that's the way that it was traditionally understood. And so the woman provides home, right? She provides home in her womb for the child, but then she also provides home for the family. And so that's why there's always been a relationship between the feminine and preparation of food, because she gathers the food for the family. She prepares it to hold the family together. And so it's an extension of what happened to the children when they were born. It's a natural extension of that.

- 6.7 And so the husband, in the traditional way, will provide name. That's the way, that's why we have the names of our fathers. There would be different ways of doing it, but you can kind of see how it works. Like, the mother provides body, home, the man provides name, identity, you could say. And then also authority. But the authority, of course, it's also, it's a coupling, right? It's the same way that I showed it. The mother, of course, has authority over the children, and you have to see it as that coupling. So the man and the woman together—the man represents, let's say, the authority in that relationship. Then they both represent the authority for the children. So that's the way that it would manifest itself.
- 6.8 Only if you understand it, that the hierarchy is not the same as a tyranny. That's not how it works. And so the way, at least, let's say the Christian hierarchy manifests itself—and it's kind of one of the mysteries of how Christianity shows itself—is that the head gives itself for the body. So the top of the hierarchy gives itself for the bottom of the hierarchy. That's how it works. And then the body gathers itself into the head.
- 6.9 And that's a mutual relationship, right? It's a mutual relationship of love, where the reason for authority in a Christian vision is not just so that the king or the chief or the whatever gets the glory, but that that person has to give, give himself, and love the family. Love his wife, love the family, love the body that he, that is his body, you could say. All right, and so that's how it traditionally would function in the relationship, despite how controversial that is. Yeah, go.
- 6.10 You mentioned initially that everything is heaven and Earth, and within the structure of heaven and Earth, there are many heavens and Earth, right?
- 6.11 Yeah.
- 6.12 And as well as the power of sight, whenever we see that, is like, the apostles and the people involved are looking at the reason. So there's an inevitability of sight involved when it comes to attention. My question would be, since there are heavens and Earth and within this hierarchy, wouldn't it be as well that losing sight of the logos opens the door to corruption?
- 6.13 Right? Yeah, exactly. That's exactly what I said, losing sight of the reason will—that's what corruption is. I mean, that's how corruption sets itself. There's no way around it. And it's not a —when we say "losing sight of the logos," it sounds very, like, lofty. And that's totally a good way to say it. But it's as true for a sports team as it is for anything. As soon as you lose sight of the reason why you're together, then corruption will set itself in. And sometimes it's not even a moral—it doesn't even have to be a moral corruption. It can just be corruption.
- 6.14 Think about a knitting group, right? So these, you know, a group of people, they come together, they like knitting. They say, "We're going to come to, we're going to have knitting projects together." So they come around and they start to knit. And then at some point, someone in the group says, "Oh, I've got a friend that would like to come

to the knitting group, but that person doesn't knit." And it's like, "Hmm, OK, well, maybe. OK, so let's let them in." So you let that person in. And so then there's someone who comes to the knitting group who doesn't knit and just kind of sits around and talks. And it's like, it's OK. You can tolerate some flexibility. You kind of have to have some, you know?

- 6.15** But then imagine if that person says, "Oh, I've got 10 friends who would love to come to this knitting group, but they don't knit." It's like, how long before it's not a knitting group anymore? At some point, it won't be a knitting group. It'll be something else. It will have died, corrupted, and turned into something else. And it's not a moral question. Maybe that's OK. Maybe they'll decide that this is no longer a knitting group. It's something else that has another reason for being together. But the process will happen. If they lose sight of their reason, then at some point corruption will set itself in and will undo their world.
- 6.16** OK? Now, but what's important is to understand that there is, let's say, a need for some—I'm not going to use the word corruption—there's a need for exception in any system. There has to be a few monsters on the edge. That is absolutely necessary. There has to be some fat in the system. You cannot have a system that is too straight because the system will shatter. Any system. So think about this knitting group again. You've got these people in the knitting group. They're knitting. And then every time someone wants to talk about their day, someone else says, "Shh, we're knitting. Shut up. Like, that's not what we're doing." And so it's like, every time someone wants to go to the bathroom, it's like, "Hey, we're knitting. What are you doing? This is what we're here for, right?"
- 6.17** What's going to happen? The group will shatter because you need some flexibility in the margins in order to function. And that's like, that's a system, systematically true. It's true in a system way. That is, one of the problems that we have in our system right now is that we have systems that are too efficient, especially in business. You see that. This is the problem. They're like, we try to make the system as lean as possible. So we want everybody to be working all the time as much as possible. You know, we don't have too many employees. We don't have too much buffer in the system.
- 6.18** I remember that, you know, they have just-in-time delivery. So it's like if you need something, it gets delivered the same day, and then you use it so you don't take up your warehouse space, so you don't need as much. And everything gets lean and lean and lean. But the problem is that the fat—that's where you get potential from. Remember when I told you that the bottom of the world is chaos, but it's also potential? So if you don't have a bunch of employees that sometimes have nothing to do, if there's a crisis, you won't be able to handle it. You actually need to have people in the system that are sometimes not doing anything and that are kind of chaotic, that are kind of not aligned with the goal. So that if something happens that will shake the

system, you can go into that margin and you can gather more potential into the purpose. Right?

- 6.19** So that's true. Like I said, it's true of anything. It's true of a system. It's true of anything. That's why you have people sitting on the bench. In a sports team, it's like, it's boring to have people sitting on the bench that aren't, like, playing the game. But if you don't have people sitting on the bench, then you're going to run into trouble. You need that fat around the, around the system in order to be able to integrate the outside, let's say. OK? And so that's how, that's why, that's how—let's say, that's why it looks the way it looks. That's why on the edge of the world, there are always some kinds of monster, some kind of chaos, some kind of exception. And it happens structurally.
- 6.20** Remember when I told you about the image of the world? You know, the omphalos, the belly button of the world, and the monsters on the edge? Well, that structure is the structure of a church. Like a medieval church would have looked like that too. But you have the altar in the middle, and then on the outside of the church, what do you have? You've got the gargoyles. You need those gargoyles on the outside of the church because that's how it works. If you want to encompass a whole image of the world, you're going to need that—exceptions, right?
- 6.21** And so think about, in a year, they have the same structure. So a year, a traditional year, is patterned, right? We understand that time is patterned. So we have days. You wake up, you have the day, you go to bed, you sleep. Then you have the week, you work during the week, you have some time off at the end. So the week is structured as the day. Then you have the year, and in that year, you have some vacation time. So the year is structured as the week is structured as the day. It's like a little fractal system.
- 6.22** Well, that's true just in terms of secular work, but it's also true in terms of sacred time. So the year used to be organized religiously around festivals. You have Christmas, you have Easter, you have Pentecost, you have Ascension, you have all these celebrations. In other cultures we'd have the same. Jewish culture has all these feasts as well. And then in those feasts you will have what you could call inversion feasts. And that is a universal thing. You'll have the feast of the monster. You can't avoid it. It will happen in every culture. So you will have a feast in the year which will be like the gargoyles on the edge of the church. So Mardi Gras, Purim, Halloween, whatever, right?
- 6.23** In the medieval west, they had a feast called the Feast of Fools. And then at the Feast of Fools, they would elect, they would take a child, they would make them into a bishop for the day, dress them up as a bishop. They would turn the world upside down. They would go into exception, cross-dressing, you know, just joking, kind of lewdness. All of that would come during those inversion festivals, like that gargoyle on the edge of a church. There's a tradition at Purim, for example, in the Jewish tradition, where on Purim—this is a rabbinical tradition—that on Purim every man should drink wine and spin on himself until he falls to the ground.

- 6.24** It's like, you have to kind of embody that chaos just a little bit, right? You kind of, it's almost like you need to have a place in the year that has—it's a kind of buffer. It's a kind of place to let in just enough chaos. Not too much. Too much will poison you. But if you don't have any, then the system will crack. Think about the—just think about you. Like, if you just work all the time, you don't rest, what's gonna happen? You're just gonna crack. If you don't take any time to play or to relax or to do things that are a little silly, then it's gonna build up in you. And then at some point, you're gonna find yourself in Las Vegas, whatever. You're gonna smash it, and you're going to move into excess.
- 6.25** So a little drip of chaos is actually how the world works. You kind of need that. So I didn't expect to talk about that. But it's important to understand that, because it will help you understand so many things that are happening today. It'll help you understand so many things that are happening today. Our world is a swing between too much order and too much chaos. That's how the modern world is set up. So instead of having this normal fractal system, what we've got is we've got something like heaven and Earth separating, and heaven is becoming very, very strong, and Earth is becoming very, very strong at the same time, and they're not connecting.
- 6.26** And it's important because sometimes you look at the world and you wonder, how is it possible? How is it that we are now seeing in front of us systems of control, the likes of which we've never seen in the history of the world? Tracking, identification—you know, all these things are becoming global, and at the same time, absolute fragmentation, right? Everybody is their own thing. You know, it's like gender identity has exploded into a million different names. And it's like Carnival all the time. So you've got Carnival, Mardi Gras, and you've got this crazy totalitarian system rising above it. It's like an excess of the two sides happening at the same time.
- 6.27** And some people—it's funny, the modern world is so much like that. In the United States, 100 years ago, alcohol was illegal, but that's how crazy this is. So it's like, you move from alcohol is illegal to, like, to, like, furry culture, right? How the hell did you get from there to there? Right? It's like, no, it's related to each other. It's like these two extremes that are appearing and are breaking down the normal fractal structure which is supposed to make the world exist, right?
- 6.28** There's an image of that in the Bible, in the Book of Revelation. It describes a whore riding a beast. That's what it is, right? In that image, the beast is actually an amalgamation of all the civilizations. So in Revelation, the beast is—all the different elements of the beast come from the Book of Daniel that describes all these empires. So like the Persian empire, the Greek, the, you know, Alexander's empire, and all these different empires, Babylonian, whatever, and then they get gathered into one image in Revelation, which is this beast, basically civilization, right? The structure.
- 6.29** And then on the back of that is riding a whore. It's like, what's a whore? A whore is chaos, right? A whore is lack of identity. Mixture. That's what a whore is. If a whore has a child, you will not know who the father is. You will not know what his name is, right?

Mixture, confusion, excess, licentiousness, all of that. And so, the thing is that those two, they need each other. You need an excess of one to get the excess of the other. You need an excess of heaven to have an excess of Earth. That's how it works.

- 6.30** I always joke and say, "You can't have a punk rocker in the Amazon jungle." They would die in two days. For a punk rocker, an anarchist, to exist, they have to be in an extremely structured society, because normally the chaos and the excessive order, they kind of call each other. That's how it works. So, yeah, I don't know how I got there, but I think it's important to talk about. Yeah.
- 6.31** So I came into these lectures knowing just a little bit about you and what you talk about. And so I still have yet to figure this out, really. But is it enough to understand these patterns from the Bible and their usefulness in our life without affiliation to any one religion? Is that enough, or do you think that, to go along through life that way, there will always be something missing?
- 6.32** Yeah, no, I definitely, I definitely think that. I think that —you know, I tried to present this pattern as, let's say, as objectively as possible so that people can see it. People can grasp it. People can at least understand that this is actually how reality works. But the thing is, is that when I say this is how reality works, I mean, this is how reality works. That is, it's not something that you think about. It's something that you participate in. So the patterns that I'm talking about ultimately should be lived. You know, it's not just enough to sit at a desk and think about it.
- 6.33** And so part of that means you have to participate in this structure. You have to kind of, you have to enter into it. What that means is enter into these communions. And of course, you know, getting yourself together, you know, aligning yourself towards, towards what is good—you need that. Participating in family or in smaller groups—all of that you need. But I do believe that ultimately, the best way to bring it all together is through worship.
- 6.34** And it sounds like, when I say it that way, it's like, "OK, here's Jesus smuggler." But the first reaction we should have to a good is to celebrate it. And this is not something you just do in your mind. It's something that you have to physically do. You can't just think about it. And so that is true of all the goods, but it's excessively true of the highest good. And so if we identify the transcendent, everything kind of moving up towards the highest good, you know, the God of love, then you have to worship the God of love. And that has—it's not arbitrary—it has a form and it does something. And it means also gathering together. Right? Paying attention to this, all singing.
- 6.35** Why do we sing? It's not arbitrary. Singing is this patterning of reality. And so you come together, you pattern reality together, all looking up and all participating in this together. That is the way that reality holds together. It is actually the way reality holds together. And so I do believe that, ultimately, the breakdown of the religious, let's say,

the fact that Christianity in the West has been kind of set aside, I think, is the main reason why the shattering is happening.

- 6.36** Now the problem is that, in this kind of shattering, people can't see. They can't see it. So you have to help them. Like the ladder—if you just show them the top of the ladder, they'll be like, "I don't know. What are you showing me? Like, what is this?" You have to kind of rebuild the ladder, is the way to say it. So it's like, that's what I'm trying to do, help people see, like, this is how this works. But I do believe that you have to engage. And that does mean, I think, not abstractly, concretely, being part of a body, right.
- 6.37** And then submitting yourself to authorities, and then celebrating the highest good, worshipping, doing all those things that people do in church, but not abstractly. Really doing it. That's a tough one. But I think ultimately this is what it leads to. But some people will, let's say, some people will make their way along that route and will find themselves where they will find themselves. But I think ultimately that's what it points to.
- 6.38** You mentioned worship right now, which you've touched before. Even you said in one talk you had with Michael Knowles, you said that you even, like, force yourself to go to church, or something along those lines, because there are—this chaos pulling you back, that you should not participate in this, which is, you know, something along the lines of diabolical. What is one advice you would give to any of the young minds that are watching this—not that we're old here, I'm sorry—but what is that particular advice that would set all the other advices apart? Meaning, this is at the top of the hierarchy in your system.
- 6.39** I mean, that's what I would say. I think that the highest, the highest part is worship. That's what it is. And so that's why I kind of joke and I tell people, "Go to church," and I think you could reduce it to that. It's like, participate. Like, you don't just think about it. Get involved. Like actually join a body and celebrate. And I know that it's, like I said, it's hard because I don't want—that's why I talk about sports teams and I talk about military, whatever, because people can start to experience it at lower levels if they struggle to get it. It's like, get involved in something. Notice how it works. Notice what happens. Notice how you bind together with others. Notice what that is. Get involved in your family. Notice it.
- 6.40** But I do believe that scales, and I do think that the highest one holds it all together. So my advice is go to church, but take it at the level that you're ready to take it right? Get involved in your family, if that's all you can do, but do it. You'll see what happens. You'll notice attention, celebration, coming together. And so that's actually what I'm going to talk about now. So it's kind of nice.
- 6.41** All right, so I'm going to talk about—we're going to get back to a little bit, to the Sam Harris recipe, but not directly, but I'm going to try to use eating as an image of how this kind of all comes together, right. How it all fits together in terms of bringing this pattern

into participation. Now, this is something that you can do. It's not just interpreting fairy tales or interpreting religious stories, but it is something that you can do in your life.

- 6.42** What is eating, right? Eating is gathering something below you into your purpose. That's what eating is. Eating is taking potential, right, and then gathering into your identity. You want it to say that way. So the sandwich is broken down and becomes you, quite literally. OK? That's how, that's what eating is. So eating can become an image of this whole process of, like, all of—can say how, how this works, OK? And so when I gather, so when you eat, you already do it. We've talked about it in terms of the recipe. You take different elements in the world, and then you gather them together in a little hierarchy. You'll have a little hierarchy, which is your recipe.
- 6.43** And it has to be a hierarchy because it's not true that you can mix any type of food together in order to make a recipe. You know that. You don't want to put peanut butter on your steak or whatever. There's things that just don't go together in terms of your experience. And so recipes have a little hierarchy. Bring that together, right? And then you gather that into yourself. And so you're already participating in this pattern, but there's a way in which that becomes true at a larger level. And so a family meal is also a little image of this whole pattern.
- 6.44** So think of a potluck. Potluck is an even better version of this. And so you invite your family, let's say, Thanksgiving, and then people bring their food. Bring all the food together. All these little hierarchies. They bring them together, and then they offer this food up, right? Just the way that you take the food and you bring it up into yourself. Now, we're doing the same. We're taking this food, and we're offering it up. What are we offering it to? We're offering it to our communion. We're offering it to our family.
- 6.45** We recognize that this is not just a bunch of strangers walking around in the street, right? This is people that have a reason to be together. Whatever that reason is, it could be family, it could be something else, but it doesn't matter. It's like, we have a reason to be together. We recognize each other as being a group, as being something that holds, and so we take the food and we offer it up to that group. It's a kind of little sacrifice, and it's a sacrifice to the family.
- 6.46** So you try to make the best food, right? You know, if you go to potluck, you don't want to bring anything. You don't want to be that person that just goes to the store, picks something up. You want to bring something nice, prepared. If you do that, you're honoring the group. You're honoring the family, right? The person that really makes something amazing and brings it to the pot, like, everybody's like, "Wow, that's so awesome that you would be willing to put all that time, all that effort, all that love into this food, which celebrates our group."
- 6.47** And then there's, like—honor is, like, falls on that person that brings this food. And you think, think about it. Is it ridiculous? Like, it's not. But if you were just the kind of materialist, it kind of, all of this sounds ridiculous. And so now you come to the food

and you know right? And you know that if aunt so-and-so brings a dish and nobody eats her food, that it means something. It means that aunt so-and-so is the quirky one that's kind of on the fringe of the family. And so, you know, you make a little effort to eat a little bit of her food, even though you don't really want to, but you do that because you want to make sure—why? It's just food, right?

6.48 No, you want to make sure that she feels included into the family. If nobody eats her food, she will feel excluded. There's no way around that. And not only will she feel excluded, she will be excluded to a certain extent. You gather this food, right? You go to the potluck. You gather it. You put it on your plate. You brought all these little patterns. You bring them into the one plate, you put them on the table, and now the very gathering together around the table will have an order, right? Eating a meal together is not just people sitting around the table and eating, is it? You don't just sit around and eat. Just sit down, eat, leave. That would be ridiculous. No.

6.49 So this sharing of food now becomes a sharing of something else. It becomes a sharing of presence. Becomes a sharing of stories. Becomes a sharing of looks, right? Where we're looking at each other, we're listening to each other, and it's a dance, right? A family meal is a dance. Whether it's just your family meal, let's say, in terms of sitting together just with your kids and your spouse, or whether it's like a bigger family meal, it has to be a dance. And you know that it's a dance. Well, maybe you don't, but you should know. And if you're not sure that it's a dance, you should try to do the opposite of the dance and just see what happens, right? Eating at a meal, at a family meal, has an order to it.

6.50 And if you break it, it's not that hard to break it. There are, like, a million things you could do to break it. Just sit at the table and then just turn your chair like this to the table. Just see what happens, right? Just stand up on the table, let's say. There's a million things you could do to break the dance, but it is a dance, right? So you have to speak to a certain extent. You have to listen. You have to not hog the food. You have to make sure, looking at the plates on the table. You're always kind of making sure. Did everybody get a little bit of something? Is there enough? Like, oh, if I've already taken a helping of something, maybe I'm going to leave some for the others, right? There's all these things that we do, but it is a ritual. It is a ritualized practice.

6.51 And that can help you understand that all human encounters are like that. All human encounters are rituals. That's also something that you cannot avoid. We have a strange, modern way of thinking, which we think that somehow informality is reality and that anything formal is fake, right? People have this strange cultural idea, but that's total nonsense. Everything you do in relationship to others is formal, and it has rules and it's a ritual. So the family meal is one thing, but just a conversation is the same. If one person only speaks and the other person isn't given a chance to speak, that relationship will break down. And like I said, just try it. When you're talking to someone, just turn your back and see what happens. Or just lay on the ground and see what happens.

- 6.52** There's a million things you can do to manifest the fact that any human encounter is ritualized. There's no way around that. OK? And so then, now when you come at the family meal, now this family meal is heavily ritualized. It's something that you have to learn, something that you have to master. And if you don't master it, you are a danger to the communion of the group. Right? At the table, at the family meal. Right? If your child is just screaming and doing all this stuff, it's a danger to the communion of the group. And that child has to learn to dance, to participate in the ritual, so that at some point it becomes natural, and then the rules go away. Right?
- 6.53** It's the same thing. Like, I talked about the piano, right? When you have little kids, it's like, sit at the table. You can't leave without asking permission. Like all these different rules that you'll give the child in order to know how to eat at the table. But as adults, we don't follow rules. We just know what it is we're doing. We just engage with it naturally. It becomes very much like dancing, OK? But it is nonetheless ritualized.
- 6.54** Now you can scale this ritual up again. So you have eating alone, which is already all this gathering, sitting at the table with your family, say, bigger family gathering. Then you can have a feast. Then you can have a wedding feast. A wedding feast is the best example of that. So why do we eat at weddings? Why would we have to eat at a wedding? We could just go to the wedding and then go home. Just all, each of us go to the restaurant on our own. We don't do that. Why don't we do that? It's because we know intuitively that eating together —let me say it this way, even clearer.
- 6.55** Eating together is sharing the same body. Literally, like the food we eat. We eat the same food and we're making body with the same food. It's like it's a literal process of, let's say, participating in the same body. So we know that gathering together and eating is, is very, very deeply, deeply, deeply related. We understand that. So now we have the wedding feast. Come together, and then we sit around. We all eat. And then there's the hierarchy at the way it's set up, right? Like, there's the table with the bride and the groom. Then there's a hierarchy of tables.
- 6.56** You know how that works? Like, the people that are closest to the bride and the groom are closer to the head table. The people that know them less are further from the head table. And we all think this is completely natural. Nobody complains. Everybody kind of knows their position. But if you get it wrong, you might run into trouble because someone thinks they're really close to the couple and they get put out in the table that's kind of behind a post somewhere. They're going to get annoyed, right? They will, because they'll realize that this is revealing something about their relationship that they didn't think was true. Right? And so it's tricky. Setting up a wedding feast is very tricky, and it's very contentious.
- 6.57** And setting up this ritual, just like a family feast, will expose the cracks in the relationship. They can be a way of mending them, but they can also be a way of exposing the cracks that are already there, right? And so we get together. Then what do we do? What are we doing at a—what do we do at these feasts? Like, what is this?

What are we doing? What is this? What's a toast? But how silly is a toast, right? You take liquid. You lift it up to the sky. And then you honor something. Is that weird? Right? What are we doing?

- 6.58** This is a sacrifice. This is the image of a sacrifice, a ritual religious sacrifice. It's not an actual religious sacrifice, so don't freak out and think that you're, like, sacrificing to some foreign god when you're doing this, but it follows the pattern of a sacrifice. I'm taking food, I'm taking liquid that I'm going to drink, and I raise it up, just like the priest raises up that cup into the heavens. I lift it up, and then I announce something to celebrate. Say, "Celebrate this." And then everybody does the same. Everybody raises their glass. They're all drinking the same thing or similar things, and then they take a sip together, and they make that real by embodying the same stuff, by making body together, by drinking at the same time.
- 6.59** I think of even a toast at a table. If we're all close to each other, what do we do? We all bring it together. Like, we all kind of bring our glass together. We even touch each other's glasses, like, lift it up and manifest our communion through this strange act of food, bringing food up to the heavens. And so now you have everything you need to understand religious sacrifice. You have all the tools you need to understand how that works. What are people doing in those days, with their burning meat to their gods? What is happening? Isn't it strange? Why would you do something like that? It looks very odd, but it's not that odd.
- 6.60** What the people did—they would take food, take meat, take potential, take the animal part, right? And then they would offer it up to the thing that binds them together, or to the thing that binds them to something, right? So if I have a purpose, and I want to aim at that purpose, and I want something from that purpose, what will I do? I will take potential, and I will lift it up and offer it to that purpose. That's what you do when you play basketball. You take your potential, your energy, your capacity, your body, and you lift it up, and you offer it up to the purpose of what you're doing.
- 6.61** Now you have this ritualized version of it. So I take the meat, I burn it. It goes up into the sky, right? There's a cloud that makes a pillar that connects heaven and Earth, that goes all the way up. And then it says, usually it says, the gods smell the—it's like, it's made spiritual now. It's not a physical anymore. It's become air. So now it's smelled by the god, and the god sends down their blessing. A modern person thinks that's the silliest, most superstitious, ridiculous thing ever, but they do it all the time. They just don't realize that they're doing it, but they do it all the time. And the ritualized version of it, it's the pattern. It sets up the pattern for the rest of your life.
- 6.62** And now, even as a secular person that doesn't believe in any of this, you can understand it because you're saying, "This is an important moment," right? It's a sacred moment. I take my time, I prepare myself. I get this animal. I offer it up to the purpose of what I'm doing. And what it does, it sets the pattern for the rest of my life and the rest of my behavior. That's what ritual does. Ritual sets the pattern. So take a simple

example. You can understand it if you teach your child to shake someone's hand. What are you doing? I mean, isn't it ridiculous? "OK, touch this person's hand, grab their hand, and then move it up and down like this." So this is what you're taught to do. Like, really? That's how, that's how, that's how relationships work. It's ridiculous, right? Of course it's not ridiculous. It's not ridiculous at all.

- 6.63** You say, "This is how you shake someone's hand. Make sure you have a nice grip. Make them know that you're there. Look them in the eye. Don't look away when you're shaking someone's hand. Don't come right up to their face. Don't go like this. Stand straight. Put your hand out. Shake the person's hand. Learn to shake someone's hand." What does it do? It creates a pattern. Creates a pattern of behavior. You know how far to stand from someone. You know how to engage with them. You know what it means to honor and respect someone.
- 6.64** So then that pattern will fall back down into your other behavior. So when you're teaching someone to shake someone's hand, you're not just teaching them to shake a hand. You're teaching them what's a normal pattern of engagement with a human being. And if you do it every time you meet someone, then that will trickle down into the rest of the way that you engage with them, necessarily. OK? So if you think about sacrifice that way, even as a secular person, you should kind of understand it. It's like, we come together, we offer our attention, our purpose, our food, up towards the reason, and then a blessing comes down—a name, a structure, a pattern—comes down from heaven.
- 6.65** OK, now, what happens in the, let's say, in the, in the West or in the, in the Christian tradition is that, at some point, the problem is that, what should you offer your sacrifice to? Right? How do you do it? What is the god that you should follow? And so it's like, do I offer it to the god of war, to the god of, you know, this or that or this or that? And then ultimately, these goods stack up into the highest. So offer to the highest god. OK.
- 6.66** And then what the people would do at a sacrifice, they would eat the meat. The sacrifice—most of the sacrifices were also a meal at the same time. So you come together, the bunch of people, you offer the food up, and then you sit together and you eat, and you're eating the food that was offered. And therefore—same thing as when you're sitting together as a family—you're making body together in the name of that god, in the name of that reason why you're offering the food. OK? Does that make sense? Hopefully it makes sense. And it's like, I know I'm stretching people to the limit, trying to get them to explain animal sacrifices, but to help you understand how these patterns kind of stack up with each other.
- 6.67** And so now it's a—in the Christian tradition, you'll have a version of that which is different, but it's still, let's say, very similar. And it's, it's a little different. It's a little different because it kind of goes both ways, right? So we come to the church. You make bread, right? And then you offer up the bread. Someone had to make the bread. You offer up the bread. And now the bread is blessed, and the wine is blessed, and then it

comes back down, and then is given to the people. And then that becomes communion. It becomes the manner in which we bind together because we partake of the same body. We partake of the same food.

6.68 But in this case, right, the blessing and the food come together. Like, we partake of the same name. We partake of the same—we are Christians, we're little Christs. We all gather into that name. Then that comes down, and it becomes the binding agent for the church. So we come together, eat the same food, and then we go back into our world, and we remember communion, or remember God is the best way to understand it. So that's the connection between this and that. It's memory, the best way to understand it.

6.69 So when I talk about how something is positional, that's what I mean. It's like, you can be up here or you can be down here. What's important in terms of the reason is memory. Let me show you an image. This image again, right image. OK? So you've got these monks that are coming up towards the purpose. And on the ladder, you'll notice some of the monks fall from very, very high up, and then some fall from lower down. You could have them fall from anywhere on the ladder. And no matter where you are on the ladder, you can be looking up towards the center, towards the top of the mount, towards the reason.

6.70 And so that's actually an interesting way to understand how that works. So you—let's go back to the communion thing. You go to communion, you get the thing that binds you together, and then you go back out into the world. But if you remember that connection, then whatever you do will be aligned with what it is that you partook of, whatever it is you're doing. But if you forget, then you start to fragment and break apart. So you can go very far away from identity and still remember where you're from or what it is that's binding you. And it's going to be, it's going to be OK. Or you can be very, very far and then suddenly remember. And all of a sudden, if you remember, then that connection happens.

6.71 There's an interesting image of that in the story of Jonah. So Jonah —God tells Jonah what to do, says, "Do this." That's the pattern, right? "This is what you have to do. This is the goal. This is the thing you have to follow." Comes from heaven. And Jonah says, "No, I don't want to do what you want me to do." God says, "Go to the city and tell them it's going to be destroyed." Jonah doesn't want to do that. He's like, "I don't want to do that." So what he does, he goes in the opposite direction, and he moves out onto the waters. He goes down the mountain. Best way to understand it. So God tells him to do something. I don't know. It's not so much on the thing. God tells him to go somewhere, and he says no. So he's moving away, and he's moving down, down, down.

6.72 What's at the bottom of the world, at the end of the mountain? Always water. That's the lowest thing in the world. That's why chaos is often represented as an ocean or something like that. Because the lowest part of reality is always water. Salt water is even better because you can't drink it. It's death, really. You can't drink it. Has nothing

to do with it. It's just chaos at the bottom. So Jonah goes away from that, and he finds himself on the sea with strangers. And then he gets, right, he gets eaten by a monster. This monster grabs him, pulls him all the way down to the bottom of the world. OK? He's in the fish at the bottom of the world. And then he is, for all intents and purposes, he's dead. He died. He's there for 3 days.

6.73 And then it says, "Jonah remembers the Lord." Jonah remembers God, but he's at the very, very bottom of the world. He's in death. But remembering—that's why even the word "remember", that's what it means. It's like, dismember, re-member. You break apart. You bring together. Remembering is a regathering. And so Jonah remembers. And as soon as he remembers, he's connected to God. He's very, very far away, but he's still connected to that purpose.

6.74 And then he repents, obviously. And he—if you read this prayer, I don't have it with me. If you read his prayer while he's down there, he says, "I remember your holy place." Right? "I remember your temple. I remember that place, that place at the top of the mountain." He remembers the place that the church—he's not the church, but he remembers the top of Mont Saint-Michel. He remembers the place where the glory of God comes down. It's like, "I remember your temple. I remember your place." And then because of that, the fish spits him out, and then he ends up going and doing what God asked him to do.

6.75 That's how this thing works. So think about the handshaking, or think about the meal. It's like that. So when you have a family meal together, you are dancing with your family, and you're ritually participating in the union that your family has. You're training, right? You're setting the pattern. So that's why it's actually, like, if we talked about participation, we talked about how what we can do—that's a really simple, very easy thing we can do, right, is to just have family meals. It's so hard in the modern world, but that's a great way to start.

6.76 So you train the model how to function. It's a microcosm of your whole family. That's where, like, the problems of your family, they'll appear there. It's better that they appear there. It's actually, it's actually good. So if there's some little disease in your family, if you sit together and you have this ritual, that's where it's going to start to show. You start to see it there. But then what happens is it's a pattern. So you move, right? You eat together, then everybody goes on their own way. And what you hope is that people remember the communion. They remember the family. And then in their individual acts and their individual things, that they will be connected by memory to the identity of the family.

6.77 You want that because, if you don't have that, what happens? Your kids leave their stuff lying around, right? Nobody does the dishes. People always expect the other person to do the thing instead of them. If you don't, if you're not connected to the identity, then you start to act on your own, and you don't act as a member of the body. You don't see the body as being the thing that binds you together. So this idea of how

all of this fits together, you can understand it. It just kind of flows out. And so these rituals of participation can happen at every level.

- 6.78** And it's the same, like, it's also the same with a marriage. There's a reason why we have rituals around marriage or the feast around marriage, because you have to remember your marriage. You have to remember the ritual. You come together, you gather all these people. It's one of the —like, this is, like, one of the secret reasons why, when you get married, you have a bunch of people there, is because it's so that, that moment when you're tempted or that moment when you're fighting and it's going to start to break—all those people saw you make that engagement. All those people participated. They're like this body that you created, that now all of these people will know that what happened, their memory of what happened there, was false or that there was something wrong about that memory.
- 6.79** It's a really good thing. Inviting people to your wedding is really good if you want your couple to stay together. It's not an arbitrary thing, but even the ritualization of it is important because it creates a moment. Secular people, like, a lot of people, they're just like, "You don't need marriage. Piece of paper, right? Who needs that? Like, we love each other. That's all that matters." But no, that's not how it works. You have to create these points. You have to create—you have to create these. You have to create a point where it happens. Like, this is the place, instead of just space. You have to raise a pillar. You have to make it a marker.
- 6.80** Right? That's why we celebrate birthdays. That's why we celebrate, we celebrate things because we need to mark things. And so a wedding is a great way to do that. So you come together, you stand in front of everybody, and then you make a promise, and then you pledge your allegiance, and you'll engage in some kind of ritual to manifest it. There's all kinds of different traditions. You'll drink from the same cup, you'll light a candle, like whatever, like two candles, like there's all kinds of things that people do. There are different traditions. Like in the Orthodox church, they'll put crowns and they'll have the crowns, like, tied together. So you have these two crowns tied together. You have different, different traditions.
- 6.81** But it's important to do that, so that will act as an anchor. It will act as an anchor for your life. It's not, like I said, it's not arbitrary—in the same way that any of these ritual communions act as anchors. And if you don't have them, then it starts to shatter. A good way to say it is that, if you never eat together as a family, you'll stop being a family. Just going to happen, right? If you never meet and eat with your friends, you're going to stop being friends at some point. It's just going to happen on its own. You need to embody and create. You need to create this—places like here, now, this, right now. This is the point of attention because that's how memory works.
- 6.82** Memory—remember, like, the world is millions and millions and millions of details? And so memory needs these. Memory needs these in order for it to work. And the punctuated cycle of a day, of a life—this punctuated cycle is to make sure that you

don't just wash away in time. Sadly, some people fall into that. Like they don't have anything to celebrate. They don't mark their—they don't have days that they work and days that they rest. They just kind of go, and everything becomes, like, this equal. And there's no punctuation. And then they, then they wake up, you know, at 50. They're like, "What happened?" Right? It's like, where, "How did I get here? There's no, there's no quality to my life." But quality has—there's a way in which quality happens, and it has to do with creating points, right?

6.83 So everybody knows that intuitively, right? That's why you, that's why you organize events with your friends. That's why you go on vacation. That's why you have special meals. All this stuff is something that you do. But I just want you to understand that that's the basis for—it's the basis for why you also go to church, why there's religious rituals. And in some ways, the religious rituals are the ones that hold most reality together. And everything kind of stacks into that, all the way down to, you know, sitting with your friend and having a drink, right? And engaging in that little ritual.

6.84 And so, hopefully this was helpful to you. Like, I hope that this helps you kind of see how awash, especially now, like, awash in the kind of the chaos of the world. And also looking towards these kind of structures of control that we're seeing, we often feel a little hopeless, that it's as if the real world is slipping away from us, right? It's either idiosyncrasy, complete idiosyncrasy and fragmentation, or it's falling into the machine. But if we can grasp this way of seeing, like, I hope—grasp that how this fractal structure and how it is in some ways very natural—it's the way a tree grows, it's the way that cells become bodies. Like, it's just the way that multiplicity and unity come together, that it can give us a little bit of a, little bit of a track to follow in order to reengage with meaning and to re-embodiment meaning in our lives.

6.85 And it's not that hard. It's hard because it's become almost countercultural, but it's not that hard because that is the way the world works. It's not that hard to live with this cycle of the sun, because that's how the world works. It's not that, it's not—it's natural in some ways. But we do, sadly, have to kind of break our idols or break a few idols, break a few tyrannies around us, in order to be able to reengage. But it is very much possible. And so I hope that this will give you some energy, some fuel, and some hope that we can do that. So, thanks, everybody, for your time.